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SUMMIT CONCLUDES: INITIATIVES INCLUDE EARLY WARNING SYSTEM ON INFECTIOUS DISEASES, SUPPLY CHAIN FRAMEWORK

Modi flags 'weaponisation' of tech; Xi announces open-source AI for BRICS



Prime Minister Narendra Modi addresses a session on the second day of the BRICS Summit in New Delhi, Sunday. On the right are Chinese President Xi Jinping, South African President Cyril Ramaphosa and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian; on the left are Russian President Vladimir Putin, Egypt's President Abdel Fattah El-Sisi, Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto and Kazakhstan President Kassym-Jomart Tokayev. MEA

Global South should jointly advance better governance structure, says Putin

Shubhajt Roy & Divya A
New Delhi, September 13

ON A day when Prime Minister Narendra Modi warned that "the weaponisation of technology and critical minerals" could hinder progress and underlined the need for "inclusivity", Chinese President Xi Jinping on Sunday announced that Beijing would lead the creation of an open-source AI ecosystem for BRICS member nations.

Modi's remarks are seen as an oblique reference to Beijing's control over the critical mineral supply chain and the US-China leverage battle over access to technology. He was speaking at the concluding session of the two-day BRICS Summit, with Xi, Russian President Vladimir Putin and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, among other leaders, in attendance.

Xi, who spoke after Modi, made the announcement as part of a five-point initiative to boost cooperation in technology, manufacturing and trade, even as he called on the bloc to focus on building a large integrated market comprising emerging economies. This is seen as an effort to position Beijing as a central technology partner for BRICS amid its grow-

Business as Usual

By EP UNNY



ing AI competition with the US.

In a statement, the Chinese Foreign Ministry said Xi called upon BRICS leaders to work towards writing a "new chapter of strength through unity for the Global South", and asserted that the logic that "might makes right" should have been discarded long ago.

Putin, in his address, urged the Global South countries to "jointly advance better (global) governance structure and tackle both traditional and non-traditional security threats."

Addressing the BRICS leaders' outreach summit, attended by the groupings' »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Russian President Vladimir Putin and Chinese President Xi Jinping depart from New Delhi, Sunday. MEA



EXPRESS special

What led to Iran-UAE consensus: Ceasefire window, 100-hour talks, back-and-forth at top level, nudge from China and Russia

The Indian Express pieces together how BRICS talks moved on the inside track



India's BRICS Sherpa Sudhakar Dalela, Sous Sherpa Shambhu Lingappa Hakki, Joint Secretaries Rajiv Bodwade and Dr Basir Ahmad, and Director Mini Devi Kumam worked closely with the teams of other BRICS member countries regularly

Shubhajt Roy
New Delhi, September 13

A NARROW ceasefire window, talks at the highest level, a nudge from Beijing and Moscow, support from Egypt and Brazil, and nearly 100 hours of down-to-

the-wire negotiations by Indian diplomats — with experience ranging from Geneva and Washington to Beijing and the WTO — fell into place to produce the fraught consensus on the war in West Asia in the BRICS joint declaration Saturday.

Speaking to officials involved, *The Indian Express* has pieced together this journey, which began 17 days before the US and Israel attacked Iran and killed its Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei.

It was at the first BRICS

Sherpas meeting, held in New Delhi from February 9 to 11, that priorities under India's chairship were outlined. Once war broke out on February 28, the rulebook went for a toss.

At the second Sherpas' »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

IRAN, GULF COUNCIL TO DISCUSS HORMUZ TODAY

Agreed to put the past behind, look to future: Pezeshkian on Iran-UAE meet

Shubhajt Roy
New Delhi, September 13

A DAY after meeting Abu Dhabi Crown Prince Sheikh Khaled bin Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit here, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian on Sunday said they had "agreed to put the past behind... and look to the future".

This is a rare moment from Delhi, where Iranian and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) leaders met for the first time since the West Asia war began. Following hectic negotiations,



Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian departs from New Delhi, Sunday. MEA

the two sides had agreed to the BRICS joint declaration adopted on Saturday, which acknowledged the sensibilities of both sides.

"We had a good conversation with the Crown Prince of Abu Dhabi, and agreed to put the past behind us and look to the future," Pezeshkian said at the conclusion of his visit to India, according to a statement by the Iranian Embassy in India.

"We also had discussions with the Presidents of Russia and China, which were mostly »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



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AT BRICS, MORE OPTIONS, A WIN FOR DIPLOMACY

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PM DISCUSSES TRADE, DEFENCE WITH EGYPT, SOUTH AFRICA AND INDONESIA LEADERS

GUTERRES BACKS DEMAND FOR UNSC EXPANSION



Union Home Minister Amit Shah with Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnis and Deputy CM Eknath Shinde in Mumbai, Sunday. AKASH PATIL

Uniform Civil Code in all 21 NDA states before 2029: Shah

Express News Service
Mumbai, September 13

THE UNIFORM Civil Code will be implemented across all NDA-ruled states before the 2029 Lok Sabha elections, Union Home Minister Amit Shah said on Sunday.

Speaking to reporters in Mumbai, Shah said, "Some states have introduced UCC. It is our resolve to enforce UCC in all 21 BJP-led NDA-ruled states before 2029 Lok Sabha polls."

Responding to other questions, Shah said the "Government is discussing with its alliance partners and various groups" on the implementation of the National Register of Citizens (NRC) in Manipur.

Listing the Government's "major reforms", he said, "Our Government abolished Triple Talaq, which gave equal rights to Muslim women. We will nab and deport illegal Bangladeshis. This much is for sure."

firing a bullet. Kashmir is an integral part of India."

Shah said, "In the last 12 years, the BJP-led NDA government has pushed major reforms on many fronts, including social, economic and criminal justice. The Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) has been effectively enforced. The rate of conviction recorded in one year is 30 per cent."

He said, "We have ruthlessly tackled Naxalism and adopted a zero-tolerance policy on terrorism... Whether it was the surgical strikes or Operation Sindoor, it showed the Government's grit and determination to fight enemies without compromise."

Speaking about the drive against illegal immigrants, Shah said, "All I can say is we will identify each and every individual who has illegally sneaked inside. We will nab and deport illegal Bangladeshis. This much is for sure."

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Pushing UCC, state by state

Amit Shah's announcement underlines the BJP's shift from a national push for UCC to a state-led approach — a line the Sangh Parivar expressed in 2022-23 — with Uttarakhand's code, in force since last year, as the template.

Gujarat, Assam and MP have followed with similar legislation; MP's Bill is awaiting assent. All four state laws ban polygamy, require marriage registration, standardise divorce and in-

heritance rules, grant women equal inheritance rights, and mandate registration of live-in

relationships. Uttarakhand allows deregistration and recognises children from live-in relationships while Assam penalises non-registration. Responding to RSS concerns, all four laws exclude STs, with Uttarakhand and Assam adding protections for specific tribal customs.

E.

Manipur flares up again: 2 women among 4 killed

Jimmy Leivon
Imphal, September 13

FOUR PEOPLE, including two women, were killed in two separate attacks on remote Kuki settlements in Manipur's Tamenglong district on Sunday.

One of the two deceased women was pregnant, according to a Kuki group.

The first incident took place in Tollen village where a woman and her husband were killed and their son severely injured in an attack by unidentified armed miscreants at 4am.

The deceased were identified as Lhingjangai Singnit and

Seineh Singnit. Their son is undergoing treatment at a Jiribam hospital.

Around 3pm, in Longpi village, a man and a woman were killed in an alleged attack by armed persons when they were returning home with essential commodities.

The deceased have been identified as Julie Singson and Thangvel (Roel) Gangte. A woman accompanying them is feared missing.

In a statement, Western Village Volunteers (WVV), a self-defence Kuki group, said that following the killings, the attackers »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Happening today

• DELHI HC will pass its order on whether it has the jurisdiction to entertain a plea by Vimal Elai-chi makers, seeking to quash notices issued by the Maharashtra FDA to Shah Rukh Khan, Ajay Devgn and Tiger Shroff.

• NATIONAL LAW SCHOLARS PROGRAMME IDENTIFIES PROMISING STUDENTS AND PREPARES THEM FOR CLAT

Navodaya to law college: How a programme is powering rural dreams

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, September 13

ON THE evenings when there were power cuts in Hapur's Athsaini village in Uttar Pradesh, Anshita Rani's father would come home to find her sitting in the dark with a book she couldn't read, so he bought her a rechargeable lamp.

At 23 and in the final year of the five-year law course at National Law University, Jodhpur, Anshita still has that lamp. It's old now and considerably weakened, but it still holds a special place for her. "It barely works now, but we still have it," she says.

For Anshita, the lamp was a reminder of her journey, made possible not only by hard work but by an opportunity. She is part of a larger effort to bring students from places that rarely produce lawyers into the country's most competitive law schools through the National Law Scholars Programme (NLSP), an initiative that identifies promising students at Navodaya schools, prepares them for CLAT and supports them through law school. With CLAT registrations underway, students across the country are preparing for their law school entrance examinations — includ-

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anchor



AMONG THE SELECTED: Anshita Rani from UP, Vaishnavi RK from Kerala, Vedant Deshmukh from Maharashtra, A Taruna from Karnataka

ing those at NLSP.

Started in 2019 as a collaboration between Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti and its alumnus Anoop Maurya, the NLSP is a fully funded two-year residential programme. For students like Anshita, it presents an opportunity they never had before.



Anshita's family was poor and large — a joint family of 22 people living under one roof. Means were few, the house was always crowded, and finding a quiet corner to study was often a challenge. Anshita had never given law serious consideration.

That is, until Anoop Mau-



rya's NLSP visited her school and introduced the residential programme.

"I had always wanted to do something where people would listen to what I had to say," she says. "When Anoop sir spoke about people from backgrounds like ours becoming



leaders and shaping policy, it resonated with me."

In 2022, she successfully cracked CLAT and joined JLU. This phase has been challenging to adjust to — the feeling of being left behind by classmates with stronger English and wider networks is constant and

worrying. But Anshita knows these are just hiccups.

"When I met people from across the country — people who are far more confident, articulate and worldly, I realised how small my world had been," she says. "There were so many things that I had never known or heard of."

What is NLSP

Every year, the NLSP conducts outreach sessions across the Navodaya network, reaching roughly 10,000 students, mostly from rural backgrounds. Tests across the 600+ JNV schools comprise two written exams and an »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

IDEA EXCHANGE
"You cannot say that data centres should not be there. It creates jobs, but regulations will be put in place"
ASHWINI BHIDE
BMC COMMISSIONER
PAGE 16

Adult star’s stay at Rourkela circuit house creates a flutter, police begin probe

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, September 13

INAUGURATED LESS than a year ago, the circuit house in Odisha's Rourkela has been finding itself at the centre of some controversy or the other.

Almost a month after the police arrested seven persons and seized arms from the premises, an old video of an “adult” film star, claiming to have received special treatment at the state-run facility, has sparked a fresh controversy, prompting the police to launch an inquiry.

Police sources said at least three persons, including the son of a retired SP-rank officer, were questioned by the investigating officers in connection with arrangement of accommodation for the actor on December 1 last year, during her visit to the city. The three persons were allowed to go after questioning.

“The investigation is on. We are probing under what circumstances the booking was done, who recommended it, and whether due process was followed,” said a police officer.

In the almost five-minute video, the actor, who has more than 300,000 Instagram followers, could be seen narrating her journey from the Jharsuguda airport to the Rourkela Circuit House.

“The owner/CEO of the company is coming himself to receive me in his Audi,” she is heard saying in Hindi at the airport, without specifying who she was referring to.

The probe has also revealed that a local travel operator had rented out a luxury vehicle on the demand of a senior official of a private firm in Rourkela, in which the actor travelled. Though the actor claimed in the video that she had come to Rourkela for shooting, which she claimed was the “biggest project of my life”, police sources said they are verifying such claims.

Pointing at the circuit house, the actor is heard saying, “As you can see, I am going to stay at the circuit house. I used to be in a government job but never received such a treatment. Only

top officers get to stay here... So, the people on whose invitation I am here are no small fry.” She further said, “I have a meeting with the SP and his son. I have come here for a project. I won't reveal further...”

Rourkela Superintendent of Police (SP) Nitesh Wadhvani didn't respond to calls and messages for a comment on the issue.

Senior government officers, ministers, MLAs, accredited journalists and other dignitaries are entitled to stay in the circuit house following approval from authorities concerned.

The circuit house came under scanner last month after the Rourkela Police raided the premises and arrested seven persons with arms. Youth BJP leader Prakash Paswan, 35, who was a representative of Union tribal affairs minister Jual Oram, was also arrested from Bihar for allegedly sheltering armed criminals in the government-run facility. He was suspended from the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in view of the incident.

The newly-built circuit house was inaugurated in November last year by Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi.

Police sources said that they have sought a detailed report from the Panposh sub-collector's office regarding protocol for booking of accommodation, details of last few months, people who were hosted, and other relevant information for further probe.

When contacted, Panposh sub-collector Chandra Kanta Mallick said he has no information about the stay of any actor or film star in the circuit house.

DIG, western range, Rourkela, Brijesh Rai told *The Indian Express*. “We have interrogated some people in connection with the incident. The investigation is on and we are trying to get the details like under what circumstances she got accommodation in the circuit house and whether due process was followed for booking. We are trying to get those details first.” Rai said the police haven't registered any case in this regard yet.

statement, “I express my strongest and unequivocal condemnation of the barbaric and cold-blooded killing of innocent civilians, including women and children, in two separate incidents perpetrated today by armed civilians.”

She said, “These merciless acts of violence against unarmed and innocent civilians are not only inhuman and reprehensible, but also constitute a grave assault on the sanctity of human life, peace, and the very principles of civilised society.”

The Henglep MLA said in his statement, “The loss of innocent lives is a grave tragedy and a deeply disturbing reminder of the persistent insecurity faced by our people. Such violence against unarmed civilians is wholly unacceptable and must not be allowed to continue.”

Kuki Civil Society Organisations condemned the attacks and called for an impartial investigation into the incident.

The Kaimai Naga Village Authority also condemned the attacks, describing the perpetrators as an unidentified group and expressing concern that the incident could create suspicion and division among communities living in the region. The authority urged all communities to exercise restraint, and community leaders and CSOs to reaffirm peace and understanding.

WITH PTI INPUTS

The Saikul legislators said in a

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Modi flags ‘weaponisation’ of tech

full member countries as well as its partner countries, Modi said the trust of Global South countries in BRICS has grown because their voices are heard and their experiences are respected.

He said that with rising global tensions impacting lives, the emphasis is on enhancing resilience within the bloc. In this context, he announced a slew of initiatives -- BRICS Integrated Early Warning System for prevention of and response to infectious diseases, BRICS Logistics Supply Chain Cooperation Framework, BRICS Incubator Network, Startup Innovation Fund, BRICS MSME Cooperation Portal, Digital Centre of Excellence for Smart Grids and Energy Storage, Urban Mobility Hub, and Centres of Excellence for Agro-Ecology and Regenerative Agriculture.

"The BRICS Network on Digital Agriculture will create new opportunities for farmers. Through this initiative, AI, geospatial technology, and Digital Public Infrastructure will be connected to the real needs of farmers. The weaponisation of technology and critical minerals can hinder our shared progress. Therefore, we have emphasised inclusivity in the adoption of technology," he said.

"I can say from personal experience that the trust of Global South nations in BRICS has grown, because within BRICS, their voices are heard. Their experiences are respected. And solutions are created with them, not merely for them," he said.

Framing the global situation, he said: "Tensions across the

world are constantly rising, having a significant negative and far-reaching impact on the lives of ordinary people... Pandemics, climate disasters, and supply-chain disruptions have demonstrated that in today's interconnected world, no crisis remains confined to a single region. That is why we have placed special emphasis on enhancing resilience within the BRICS group. Identifying challenges in time, preparing for them, and taking immediate action are equally essential," he said.

"With this mindset, a consensus has been reached on a BRICS Integrated Early Warning System for the prevention of and response to infectious diseases. Guidelines for Early Warning Data Integration regarding disaster management have been formulated. The BRICS Logistics Supply Chain Cooperation Framework will help make our supply chains more reliable and resilient," he said.

"Today, this hall brings together diverse continents, cultures and developmental journeys. This stands as a testament to the growing strength, appeal, and unprecedented trust associated with BRICS... The strength of BRICS lies in our diversity and cooperation," he said.

"Under India's chairmanship, we have focused all our efforts on four pillars: Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability. I am pleased that, with your cooperation and support, we have been able to transform our shared vision into a win-win collaboration," Modi said.

"By advancing along these

four pillars, we have endeavored to foster inclusive global growth through BRICS. This is because we believe that the benefits of solutions developed within BRICS should not be limited to the bloc alone; they should be made adaptable and accessible to meet the needs of the Global South," he said.

Under the pillar of innovation, he said the BRICS Incubator Network would connect start-ups and incubators. "We have proposed a BRICS Startup Innovation Fund to promote innovative and scalable solutions," Modi said.

Underlining that India has advanced the spirit of friendship, partnership, and cooperation through the BRICS platform, Modi said, "We have endeavored to ensure that BRICS cooperation is not limited to governments alone; we want our entrepreneurs, farmers, researchers, women, youth, and ordinary citizens to become active participants as well."

Xi's 5-point plan

Elaborating on the open-source AI proposal, Xi, in his address, said: "China will be a pioneer in establishing a BRICS AI open-source community, support cooperation in developing and applying large language models, hold specialised AI seminars and training courses, and build an open ecosystem for AI."

China has partnered with around 30 countries to establish the World AI Cooperation Organisation. Beijing is focusing on establishing a cost-effective international AI ecosystem based on open models, unlike major

Sherpa, but Tehran wanted the matter raised at the leaders' level. Pezeshkian's team said he would revert after consulting the top leadership, particularly the IRGC and Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei, who have the final word on foreign and strategic policy in wartime.

Within days, Tehran responded it was willing to go the extra mile, since it should not be blamed for a war started by the Americans. This was the first breakthrough, sources said.

That gave momentum to talks with the UAE, which had been less enthusiastic. Sherpas worked overtime in the final days: sentences and paragraphs were projected on a screen in Delhi as they argued over formulations. Changes were made, suggestions struck down or accepted, and any sentence lacking consensus was flagged in square brackets — removed as agreement was reached. Central to the consensus was that neither the US nor Iran could be named.

China and Russia stepped in as well in the final countdown, with Brazil and Egypt playing a supporting role with both sides. "The Iranians had come around, but the Chinese and Russians leaned on the UAE to sign off on the language," a diplomat said.

Hanging over the talks was the possibility of no joint declaration at all. "That would have

The meeting came days before scheduled talks between Iran and members of the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) in Oman on September 14 to discuss an agreement on transit through the Strait of Hormuz.

In the joint declaration on Saturday, the BRICS leaders expressed "deep concern over the continued escalation of tensions

US developers such as OpenAI and Anthropic, which rely on closed frameworks.

The five-point initiative, Xi said, is aimed at boosting cooperation in manufacturing, trade and technology across member states. The initiative focuses on establishing an inclusive artificial intelligence framework, facilitating trade and investment, deepening digital industry ties, advancing "intelligent manufacturing," and launching a joint science and technology development initiative.

In his remarks, Xi said that BRICS should leverage its close ties with emerging markets and the Global South to safeguard supply chains and build a large integrated market.

The Chinese Foreign Ministry statement quoted Xi as saying in his address that "a world without rules is like a crossroads without traffic lights, where chaos and disorder are all but guaranteed. Fairness and justice is a universal aspiration, and international rules must be written by all countries".

"The world is currently undergoing profound changes, a phenomenon unseen in a century, with the Global South rising collectively and becoming a key driving force for multipolarity. At the same time, the international situation is complex and volatile, with various risks and challenges emerging one after another. To stabilise and improve the world, the BRICS countries must seize the initiative in history, unite with the vast majority of the Global South countries, play a positive, stabilising, and benevolent role in international affairs, and enhance the common well-being of humanity," he said, according to the statement.

been portrayed by Western countries as a failure. So it was in the interest of both UAE and Iran, and China and Russia helped in convincing them," the diplomat said.

All of this led to Paragraph 28: "We express deep concern over the continued escalation of tensions in Middle East/West Asia and, recalling our respective national positions, call for exercising maximum restraint, as well as avoiding actions that could further aggravate the situation."

The declaration, accepted by both the UAE and Iran, acknowledged the sensitivities of each side by flagging territorial sovereignty and the need to protect civilian lives and infrastructure — a nod to the UAE, which has faced Iranian strikes on its cities, with Tehran striking it a proxy of the United States.

"We urge to ensure the protection of civilians and civilian infrastructure in accordance with the purposes and principles of the Charter of the United Nations in their entirety and interconnectedness, including respect for the sovereignty and territorial integrity of the States," the declaration said. "We encourage increasing efforts, through dialogue and diplomacy, towards a long-term understanding that will contribute to lasting peace, security and stability in the region. We stress the need to work together

The meeting came days before scheduled talks between Iran and members of the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) in Oman on September 14 to discuss an agreement on transit through the Strait of Hormuz.

In the joint declaration on Saturday, the BRICS leaders expressed "deep concern over the continued escalation of tensions

"Xi Jinping emphasised that the Global South should jointly uphold the rule of international law, safeguard the basic norms of international relations such as sovereign equality, non-interference in internal affairs, and peaceful settlement of disputes, and ensure the equal application of international law and rules without double standards... accelerate the formation of a broadly consensus-based global artificial intelligence governance framework, allowing emerging technologies to illuminate the path to common prosperity," the statement said.

Also addressing the session, Putin said: "As global challenges keep surfacing, we should adopt a holistic approach to address both the symptoms and root causes. Global South countries should jointly advance better (global) governance structure and tackle both traditional and non-traditional security threats."

"Many around the world find our core values and ideals appealing, including our commitment to charting an independent course and a desire to resolve problems collectively, guided by international law and the key provisions of the UN Charter," he said.

South Africa President Cyril Ramaphosa, Egypt President Abdel Fattah el-Sisi, Indonesia President Prabowo Subianto, Ethiopia Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed, foreign ministers from Brazil and Saudi Arabia, leaders or representatives of BRICS partner countries and guest countries, and heads of international organisations like UN Secretary-General António Guterres were among those who attended the outreach summit on Sunday.

Asked about the anti-drug Nasha Mukht Abhiyan, the Home Minister said, "I will visit each and every state to ensure the campaign percolates to the grassroots. We have to get rid of this menace. I am confident India will succeed in eliminating this drug menace."

Shah also announced a month-long mass outreach campaign, Seva Sankalp Abhiyan, to be held from September 17, which is the birthday of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, to October 17 to convey the "message of good governance". The event will also mark Modi's "25 years of public service as Gujarat CM and PM," he said.

"We will take this campaign to every district, Lok Sabha and Assembly constituencies, and polling booths at the grassroots," Shah said.

Earlier, Shah inaugurated a specially curated exhibition of manuscripts, "Shri Ganesh Dnyanarati", at the Asiatic Society of Mumbai. Addressing the gathering, Shah said, "Knowledge cannot become a prisoner to any ideology. If you try to bind it in any form, you distort its very purpose. Knowledge should be unbound."

Speaking at the Gems & Jewellery Awards at BKC, Shah said, "India should lead the lab-grown diamond sector in the world... Knowing the potential of the sector, the Government is planning to invest Rs 50,000 crore in the gems and jewellery industry, which is rooted in tradition and culture." A new gem and jewellery bourse is being built in Jaipur, he said.

Shah on UCC

Secretary (MER & G20) — a career diplomat who joined the Foreign Service in 2008 and served as Consul General in Guangzhou (2021-25), besides postings in Beijing and Washington. Fluent in Mandarin, he also runs a YouTube channel with over 60 videos of him performing various ragas.

Dr Basir Ahmed, Joint Secretary, MER division — a 2009-batch IFS officer and a doctor by training, who was Deputy Chief of Mission in Indonesia and served at India's Permanent Mission in Geneva.

Rajiv Bodwade, Joint Secretary, MER division — a 2009-batch IFS officer who was Deputy Chief of Mission in Israel during the October 7 attacks and has served as Deputy Chief of Protocol in Delhi.

Mini Devi Kumam, Director, MER division — a 2011-batch IFS officer who has served in Vietnam and at India's Permanent Mission in Geneva.

On his YouTube channel, Hakki writes: "A practitioner of Hindustani classical music, I have been drawn towards music, which is a universal language and transcends all barriers. The music I create has its roots in Indian classical music, but has also imbibed certain aspects of Western music." In the end, it was this, transcending barriers with a common language, that struck the right diplomatic chord.

Iran-UAE consensus

meeting, from May 11-13, a diplomat said there had been a "vibe shift," with the "Iranians and Emiratis" unable to "see eye-to-eye." At the Foreign Ministers' meeting days later, on May 14-15, all that could be put on record was a statement noting "differing views among some members" over West Asia, with members expressing their "respective national positions." Nothing more.

Then the Indian team got to work. BRICS Sherpa Sudhakar Dalela, assisted by Sous Sherpa Shambhu Lingappa Hakki, along with Joint Secretaries Rajiv Bodwade and Dr Basir Ahmad and Director Mini Devi Kumam, began reaching out to counterparts in other member countries — drawing on Dalela's background in trade and economic policy, Hakki's stint in China and fluency in Mandarin, Behind them was the wider expertise of officials at the Multilateral Economic Relations (MER) wing of the Ministry of External Affairs.

The 60-day ceasefire between the US and Iran, before it lapsed in August, opened a window of opportunity. Indian officials began reaching out to the UAE and Iran to press the case for a BRICS consensus. Prime

Minister Narendra Modi and UAE ruler Mohamed bin Zayed spoke during Modi's visit to the UAE on May 15; Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian spoke to Modi on June 22, when the consensus issue also came up.

In parallel, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar spoke to his counterparts in Iran and the UAE, while NSA Ajit Doval reached out to his counterparts during the BRICS NSAs meeting on June 22-23.

Indian Ambassador to the UAE Deepak Mittal and his counterpart in Iran, Rudra Gaurav Shresth, were asked to approach their capitals and do the spadework. Unsurprisingly, positions hardened on both sides, with red lines firmly drawn.

Modi's visit to Bishkek for the SCO leaders' summit from August 30 to September 1 offered a chance to meet Pezeshkian. It is learnt he was told that as a new BRICS member — Iran and the UAE joined in 2024 — it would not reflect well if the grouping failed to reach consensus, and that since this would be his first visit to India, he should be part of a "successful" summit.

The groundwork had already been laid by Dalela's team in negotiations with the Iranian

Pezeshkian

brief exchanges. A promising outlook for the expansion of economic cooperation is taking shape," he said.

Pezeshkian's remarks offer the first possible window of opportunity for the two warring

sides to sit down and talk, and move towards de-escalating the tension in the region.

The Crown Prince is the eldest son of UAE President Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan.

How a programme is powering rural dreams

interview. While the written exams test school coursework, the interview checks students' aptitude, potential, background and inclination.

The two-year programme, too, is just as intense, accepting only 30 students each year. Students who qualify move to their campus, currently in Hyderabad, where they study at the local JNV school by day and attend coaching classes in the evening.

Of the 150 scholars selected for the programme in the last seven years, 120 completed the two-year NLSF residential programme and went to law school. Of these, 84 are still pursuing law — 54 at NLUs,

Those who secure admission to law schools continue receiving financial assistance from the programme — including tuition fees that can run into several lakh rupees a year.

For Anoop Maurya, an ac-

tive member of the Bharat Navodaya Abhiyan (BNA) — the public service wing of the Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya (JNV) alumni network — the programme stemmed from his own experience. Born in Uttar Pradesh's Bahraich and educated in the Navodaya system, the 31-year-old said school changed not only his circumstances but also his outlook.

Founder Anoop Maurya believes CLAT has become an "anti-poor exam". "A candidate is expected to work through a 40-page paper in two hours, much of it built around lengthy English-language passages adapted from publications. For many of the students NLSF takes on, that presents a challenge long before the examination hall," Maurya says.

'It gave me a direction'

For many students, NLSF offered not just coaching but a sense of direction. Among

them is Vedant Ravindra Deshmukh. For the 21-year-old from Maharashtra's Wardha, law was never a viable career option: his father often liked to say: "Lawyers can't even afford soap to wash their coats."

It was quite by accident that Vedant took the NLSF entrance test. His school teacher announced a notebook inspection, and Vedant slipped into a classroom to avoid it. That classroom was where the NLSF test was being held.

He topped the exam across Navodaya schools in three states in 2023. What followed was two years of struggle against family pressure and financial constraints that appeared to make CLAT more and more distant. Finally, he joined Rashtrasant Tukadoji Maharaj Nagpur University, formerly known as Nagpur University, also with NLSF's help.

"I also struggled a lot with

confidence, but it was the alumni network that helped me improve," he says. "Being shown direction on all of this changed my outlook."

For some, opposition came in the form of societal norms. One of them is Vaishnavi RK from a lower-middle-class farming family in Palakkad, Kerala. Knowing there would be objections, 17-year-old Vaishnavi told them about taking the NLSF test after she had cleared it.

When she did, her family screamed, her neighbours advised against it, and even her teachers were apprehensive. "It was me against the whole village. Much of the argument eventually centred on safety," she says. "But the programme changed their mindset too."

Life on campus

On its 30-acre campus, life is busy and exciting. Students spend two years integrating

coaching with regular schooling, mentoring and leadership workshops. For most students, coaching begins soon after school and continues until late evening. In between, students are encouraged to organise debates, mock parliaments and discussions on everything from geopolitics to gender studies.

For some students, it was an unfamiliar education. "I froze while speaking in public and had backed out of so many speeches before because I couldn't even say two sentences," says Vaishnavi. "Now, I can speak."

For 17-year-old A. Taruna, campus life couldn't be more different — and further — than the one back home in Ramdurga, a village in Karnataka's Bellary district with just two buses a day. His father, a former lawyer, had given up his practice after an injury. His parents worried that five years of law study was too long when the

family needed someone to earn. But Taruna had made up his mind in Class 8 and needed only a nudge in the right direction. Then came NLSF.

"The people who do understand the system usually have the advantage over those who don't. It's this gap that I want to fill," he says.

But the programme was only the first step, as students like Anshita and Vedant are finding out. Now, there are other concerns — such as seeking internships and jobs. Applications go unanswered, calls are frequently ignored, and worry mounts. "I feel like I'm constantly trying to catch up," she says.

Vedant, meanwhile, has had that chance. Last year, while interning with a law firm, he worked on a matter involving a major airline — something he considers a feather in his cap. When a response came back from a bigger firm, he says he sat looking at the letterhead for a while before he could read the rest of it. "I thought maybe I could work there someday."

CORRECTION & CLARIFICATION

PAGE 6, 13.09.2026

● The caption of a photograph showing Union Ministers travelling on a bus to attend the BRICS dinner wrongly identified Union Minister of State Bhagirath Choudhary as Union Minister of State Arjun Ram Meghwal. The error is regretted.

The photograph above is of Union Ministers Arjun Ram Meghwal and Kiren Rijiju on their way to the dinner hosted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi for the visiting BRICS dignitaries in New Delhi Saturday.



सत्यमेव जयते

दिल्ली सरकार

गणपति बाप्पा मोरया

गणेश चतुर्थी

की
हार्दिक
शुभकामनाएँ



नरेन्द्र मोदी

प्रधानमंत्री

वक्रतुण्ड महाकाय सूर्यकोटि समप्रभ।
निर्विघ्नं कुरु मे देव सर्वकार्येषु सर्वदा॥



रेखा गुप्ता

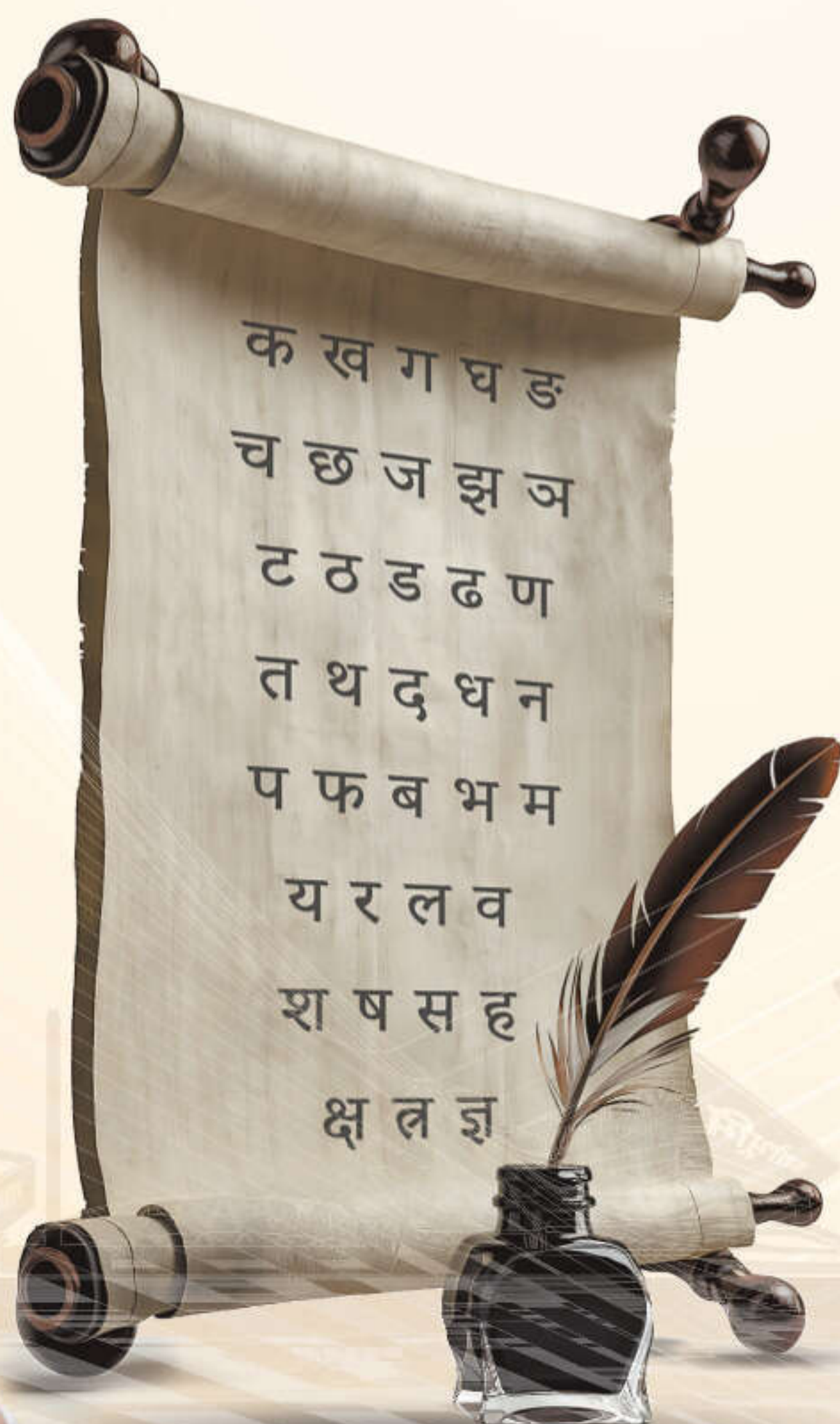
मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

DIP/Shabdarth/Display/086/26-27



सत्यमेव जयते

दिल्ली सरकार



हिन्दी

दिवस पर आप सभी को बहुत-बहुत शुभकामनाएँ



नरेन्द्र मोदी

प्रधानमंत्री

“भाषा की सरलता, सहजता और शालीनता अभिव्यक्ति को सार्थकता प्रदान करती है। हिंदी ने इन पहलुओं को खूबसूरती से समाहित किया है।”

- नरेन्द्र मोदी, प्रधानमंत्री



रेखा गुप्ता

मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

DIP/Shabdarth/Display/087/26-27



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New Delhi



DAYS AFTER SATYA NIKETAN BUILDING COLLAPSE

Fire NOC, building plan: Checklist part of MCD crackdown

Drishti Jain
New Delhi, September 13

IS THE building plan sanctioned? How many occupants live in the building? Is the structure constructed in compliance with the Master Plan of Delhi? Are fire safety guidelines being followed? These are among the questions that are being asked as the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) continues to hold a citywide survey of paying guest (PG) accommodations amid a crackdown on illegal constructions. The survey comes in the wake of the building collapse in Southwest Delhi's Satya Niketan on September 6, which claimed seven lives. More than 1,000 such buildings have been surveyed so far across the Capital.

As the Satya Niketan incident yet again raised questions over the mushrooming of illegal constructions in the city, the civic body, which is responsible for ensuring on-ground checks, on September 7 suspended five of its officials from the South Zone where the PG accommodation that gave way was located. These included the Deputy Commissioner of the area.

The same day, as the Delhi High Court pulled up the civic body, MCD's senior officials instructed the Executive Engineers of all zones to conduct a survey of every PG in their area.

In Satya Niketan, the civic body issued vacation notices for several properties surrounding the collapse site, citing "ruinous/dangerous" conditions. It is dangerous to occupy the building or pass by the structure, the notice warned.

"We have asked the officers on the ground surveying the PGs to inspect every detail of the accommodation, which includes the number of floors, number of occupants, and whether the building plan is sanctioned or not," an officer said.

The Junior engineers — who are the field officers on the ground and are surveying multiple wards — have been asked to check if the building has occupation and structural stabil-



During a sealing drive in Chandni Chowk. AMIT MEHRA

ity certificates, and an no-objection certificate (NOC) from the Delhi Fire Service. Officials are also checking if any previous violations were reported against the structures in the past.

The officer added, "We are also assessing compliance with the Master Plan of Delhi and if conversion charges are paid according to it."

While the survey is still on, the officers said that they had till September 10, surveyed around 1,350 buildings. Of these, three located in the South Zone were found to be visibly dangerous, where 69 people were staying.

Concerns were raised by residents and students regarding lack of checks earlier.

The civic body has separately identified 90 framed structures above 'ground plus four' floors for close monitoring as they may be vulnerable, the highest 62 located in Shahdara South. "The vulnerability of these buildings will be further ascertained," a senior official added.

The survey also identified 39 buildings that are in need of visible minor repairs, housing 664 occupants; and nine buildings in need of visible major repairs, housing 140 people. Of these nine buildings, five are located in Keshavpuram Zone, followed by two each in Najafgarh and South Zone, said officials.

The civic body had also carried out demolition and served sealing notices in various parts of the city, including Chandni Chowk in City S.P Zone; Laxmi Nagar in Shahdara South Zone; Bijwasan in South West Zone; and Nehru Vihar, Gandhi Vihar in the North Zone.

Housing takes the centre stage in DUSU election manifestos

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, September 13

STUDENT HOUSING has emerged as the focal point in the Delhi University Students Union (DUSU) election campaign days after seven people, including five students, were killed in a building collapse in Satya Niketan. The incident yet again raised concerns about the dependence of students on private accommodations amid limited institutional hostel capacity.

The student elections are set to be held on September 18 and the results will be declared the next day.

Key contenders AISA-SFI alliance, Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) and Association of Students for Alternative Politics (ASAP) are placing affordability and safety prominently in their manifestos. On one hand, AISA-SFI has demanded enforcement of the Rent Control Act within a 2-km radius of every college, university assistance and subsidies for verified private accommodation, and at least two hostels in every college.

On the other hand, RSS-backed ABVP has made Awas (housing) the first of its four-pillar manifesto, promising separate girls' hostels in every college, a dedicated Student Housing Cell and helpline, and fire audits of PGs and hostels across the Capital.

The Congress-backed National Students' Union of India (NSUI) is scheduled to release its manifesto on Monday.

AISA-SFI flags 'dark reality'

The AISA-SFI manifesto has termed the collapse "another dark reality" of DU. "This collapse must not be addressed as an accident when it is clear case of negligence," it underlines, adding that the incident exposed "the huge shortage of hostel accommodation and the nexus of PG mafias regulating these spaces around the varsity".

The group said less than 5% of DU students get hostel accommodation, against the University Grants Commission (UGC) norm set for at least 60%.

It has demanded at least two hostels in every college and a mechanism to identify subsidised, standardised and certified private accommodation. It has also called for the Rent Control Act within a 2-km radius of every college and major university zone.

The student elections are set to be held on September 18 and the results will be declared the next day

Meanwhile, the wider agenda includes retaining DU's own entrance examination instead of Common University Entrance Test or CUET, removing mandatory attendance and debarment, and revising the 45% internal assessment component.

ABVP promises new hostels

ABVP's 'Awas' agenda has promised new hostels across DU and its colleges, separate girls' hostels in every college, a 'Student Housing Cell' and a helpline, and sanitation and hygiene standards in hostels.

It has called for the implementation of the PG and Student Accommodation Regulation Act across Delhi-NCR, Rent Regulation Act, and fire and safety audits of PGs and hostels. It has also proposed reviews of college infrastructure for student safety.

Among other focal points — defined as pillars — in its manifesto are participation, safety and outcomes.

ASAP promises 'Hostels for All'

The Aam Aadmi Party's student wing ASAP has made "Hostels for All" one of its four key demands, calling on the Central government to construct hostels for students and saying, "Till hostels are allotted, the government must bear students' PG expenses," it says.

Its infrastructure agenda also calls for "affordable hostels for all" and proposes cutting rents crossing Rs 1 lakh. Its wider affordability demands include rolling back fee hikes and refunding fees already collected, 100% concession on Delhi Metro fares and free travel on DTC and cluster buses for students.

Beyond housing, ASAP has proposed free counselling in every college, a 24x7 student helpline, strengthened Internal Complaints Committees (ICCs), menstrual leave of up to 15 days a semester without attendance penalty, permanent PCR vans outside girls' colleges and gender-neutral washrooms.

NOIDA WORKERS' PROTEST

Censured by HC, Noida DM moves SC against order quashing student NSA case

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 13

THE DISTRICT Magistrate of Gautam Buddha Nagar, Medha Roopam, has approached the Supreme Court challenging the Allahabad High Court order quashing the detention of a Delhi University student under the National Security Act, 1980.

The September 2 order of the High Court pulled up the District Magistrate (DM) over the manner in which she passed the NSA order detaining 25-year-old student Akriti Chaudhary, and directed a payment of Rs 5 lakh from her salary as compensation. The court also observed that unchecked abuse of power by Uttar Pradesh police and officials risk reducing the state to an "Orwellian Dystopia."

Stating that the "casual and cavalier exercise of authority" by the state through the DM had "violated the Constitutional rights" of the petitioner, the court had ordered Rs 5 lakh as compensation to her, and directed that the amount be recovered from the "salary of the District Magistrate Gautam Buddha Nagar, who has passed this order of detention without



DM Medha Roopam

application of mind and from all such other officers who may have been responsible, right down to the SHO."

The High Court said that the conduct of the DM, who passed the detention order, was "worthy of derision" and added that she should have examined how the general law was inadequate against a female student activist with no previous criminal record agitating for the rights of labourers, and that the material on record did not disclose that she had in any way incited violence.

The ruling said the material "reveals that the District Magistrate desired to set an example out of the petitioner and deter others from exercising their right to freedom of speech and

expression in public spaces in support of the labourers".

"The District Magistrate Gautam Buddha Nagar is guilty of violating her oath of allegiance, making this a fit case for the imposition of compensation to the petitioner," it said.

The High Court also elaborated on the relationship between the IAS and IPS with the citizens of Uttar Pradesh "whom they serve" and said it defined the existence of the rule of law or its absence — as the case may be.

"The officers are endowed with immense powers by law and for very good reasons, as they bear the responsibility of improving the lot of the citizens by maintaining that delicate balance of upholding the Constitutional and legal rights, dignity, honour and welfare of the citizens by just and good governance, while ensuring the stability of the State and the unity and integrity of the nation," it noted.

The court highlighted that "with great powers come great responsibility" and an introspection on the part of the bureaucracy to examine to what extent such power is exerted.

"Else, in the words coined by Rudyard Kipling (spoken

publicly by Stanley Baldwin) that 'power without responsibility — the prerogative of the harlot throughout the ages', will ring true whenever the power is exercised by the bureaucracy in a cavalier manner, devoid of human sensitivity resulting in deleterious consequences for the citizen," the ruling said.

The ruling clarified that any detention under the NSA was an exception and not a "substitute to ensure that a person who may receive bail on account of merits of his case" remains detained in custody under a "concocted reasoning" by the state.

Coming down heavily on the District Magistrate, the bench termed the grounds of detention as "repetitive, speculative and only an opinion based without referring to a 'shred of evidence/material' in support of sustaining those opinions."

"Preventing people from gathering in public spaces or agitating their rights on the grounds of assumed breach of peace, would be throwing the baby out of the bath water. If such a view is taken by the state and approved of by the courts, it would lead to a cessation of the collective expression of opinion in public spaces," the rulings said.



Ganesh idols at a shop in New Delhi on Sunday ahead of the Ganesh Chaturthi festival. GAJENDRA YADAV

Festive spirit

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 13

2 fire incidents in Capital: 6 injured after jumping off buildings in panic

ON SUNDAY, a factory-cum-godown in North Delhi and a godown in East Delhi were gutted in fire, officials said. Driven by panic, while six people sustained injuries after jumping off buildings in North Delhi's Swaroop Nagar, around 25 fire tenders had to be deployed in East Delhi's Dallupura where firefighting operations were underway till late in the night.



At the site of the incident in Dallupura on Sunday. GAJENDRA YADAV

No casualty, however, was reported in both the incidents, they said.

At the Swaroop Nagar unit that manufactured judo outfits and boxing gloves, the fire broke out in the morning, said officials. According to the Delhi Fire Services (DFS), there were rexine waste and cotton webbing stored in the building, which comprises a basement, ground floor, first floor and a tin shed on the second floor, and is spread over an area of around 200 square yards.

An official said a call regarding the incident was received around 11 am. Fire tenders were rushed to the spot and the flames were brought under control around 1.50 pm, and subsequently doused.

Five of the injured persons were sent to Babu Jagjivan Ram Hospital, while the sixth one was admitted to a government hospital in Burari. According to officials, all of them jumped from buildings adjacent to the unit where the fire started and are currently out of danger.

The blaze at the godown in Dallupura near Dharamshila Cancer Hospital in East Delhi started around 3.30 pm.

According to DFS officials, a total of around 25 fire tenders were deployed at the site. While no injuries were reported, the fire was declared "under control" only around 9.30 pm, with firefighting and cooling operations underway till late in the night.

Deputy Chief Fire Officer (Fire Prevention Wing) for the Delhi Fire Service, M K Chattopadhyay, said the fire control room received a call about the Dallupura blaze around 3.30 pm. "Initially, four to five fire tenders were sent, but later the fire spread in the entire godown and it was declared under the

'upper category'. It was declared under the 'medium category' around 5.17-5.18 pm. Later, more fire tenders were pressed into service," Chattopadhyay said.

There were electric panels, wooden materials and chemicals at the godown. "When fire officials reached the spot, the godown was engulfed in thick black smoke, making firefighting operations difficult," the officer said.

Meanwhile, one of the fire officials, who fell unconscious after inhaling smoke, was taken to a hospital.

"The godown was located on a large plot in the middle of the congested Dallupura village. As a precautionary measure, residents of neighbouring houses vacated their homes during the fire," an official said.

Officials also said that some workers, who were inside the premises when the fire broke out, had managed to step out safely. The incident in Dallupura also led to a traffic snarl on the Noida Link Road, with people stopping their vehicles to watch and record videos of the massive blaze.

Police said they are yet to ascertain what triggered the fire at both the units.

Teen dies weeks after assault by truck drivers over theft suspicion

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 13

AN 18-YEAR-OLD man died at a Delhi hospital nearly two weeks after he was allegedly beaten by truck drivers who accused him of trying to steal cables and other articles from their vehicles in Bhalswa Dairy area, police said. Two truck drivers have been arrested in connection with the case.

According to officers, Ram Kumar, a resident of Kalandar Colony, was allegedly caught along with four others by the truck drivers around 7 pm on August 29 over suspected theft of articles. Kumar was then allegedly beaten brutally by them.

According to police, Kumar was taken by his family to Burari Hospital on August 30. An MLC (medico-legal case) was prepared, and he was examined for bruises and a laceration on his hand, a black eye and bruising on his leg. He was treated and discharged.

Kumar returned to the Burari Hospital on September 9 for a check-up after complaining of breathlessness. He was referred to BJRM Hospital and subsequently to Rajan Babu TB Hospital, where he died hours later.

Crackdown on illegal liquor trade: 730 arrested, 725 FIRs registered

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 13

THE DELHI government has stepped up its crackdown on the sale and smuggling of illegal liquor, registering 725 FIRs between April and August this year, according to data released by the government on Sunday.

In the last five months, the Excise department has arrested 730 people. It has also seized 197 vehicles allegedly being used to transport illegal liquor and recovered around 2.2 lakh liquor bottles. Notably, during the corresponding period last year, 315 FIRs were registered, 312 people were arrested, 112 vehicles seized and around one lakh bottles of illegal liquor were recovered. Delhi is following a "zero-tolerance policy towards the illegal liquor trade", Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said, adding that the government is also working on an effective excise policy.

The department has also initiated action against violations at licensed liquor establishments. Seven FIRs have been registered in such cases, with action including sealing of bars, and imposition of fines.

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, TUSHAR alias TUSHAR KUMAR AGGARWAL S/O- MINTU KUMAR AGGARWAL R/O- H.NO. 32/264 TRILOK PURI EAST, DELHI-110091, have changed my name to TUSHAR KUMAR AGGARWAL, ALL FUTURE PURPOSES
0040878259-1

I, CHHANDITA ROY CHOUDHURY W/O SH. PARTHA PRATIM BHATTACHARYA R/o 27, POKHET H-33, SECTOR-3, ROHINI, POST OFFICE ROHINI, NCT OF DELHI-110085, That my date of birth is wrongly mentioned in my 10th Class Certificate i.e. 14.12.1968 in place of 14.12.1967
0071060520-1

I, Kaushlya W/o CPL Balwant Rai Bajaj R/o H.No. 704, Gracious Tower, Plot No- GH-12, Sector 56, Gurgaon, Haryana-122001 have changed my name from Kaushlya to Kaushalya Bajaj as per affidavit dated 11.09.2026
0040878261-1

I, Deepak Kumar S/o Ramjee Sharma R/o H No 125-B Third Floor, Jasola, New Friends Colony, PO: New Friends Colony, South East Delhi, Delhi-110025 have changed my name to Deepak Sharma
0071060526-1

I, Abhishek Kumar S/o Narayan Thakur R/o H.No.-123, Block A, Near Mangal Bazar Road, Inder Enclave Phase-2, Kirari Suleman Nagar, Sultanpuri C-Block, Saraswati Vihar, Delhi-110086, I have changed my minor son name Priyanshu Kumar to Priyanshu Thakur aged 13 years
0071060529-1

I, Sankari Deepa Sivakumar W/o Balakrishnan Sivakumar R/o 79 Lodhi Estate KK Birla Lane, New Delhi-110003 have changed my name from Shankari Deepa Sivakumar to Sankari Deepa Sivakumar. Both the name Sankari Deepa Sivakumar and Shankari Deepa Sivakumar belongs to one and same person.
0040877822-1

I, hitherto known as Ritu alias Ritu Mehta, D/O-Gulab Chand, W/O-Rakesh Kumar, R/O-B-1/115, 3RD-Floor, Phase-2, Ashok-Vihar, PO: Ashok-Vihar, District, North-West Delhi, Delhi-110052, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Ritu Mehta.
0040878259-2

I, Rahul Ashra S/o Balram Ashra R/o H-10, 2nd Floor, Old Double Storey, Lajpat Nagar-4, Lajpat Nagar, South Delhi-110024 have changed my name to Raaghav Ashrra
0071060525-1

I, Sanjeev Rattan Kaistha S/o. Sh. Surinder Nath Kaistha R/o. Flat No. 434, Airlines Apartment, 23, Dwarka, New Delhi have changed my name to Sarjeev Rattan Kaistha for all future purposes
0040878205-1

I, Nitin Bhutani S/o Prem Kumar Bhutani R/o C 805 Greenwich Tower, Grand Omaze, Sector-93B, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Noida U.P.-201301, have changed my minor daughter name Gianna to Gianna Bhutani aged 9 years
0071060527-1

I, Simmi alias Simmi Soni D/o Daya Ram Soni, Ex W/O Dheeraj Verma, R/o. D-291 Lalita Park, Gali No.-11, Laxmi Nagar, Shakar Pur Baramand, Delhi-110092, I got divorce from my Ex Husband vide Court Order HMA No. 185/22 dated 10/02/2022 and remarried to Rabindra Kumar Mallick vide Marriage Certificate No. 90730000240738 dated 23/01/2026, have changed my name to Simmi Mallick, have changed my minor daughter's name from Aadhya Verma to Aadhya Mallick (14 years) that name of the father of my minor daughter is Rabindra Kumar Mallick vide Adoption Deed Certificate No.2026/5/III/899 Dated 13/05/2026
0071060574-1

I, Rekha Chaurasia W/O, Mitesh Chourasia R/o Flat No 373, seemant Vihar Kaushambi, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh Pin-201010 have changed my name to Rekha Chourasia .
0040878267-1

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i. Last Date of sale/download /submission of e-Bid Extended up to **21/09/2026 (14:00 Hrs)**
ii. Last date of submission of Hard Copies of tender fee and EMD only up to **21/09/2026 (16:30Hrs).**
iii. Commercial/ Technical Bid Opening Date Extended up to **22/09/2026 (14:00 Hrs)**

S. #	NIT No.	Tender ID	Description of Material	Techno-Commercial Bid-Opening Date (Extended)
1	SE/Proc/07/2026-27	2026_PDD_318459_I	ACSR Conductor of various sizes.	22/09/2026. (14:00hrs)

The complete NIT/Tender Documents/BOQ can be downloaded from the website www.jktenders.gov.in. All other terms and conditions as stipulated in the original NIT shall remain same.

No. SE/PROC/TS/412-17
Dated: 11/09/2026
DIP NO. DIPK-NB-1613-26 DATE: 13.09.2026

Sd/,
Superintending Engineer
Procurement, KPDCL

Life (& death) in a student ghetto



PHOTO: ABHINAV SAHA

Over the last three decades, Satya Niketan has transformed into a dense hub of private accommodations, catering to thousands of students from all over India enrolled in DU's South Campus. They chase a dream. But sometimes, like it happened a week ago, these dreams die suddenly. SOPHIYA MATHEW and SUKRITA BARUAH visited the cramped lanes to get a sense of life.

LOOKING BACK to his days as an undergraduate student at Sri Venkateswara College nearly three decades ago, Ravi Vajala clearly remembers the settlement opposite the college gate. He recalls a couple of shops that sold patties and cheap burgers, which students frequented.

Anshuman Kishore, who went to Sri Venkateswara in the early 1990s, remembers being introduced to "Campa-Doodh" — an odd concoction of milk, Campa Cola and ice — there, sold at a shop with three stools and a rickety table out front, with music played on a cassette player by a *halwai* next door.

In Vajala's memory, the colony was a residential area with a handful of small shops, where families lived in houses that were two or perhaps three storeys tall, lining bumpy, stone-paved lanes that were wide enough for a Maruti to squeeze through but not much else. Vajala is today the principal of Sri Venkateswara College. And the settlement into which he would sometimes wander as a student has transformed into a densely packed hub of private student accommodation — where residents include many students of his college who have come from states across the country to study in Delhi.

Each building in Satya Niketan begins where the next one ends. They are narrow and tall, most are at least four storeys high. Almost every building seems to offer paying guest (PG) accommodation for students who study in the Delhi University's South Campus colleges in the vicinity.

The compact neighbourhood is structured almost entirely around the lives of these students; its microeconomy is driven by the young adults who have made the capital their temporary home.

There are messes that serve Rs-90 meals, shops that offer photocopying services and give computer printouts, reading rooms where students pay to sit with books because their rooms are too small or too crowded, stalls that sell tea, momos, or rolls, and small cafes with more ambitious menus.

Shops and offices of property dealers and brokers are everywhere, promising to find just the right PG for the needs and budget of every student.

A week ago, a five-storey building housing one such PG came crashing down, crushing seven people under bricks and concrete, including five students of nearby colleges.

A crackdown by civic authorities against illegal constructions and dangerous buildings across Delhi followed. In Satya Niketan itself, at least one other building that was deemed unsafe was demolished, and many others were sealed. Many of the students who lived in the PGs packed their bags and left, shaken.

A neighbourhood and a university

The evolution of Satya Niketan over the 30-35 years since Vajala and Kishore went to Venky into one of Delhi's most prominent student ghettos is closely tied to the



A five-storey building came crashing down on September 6 in Satya Niketan area.

ABHINAV SAHA

expansion of DU's South Campus, the enormous influx of outstation students to a university that is desperately short of facilities to house them, and the alacrity with which a variety of entrepreneurs have rushed to cash in on the opportunity and Satya Niketan's fortuitous location.

The settlement at the corner of Ring Road and Benito Juarez Marg close to Dhaura Kuan emerged in the 1960s as part of a Jhuggi Jhopri Removal scheme of the Delhi Development Authority (DDA). People who had been evicted from slums on government land were allotted plots up to 40 square metres in the area.

These original allottees were not allowed to transfer their plots, but many did it anyway, using well-worn workarounds such as "agreements" and "power of attorney". But the new occupants had no legal title to the plots, and were treated as unauthorised occupants.

Then, on October 11, 1972, the DDA's Slum and JJ Department decided to regularise the occupation by offering perpetual leasehold rights at Rs 125 per sq yard, along with a 10% penalty and annual ground rent equal to 2.5% of the premium from the date of occupation.

"The decision of 1972 was a welfare measure intended to give benefit to those who were otherwise in breach of law," the High Court noted in a later judgement (2011). There are 299 plots in the area.

The lanes get even more cramped as they lead from Satya Niketan to the adjoining urban village of Moti Bagh, where the houses are even smaller. Fifty-seven-year-old Ved Prakash, who has lived all his life in Moti Bagh, described the transformation of the locality next to his own.

"The original allottees (of Satya Niketan) mostly sold their plots and left, and mainly Punjabi and Bania families moved in. Those families started a small market

in the 18 plots at the front of the locality (facing Venky). These were small shops like a grocery store, vegetable shops, a salon, and tea stalls. The rest of the neighbourhood remained residential," he said.

A resident of Satya Niketan who declined to be identified by name said his family, who lived in Karol Bagh, had bought their plot from an original allottee because they wanted to live in a quieter locality.

Chandni Singh, who runs a salon in the area, recalled having grown up in a locality that was greener and had a more closely knit residential character.

"Earlier, we would sit out on *charpais*. The lanes were wider and more open. What you see now is unrecognizable from what used to be," she said.

Singh, Ved Prakash, and a number of other long-time residents linked the transformation of the area to the coming of the PGs phenomenon. From the beginning of the 2000s, they said, homeowners started to turn rooms of their houses into private hostels, and charged each tenant individually. From the 2010s onward, the PG business exploded.

Through this period, Delhi University too underwent massive expansion. In 1960, there were 26 affiliated to the university, in which about 14,000 students studied. Delhi's first Master Plan, prepared in 1962, noted that these colleges were overcrowded and unable to cope with the increasing demand for college education. These colleges were also largely concentrated in North Delhi, and the Master Plan noted that students had to travel long distances from "far-flung colonies" to attend classes.

Thus, the Master Plan said, "A university centre in the south is proposed near the junction of Kitchener Road (today's Sardar Patel Marg) and Ring Road. This centre will have several colleges. It is also

How much are students spending

● **Kim**, 2nd year student, Jesus and Mary College
PG: ₹12,500/ month
ELECTRICITY: ₹14 per unit
COOKING GAS: ₹100/ month
FOOD: ₹4,000-₹5,000/ month

● **Manthan**, 3rd year student, Atma Ram Sanatan Dharma College
1-ROOM FLAT WITH TWO BEDS: ₹8,500 a bed/ month
FOOD (FROM MESS): ₹5,700/ month
ELECTRICITY: ₹1,000/ month

● **Neha**, graduate, Motilal Nehru College
PG, SATYA NIKETAN: ₹9,000 per bed/ month
ELECTRICITY: ₹2,000/ month
FOOD: ₹3,500/ month
SECURITY: Rs 22,000 (deposit per year; not refunded)

● **Alumnus**, Janki Devi Memorial College
ONE TIME CHARGE FOR KRISHNA HOSTEL (ON-CAMPUS): ₹10,000
MESS CHARGES: ₹42,000
HOSTEL CHARGES OTHER THAN MESS: ₹1,08,000
TOTAL FEES: ₹1,60,000



A narrow corridor at a PG in Satya Niketan.

EXPRESS

proposed to have a number of colleges within easy reach of the residential areas each to serve a population of about 1,50,000... It is proposed that only a few of these colleges would have hostel and dormitory facilities, as most of the students served by the colleges would come from the surrounding residential areas."

This was the broad context in which DU's South Campus was planned. It was developed in the 1970s, and moved to its present location in 1984. Today, there are 13 colleges in South Campus, including Sri Venkateswara, Motilal Nehru, Atma Ram Sanatan Dharma, Ram Lal Anand, Maitreyi, Jesus and Mary, Aryabhata, and Gargi — many of them within walking distance from Satya Niketan.

Unlike what the Master Plan had envisioned though, these colleges began to attract students from across the country. By the 2010s, students from outside Delhi accounted for as much as 70% of the strength in DU's premier colleges. Vajala estimates that more than 60% of the current student population at Sri Venkateswara is from outside Delhi.

"I could see a visible sudden surge of outstation students after 2010. This could be because of many reasons, including the growing gap between state and central universities, and the craze for IAS coaching in Delhi," he said.

A resident of the area who did not want to be named recalled that back in the 1990s, his family rented out a two-bedroom apartment in their building to a family for Rs 5,000. "When more students began looking for places to stay, families rented out rooms and floors to them. But soon, they realized that the PG model was more profitable than residential rentals," the resident said.

So, "Instead of renting out floors, people started to convert the space into

multiple rooms, each with multiple beds, and rented out individual beds. The number of floors also began to grow," he said.

While the recent tragedy has put the vertical expansion of this area under the scanner, unauthorised construction was already being recorded in the colony by 1991. In 1992, the government told Rajya Sabha that eight properties in the area had been sealed since January 1991.

According to information provided by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), the violations included unauthorised construction of rooms, toilets, and staircases on the first, second and third floors, as well as the construction of illegal basements.

Rs 8,000 for a bed and shared loo; food and electricity extra

A five-storey building in the area, with one of its walls comprised almost entirely of blue-tinted glass panelling, has nothing that identifies it as a commercial 'PG' accommodation. There is no signboard of any kind — even though everyone knows what the building is.

"You won't find anything cheaper this close to South Campus," the PG owner said. The owner's family lives on the first floor; the other floors have rows of rooms that operate as PGs.

Each floor has a narrow, dimly-lit corridor with doors leading to three rooms. A room on the second floor has three small beds and a shared attached bathroom. Students pay Rs 8,000 per month for a bed here. The room is tiny; the three beds leave barely enough floor space to walk past suitcases, clothes, and study tables.

"Electricity is extra, on a sub-meter. If you want food, mess charges are separate," the owner said. "That is Rs 3,500 a month for two daily meals. It is simple home-style food — dal, sabzi, roti."

If students cook their own food, they have to share the cost of gas cylinder refills. But cylinders are difficult to get, and have to be bought on the black market for prices that can be unpredictable.

A door in the room with the three beds leads to what is described as a "balcony", but from where nothing but the grey wall of the next building is visible. There is a common kitchen on the floor, with a stove and a water dispenser. The area under the sink is crowded with 20-litre bubble-top water containers, both full and empty.

Amlan Das, who came to study in Delhi from Assam, lived in Satya Niketan for a year in 2012 when he was an undergraduate student at Delhi College of Arts and Commerce. He found a broker who got him a room for Rs 8,000 a month.

"They called it a PG, but I had to buy my own bed, arrange my own food. But I had no choice. I was new and didn't know my way around, and my first priority was to get settled within my means. This place was the closest to college and offered student-friendly facilities," he said.

But Das could not stay for long. He found the area suffocating and cramped, and moved to Lajpat Nagar after a year.

A week after the building collapse, its shadow hung over Satya Niketan like invisible construction dust. Young women walked in and out of their "PGs", watchmen at the gates looked closely at strangers. Asked if a PG operated in their building, a couple of them said No reflexively.

But the student housing business was carrying on.

epaper.indianexpress.com

 New Delhi



Defence Secy meets Vietnam Dy Defence Minister, discusses regional security

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, September 13

DEFENCE SECRETARY Rajesh Kumar Singh and Senior Lieutenant General Nguyen Truong Thang, the Deputy Minister of National Defence of Vietnam, on Sunday discussed advancing regional security and deepening the bilateral Enhanced Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, while also strengthening the friendship between India and Vietnam.

This meeting followed a high-level discussion between the Prime Ministers of both countries on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit.

In a statement issued on Sunday, the Ministry of Defence said the discussions centred on accelerating joint initiatives, technology sharing and defence industrial collaboration.

The two sides reaffirmed their shared commitment to expanding maritime and defence ties to ensure a peaceful, stable, and rule-based regional security architecture, it noted.

“Both sides reaffirmed their joint commitment to enhancing practical defence cooperation through ASEAN-led mechanisms, noting that collaborative platforms like the ADMM-Plus Experts’ Working Groups are vital for maintaining regional stability and building collective security architectures in the Indo-Pacific,” the statement noted.

They agreed on the scheduled conduct of the next Defence Policy Dialogue to be hosted in India on the sidelines of Aero India 2027.

The Ministry of Defence statement noted that the interaction underscores the growing momentum in defence ties between India and Vietnam, building directly on the strategic vision set forth by both Prime Ministers at the BRICS summit.

Over the last few years, the defence cooperation between India and Vietnam has deepened substantially. This includes Defence Policy Dialogues, military-to-military exchanges, high-level visits, capacity building and training programmes, cooperation in UN Peacekeeping, ship visits and bilateral exercises between the countries.

UN chief backs demand for expanding Security Council

Divya A
New Delhi, September 13

SPEAKING AT the BRICS Summit on Sunday, United Nations Secretary-General António Guterres backed the demand from the Global South to expand the UN Security Council, which, he said, will help “bring balance and equity to global systems and institutions”. He also underlined that India has been at the forefront of this demand.

Emphasising that today’s economic, demographic and geopolitical realities are not those of 1945, Guterres said that “the institutional structures must reflect it”.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi had on Saturday pitched for a greater role for developing countries in global decision-making, saying the Global South should move from being a “rule-taker” to “rule-shaper”.

Echoing that sentiment, Guterres said: “Countries represented at this Summit speak to that changing reality.” Over the past several years, he said, major emerging nations have called for an expansion of the UN Security Council. “India has been at the forefront of this



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Secretary-General of the United Nations António Guterres at Bharat Mandapam on the second day of the BRICS Leaders’ Summit in New Delhi on Sunday. PTI

demand,” Guterres said.

He also weighed in on how the world is increasingly moving towards multipolarity, adding that it “helps bring balance and equity to global systems and institutions”. “But this requires reforming global multilateral institutions — including the UN Security Council and the Bretton Woods system — to reflect the world of today,” he said.

“As your Summit’s theme rightly frames it, we must build for resilience, innovation, co-

operation and sustainability, he said at a session on Sunday, adding that it is an imperative for “shaping inclusive global growth”.

In the New Delhi Declaration issued on Saturday, China and Russia have reiterated their support for India and Brazil to play a greater role in the United Nations. According to the Declaration, the leaders of BRICS countries reiterated their support for a “comprehensive reform of the UN, including its Security Council”.

Defence to space, trade to tech: India, Philippines to deepen ties

Divya A
New Delhi, September 13

A YEAR after New Delhi and Manila elevated their ties to a strategic partnership, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Philippines President Ferdinand R Marcos Jr held wide-ranging discussions on Sunday, on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit, on further advancing the ties.

Modi also welcomed Manila’s decision to join the India-led Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure (CDRI).

Marcos Jr, who visited New Delhi in August last year, at-

tended the BRICS Summit as the current ASEAN chair. His visit assumes significance in the context of India’s Act East policy and its Comprehensive Strategic Partnership with ASEAN.

India and the Philippines have rapidly strengthened their diplomatic, economic and security ties in recent times, with the 2022 deal to supply BrahMos supersonic cruise missiles to the Philippine Navy marking a major milestone.

Both countries hold regular staff talks for their Army, Navy and Air Force to improve joint security cooperation. Mean-

while, trade has grown past \$3 billion, driven by Indian pharmaceutical exports, IT services and agricultural cooperation.

In a statement after the bilateral meeting, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said the two leaders expressed satisfaction at the progress made in bilateral cooperation and agreed to deepen and expand collaboration across a wide range of areas, including defence and security, trade and investment, space, railway infrastructure, fintech, education, tourism, science and technology, innovation and people-to-people ties. “De-



Philippine President Ferdinand Marcos Jr at the BRICS Summit in New Delhi, Sunday. REUTERS

lighted to meet President Ferdinand Marcos Jr on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit. Wished

him a very happy birthday too. We reviewed the growing momentum in the India-Philippines Strategic Partnership,” Modi said in a post on X.

“Key focus areas are: Economic linkages. Technology. Trade. Space. Innovation. Creative industry. We also discussed ways to further strengthen India-ASEAN engagement,” he said.

The two leaders also exchanged views on regional and global issues of mutual interest and reiterated their commitment to strengthening cooperation across all areas of the strategic partnership.

Following Marcos Jr’s visit last year, India and the Philippines had adopted a 2025-29 roadmap to expand military training, staff talks, and maritime security cooperation in the Indo-Pacific region. Both sides are driven by shared concerns over China’s aggressive territorial assertiveness in the Indo-Pacific and the South China Sea.

India has consistently supported a rules-based maritime order in the South China Sea, based on international law and the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS).

{ POLITICS }

Amid shifting battle lines in poll-bound Punjab, can Pilot be a game changer for the Congress?



THE NEERJA CHOWDHURY COLUMN

THE CONGRESS has made a smart move by sending Sachin Pilot as the party general secretary in charge of Punjab in place of Bhupesh Baghel. It has signalled the Congress leadership’s seriousness about addressing the divisions within the state party unit, which could cripple its chances in the upcoming Assembly elections.

Pilot, 49, has the confidence of Rahul Gandhi, is well regarded nationally and, most importantly, has been welcomed by all party factions in Punjab.

He would take it up as a challenge. Swinging Punjab for his party would come as a real feather in Pilot’s cap, who is seen as its potential chief ministerial face in Rajasthan.

He is familiar with what intra-party feuds entail, given his bitter tussle with former Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot. But what goes for him is the will to power he displayed between 2014 — when he was appointed the Rajasthan Congress chief for turning around the party’s abysmal fortunes, and he criss-crossed the state to pull it off — and 2018, when the Congress wrested the state from the BJP under his leadership.

But, as the Punjab in-charge, Pilot has his task cut out with the elections barely five months away.

Congress infighting

The Congress should have been the natural beneficiary of the anti-incumbency sentiment this time in the border state. But the open war in its state unit has dealt a blow to the party. Pilot has to deal with the raging conflict between state Congress chief Amrinder Singh Raja War-



Punjab Congress chief Amrinder Singh Raja Warring with party’s state-in-charge Sachin Pilot in New Delhi. FILE

ring and ex-CM Charanjit Singh Channi — something that should have been addressed by the party leadership before it burst in the open.

Power sharing is usually the secret for effecting “unity” in a party. Pilot, who has already met several top state Congress leaders, is believed to have conveyed a simple message to them: Whoever delivers the maximum number of seats from their belts becomes a frontrunner for the top job in the event of the party’s victory in the elections.

The Congress is pitted against the incumbent AAP as its main foe. The AAP, which swept the 2022 elections by winning 92 of 117 seats, is facing discontent, though it still holds its own on the strength of its welfare schemes.

Paradoxically, both the Congress and the BJP believe that a fragmented polity can go in their favour. The Congress feels they would corner the largest chunk of votes to romp home. The BJP calculates that the more splintered the electoral scene, the greater would be its chances of getting a toehold in the next government.

BJP-Akali play

As of now, Punjab looks like a five-way contest between the

AAP, Congress, Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD), BJP, and Akali Dal (Waris Punjab De) headed by Khadoor Sahib MP Amritpal Singh.

It will become a four-cornered battle if the estranged former allies BJP and Akali Dal join hands again, which is not being ruled out despite the BJP’s declaration of its intent to contest all 117 seats. Both ex-NDA partners need each other; the BJP has yet to come out of the setback it suffered in the state after the farmers’ agitation during 2020-21.

The Akali Dal, down to one Lok Sabha MP and three MLAs, including two rebel legislators, has hardly shown any signs of revival. The Akalis fear that a hard bargain for seats by the BJP could send younger Sikh leaders into the arms of the Akali Dal (Waris Punjab De), a fledgling outfit.

To rebuild its base in Punjab, the BJP has announced a “Nasha Mukti Yatra” from the third week of September from four corners of the state, modelled on the “Parivartan Yatra” the party held in West Bengal ahead of the Assembly elections there earlier this year.

The BJP hopes that its anti-drug Punjab yatras, which will converge in Jalandhar, would

resonate with common people, especially with the party’s traditional constituency of urban, middle-class Punjabis. The party’s tie-up with the SAD, if it comes about, might however weaken the credibility of this initiative. For, some prominent Akali Dal faces were under a cloud of alleged drug business, when their coalition had been in power.

Amritpal factor

The wild card this time however could be the Waris Punjab De, whose pro-Khalistan chief Amritpal has been in a jail in Assam’s Dibrugarh under the National Security Act (NSA) since March 2023.

Given the perceived angst against the AAP, public fatigue from existing political parties, and Gen Z’s growing unrest, many do not rule out young Sikhs gravitating to Amritpal’s outfit. Privately, some SAD insiders express their worry on this score, pointing out that Punjab has had a “tendency to vote emotionally”.

The Waris Punjab De has already named some candidates for the 2027 elections, who include Satwant Singh, son of Kehar Singh who was executed for his role in the assassination of ex-Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, and Mandeep Singh Sidhu, brother of late actor-activist Deep Sidhu, who was an accused in Red Fort violence on the Republic Day during farmers’ rally in 2021.

There is also speculation whether Amritpal may be released from prison in the run-up to the elections.

Former PM Atal Bihari Vajpayee used to defend the BJP-Akali Dal alliance for being a coalition which kept Hindus and Sikhs on the same page. BJP leader late Arun Jaitley had once claimed, in a private conversation, that the BJP had “transferred” its votes to the then Captain Amarinder Singh-led Congress at the last moment in the 2017 Punjab

elections to “prevent” the AAP from clinching it. The Congress had won that election. The BJP had then accused AAP supremo Arvind Kejriwal of “hobnobbing” with pro-Khalistani elements for electoral advantage.

Even in 2017, many Punjab youth were rooting for the AAP, then a new entrant. “Our parents can vote whichever way they want, but we are voting for the *Jharoo* (AAP’s poll symbol),” they would say. In 2022, both the youth and their parents voted together for the AAP, propelling it to power in the state.

Punjab’s high stakes

Punjab has seen the consequences of divisive politics — and suffered as a result. In the late 1970s, the Congress had propped up a fiery preacher Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale to counter its rival Akali Dal. He became a metaphorical tiger the party could not dismount from. It was to trigger developments (like the Army’s Operation Bluestar in the Golden Temple complex in June 1984) which hurt the Sikh psyche deeply and led to the assassination of then PM Indira Gandhi.

Punjab has always had implications that go beyond the state. In recent years, India’s diplomatic ties with Canada had come under strain because of pro-Khalistani elements living there, which hit a flashpoint in the wake of killing of a Canadian citizen and Sikh separatist, Hardeep Singh Nijjar, outside a gurdwara in Surrey in June 2023. It is risky, and foolhardy, for parties to play petty politics in Punjab to win an election or to decimate an opponent, tempting though that might be. For, Punjab is not like any other state of India. All parties will do well to remember that.

Neerja Chowdhury, Contributing Editor, The Indian Express, has covered the last 11 Lok Sabha elections. She is the author of ‘How Prime Ministers Decide’



Lok Sabha Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi and Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra with Malaysia’s Prime Minister Anwar Ibrahim, and others, in New Delhi on Sunday. ANI

Rahul, Priyanka meet Malaysian PM over breakfast

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, September 13

LEADER OF Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Sunday met Malaysian Prime Minister Anwar Ibrahim here over breakfast and discussed India-Malaysia ties as well as global and regional issues of importance.

Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra was also present during the meeting. The Congress put out pictures and a video of Rahul and Priyanka from the meeting with Ibrahim.

In a post on X in Malay, Ibrahim said, “Had the opportunity once again to meet my good friend, who is also the Leader of the Opposition in the Indian Parliament, Rahul Gandhi, this morning over breakfast.” This brief meeting provided space for us to exchange views on the latest international and regional developments, the visiting Malaysian PM said.

Rahul also shared pictures from the meeting on his WhatsApp channel and said he had a warm and engaging conversation with Ibrahim.

The meeting comes a day after Prime Minister Narendra

Modi and Ibrahim held talks on cooperation in the areas of trade, semiconductors, infrastructure and defence. The two leaders had met on the margins of the BRICS Summit.

Malaysia is a partner country in the BRICS grouping. It is also a key partner country for India within the ASEAN grouping.

Ibrahim had also met Rahul during his visit to India in August 2024. In December 2024, condoling the passing of former PM Manmohan Singh, Ibrahim had paid a moving tribute and called him “my mitra, my bhai”.

This was Rahul Gandhi’s first meeting with a visiting dignitary after over a year. He had met visiting Mauritian Prime Minister Navinchandra Ramgoolam on September 16, 2025.

In December last year, Rahul had alleged that the government tells visiting foreign dignitaries not to meet the Leader of the Opposition due to its “insecurity”. He had alleged that it is a tradition that visiting foreign dignitaries meet the LoP, but PM Modi and the Ministry of External Affairs were not following this norm.



AAP leader Arvind Kejriwal (centre) during an event to announce the party’s pre-poll alliance with Goa Forward Party (GFP). PTI

‘Goa First’ alliance: AAP, Goa Forward Party declare tie-up

Pavneet Singh Chadha
Panaji, September 13

THE AAM Aadmi Party (AAP) and the Goa Forward Party (GFP) on Sunday formally announced an alliance, ‘Goa First’, for the 2027 Assembly elections in Goa.

According to AAP leaders, the alliance will be a “non-BJP, non-Congress” platform and offer an alternative to what they described as “BJP-Congress collusion” in the state.

At a press conference in Goa, AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal said the alliance would be a “credible and honest” tie-up of equal partners “which will be loyal to the people of Goa”.

“Why was this alliance needed? In the past few years, the people of Goa feel they do not have an option. Either they vote for the Congress or the BJP... there is a *gathbandhan* (pact) between these two parties. In 2017, the people voted for the Congress because they were fed up with the BJP. But the Congress sent its MLAs and helped the BJP to form the government. In 2022, again, people voted against the BJP, but the Congress again provided the numbers and the BJP formed the government. So, people have been deceived twice and they are not in the mood to be fooled for a third time,” Kejriwal said.

“If not Goa First, it is certain that the BJP will not get a majority and that most Congress MLAs who get elected will defect

to the BJP. This is not a theoretical alliance. We will win and ‘Goa First’ will form the government on its own,” he said.

The former Delhi Chief Minister alleged a “collusion” between the BJP and the Congress in the state. “More than half the leaders in the current BJP government are ‘Congressi’. This government has no ideology. This is neither a BJP government nor a Congress government. *Ye keval paisa ki sarkar hai*. (This is a government that is only interested in making money.) In every sector, the mafia... builders, contractors... they are all ruling Goa. Our alliance is ‘Goa First,’” he said.

In 2022, the BJP emerged as the single-largest party, winning 20 of the state’s 40 seats, while the Congress returned with 11. The GFP contested the 2022 Assembly polls in alliance with the Congress and won one seat, represented by Fatoroda MLA and party chief Vijai Sardesai. The AAP won two seats.

Dismissing the AAP-GFP alliance, state BJP media convener Siddesh Naik said, “Changing alliances and joining hands before elections does not change reality on the ground. Goa does not need an opportunistic alliance. It needs stability, development and leadership that delivers. The name may be Goa First, but the question is... is it really Goa First, or is it power first? The people of Goa know the difference.”



As Bengal shuts 252 madrasas, state BJP says it was long due

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, September 13

THREE MONTHS after the new BJP government in West Bengal began a detailed survey of all the madrasas operating in the state, it has ordered the closure of 252 of them and has issued showcause notices to 100 others.

Sources in the state Minority Affairs and Madrasa Education Department said that Malda district, bordering Bangladesh, has most madrasas in the government's closure list (45), followed by those in Uttar Dinajpur (37), and South 24 Parganas, Murshidabad and Nadia districts (25 each).

Speaking to the mediapersons on Saturday, Minority Affairs and Madrasa Education Minister Kshudiram Tudu said, "We have shut 252 madrasas and issued showcause notices to 100 others. These madrasas will have to respond, and if their replies are found to be unsatisfactory, then we will take action against them too."

As per the survey report, 2,132 madrasas are operating with proper approval, while 2,396 are functioning without permission from any government board or the required authority, an official said.

According to Tudu, the survey covered 22 districts and different parts of Kolkata, collecting information on their management, teachers, students, infrastructure, sources of

“Terrorists have been caught staying in madrasas and carrying out anti-national activities. Those madrasas that follow the rules will remain operational”

DILIP GHOSH
PANCHAYATI RAJ MINISTER

funding and other details.

A special team was also sent by the state government to verify the information collected during the inquiry.

In its June order, the BJP government had said that the purpose of the survey was to "obtain authentic district-wise data" as well as identify "any irregularities or unlawful activities".

"The present exercise is intended for administrative purposes, with a view to enabling the Department to obtain authentic district-wise data regarding the nature, status, academic activities, infrastructural facilities, student composition and related particulars of such institutions for educational planning, child welfare measures and maintenance of educational records," it had stated.

"The exercise may also assist the Government in identifying any irregularities or unlawful activities, if found, and

taking corrective measures," it had added.

Reacting to the report, state BJP president Samik Bhattacharya on Sunday said, "This should have happened long ago. That is why our state government did it. (Former CPM chief minister) Buddhadeb Bhattacharya had once questioned what work was going on in the guise of Khaliji madrasas, but under pressure he had to revoke it. If the then Left government had listened to him, then the condition that is there today on the borders would not have happened."

BJP MLA and Panchayati Raj Minister Dilip Ghosh doubled down on the government's decision, "There is a lot of controversy with madrasas. Terrorists have been caught staying in madrasas and carrying out anti-national activities. Those madrasas that follow the rules will remain operational, but madrasas just cannot mushroom anywhere. The government will not allow that to happen."

However, Opposition Trinamool Congress MLA Kunal Ghosh, who is with the Mamata Banerjee faction, said that all madrasas should not be painted with the same brush.

"Madrasa education is a gharana. Now, suddenly, the BJP and their leaders like Dilip Ghosh are saying that terrorists are being caught. Attacking the education system and creating such a narrative is not right," the TMC MLA said.



Malaysia Prime Minister Anwar Ibrahim arrives at the Markaz in Kozhikode on Sunday. PTI

Without AI knowledge, societies may be weaponised: Malaysia PM

Press Trust of India
Kozhikode, September 13

MALAYSIA PRIME Minister Anwar Ibrahim on Sunday called for greater expertise in AI and modern technology, warning that societies lacking an understanding of AI risk being "weaponised" by foreign forces.

Ibrahim was speaking after receiving the first "Excellence Award" instituted by the Sheikh Abu Bakar Foundation at the Karanthur Markaz in Kunnamangalam. The Malaysian PM visited Kerala to meet Indian Grand Mufti Kanthapuram A P Aboobacker Musliyar after attending the BRICS Summit in Delhi.

This was Ibrahim's second meeting with Kanthapuram in four years in the state.

Addressing a gathering at

Markaz, Ibrahim said scholars and societies must recognise the realities and challenges posed by modern technology, new sciences, digital transformation and artificial intelligence.

"The scholars have to accept the new realities and the challenges of the present time. That includes our understanding of modern technology, new sciences, digital transformation, and artificial intelligence," he said. PM Ibrahim said technological advancement should be accompanied by a strong value system.

He said knowledge and expertise in AI were essential as the technology rapidly transformed societies. "Without knowledge, we will fail. Without understanding AI, we will be colonised, and we'll become just weapons... weaponised by

foreign forces to weaken our resolve," PM Ibrahim said.

Even leading figures in the technology sector, including AI pioneers and entrepreneur Elon Musk, had expressed concerns about the implications of artificial intelligence.

He said the challenge was two-fold — acquiring knowledge and expertise in AI while ensuring that technological progress did not erode moral values. "Our concern is: We need the knowledge. We need the expertise. But our concern is also the need to have it to protect our moral values," PM Ibrahim said. He also stressed the importance of preserving cultural and intellectual heritage while embracing new technology. "Our problem is — we grab new technology but we lose sight of our own heritage."

• BRIEFLY



Rescue work underway after a building collapse in Ahmedabad. PTI

GUJARAT

Woman killed, three injured in Ahmedabad building collapse

A 50-YEAR-OLD woman was killed and three others were injured after a dilapidated residential building collapsed in Kalupur area of Ahmedabad city on Sunday. Kalupur police station officers have registered a case of accidental death and launched an investigation. According to a senior police officer, the deceased has been identified as Sonalben Rana, a resident of Raja Mehta ni Pol in Kalupur area of the old city of Ahmedabad. Personnel of the Ahmedabad Fire and Emergency Services carried out a rescue operation. "The building was dilapidated and it collapsed around 3 pm today (Sunday). While Sonalben died in the incident, her daughter-in-law and two tenants got injured in the incident. A case of accidental death has been registered," said the senior police officer. ENS

Shots fired outside Punjab singer's house

MULTIPLE SHOTS were fired outside the residence of singer Gulab Sidhu in Pharwahi village of Punjab's Barnala district in the early hours of Sunday. Sidhu, meanwhile, is in Australia for his shows while his family was home when the shots were fired. No one was injured in the incident, and bullets pierced the house's gate. Barnala Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP) Mohammad Sarfaraz Alam said, "At least six rounds were fired. Three suspects on a bike have been captured in the CCTV footage. Other details are being verified." ENS

MP hooch case accused held after encounter

A MAN wanted in connection with the hooch tragedy in Madhya Pradesh's Sagar district that claimed 16 lives was apprehended after a brief encounter with police early on Sunday, officials said. The accused, Shivanjay Rajput, 21, who was carrying a bounty of Rs 30,000, suffered a gunshot wound to his leg during the face-off, they said. The number of accused arrested in the case is 19, police sources said, adding FIRs have been registered against 30 persons. Rajput allegedly fired three rounds at a police team during a search operation. PTI

El Niño to peak during Oct-Dec this year, says US climate agency

Express News Service
Bengaluru, September 13

THE CURRENT El Niño event is all set to enter its peak phase during October-December this year, US-based National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA) has warned.

El Niño is a naturally occurring ocean-atmospheric phenomenon, wherein there is an abnormal warming recorded along the equatorial and central Pacific Ocean waters. El Niño conditions are often linked to extreme weather across the globe, in the form of higher-than-average temperatures, rainfall or droughts. The 2026 El Niño would be a historic event ever recorded since 1950.

"As a result of this, there are higher chances of experiencing impacts consistent with El Niño," NOAA said. In August, the sea surface temperatures continued to rise and the key Niño regions clocked temperatures ranging between 1.8 to 3 degrees Celsius.

The latest Niño index (June through August) was 1.4 degrees Celsius, up by 0.4 degrees Celsius from May-July, confirming the rapidly intensifying event.

The agency added there is a greater than 90 per cent chance that the current El Niño would further intensify into the 'very strong' category and prevail through the winter season.

Tamil cinema's two 'Ts' align for this race in UK: Vijay green-flags, Ajith takes off

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, September 13

WHEN TAMIL Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay arrived in the UK on Friday carrying the familiar luggage of an official foreign tour — investment meetings to MoUs — one thing stood out from his first overseas visit.

The Michelin Le Mans Cup announced Vijay as its "special guest" for Saturday's Silverstone round, saying he would support the Indian drivers and officially start a 44-car grid. Ajith, Vijay's principal box-office rival for much of the past quarter-century, is among them.

For Tamil audiences, the tableau needs little explanation. Ajith was "Thala"; Vijay, "Thalapathy". Their combative followers acquired less majestic names: Ajith supporters became "Aamais", or tortoises, and Vijay supporters "Anils", or squirrels. At Silverstone, however, the squirrel will lower the flag and the tortoise will accelerate.

How Ajith is different

Vijay's fan network evolved into a welfare organisation, then a political machine, and finally achieved an electoral victory.

Ajith attempted the reverse. He dissolved his fan associations amid factionalism, politicisation, and misuse of his



Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay and actor Ajith at the Silverstone circuit on Saturday. @LEMANSCUP/X

name. In 2017, he said he had no authorised fan clubs and apologised for harm caused by people invoking him. In 2019, denying political ambitions, he said he had never instructed admirers to join or vote for a party. Affection, for him, meant studying, working, caring for one's family, obeying the law, and respecting others. Ajith surprised his and the wider public when, during the 2015 Chennai floods, he

opened his home to residents of nearby slums and sheltered them for several days.

Famously, at a felicitation for then CM Karunanidhi in February 2010, Ajith had objected to film personalities being pressured into political and social events and asked the CM to stop such coercion. Rajinikanth gave him a standing ovation. Ajith later clarified that he respected Karunanidhi and

EXPRESS special

blamed coercive groups around the industry rather than the government.

More recently, in 2021, Ajith asked to be called Ajith, Ajith Kumar, or AK rather than "Thala". When "*Kadavule... Ajithey*" (God, Ajith) became a public chant in 2024, he called it disturbing, said superlatives made him uncomfortable and asked people to stop.

That distinction resurfaced during last April's election. Having returned from Belgium a day earlier, Ajith voted early at Thiruvanniyur, where a noisy crowd surrounded him. He covered his ears and left quickly. A claim circulated that he answered "no need" when asked whether TN required political change. His manager denied this.

After Vijay's victory, top sources close to Vijay claimed Ajith had telephoned to congratulate him, supporting accounts of their cordial relationship.

Ajith's racing is no celebrity hobby purchased after success. Returning after nearly 15 years, he formed Ajith Kumar Racing and entered international endurance competition in 2025. At Dubai's 24-hour event, his team earned a class podium; another entry he drove finished fourth in GT4 and received the Spirit of the Race award. He now competes in the Le Mans

Cup's LMP3 Pro-Am category, an entry officially confirmed by the championship.

Vijay's schedule

Officially, Vijay's visit is to drive investments to TN. His government plans investor meetings and MoUs in advanced manufacturing, automobiles, EVs, electronics and Global Capability Centres. The trip seeks to use the India-UK FTA, effective from July 15, to expand investment, exports and technical partnerships.

Silverstone also provides a governmental purpose beyond celebrity theatre. Vijay recently announced a Motor Sports City for Tamil Nadu. His delegation will examine the circuit's design, safety, commercial operation and connections to sports tourism and specialised automobile industries. Sports Minister Aadhav Arjuna and senior officials are accompanying him.

Still, Vijay's appearance could be read as an overture to Ajith's enormous but deliberately unorganised constituency, or as patronisation by a CM occupying ceremonial foreground of another star's achievement. The safer reading is Vijay is lending the authority of his office to an international event in which his old rival is representing the country.

A wig, three identities and crores gone missing: Anatomy of a 'share market' con

Manish Kumar Pathak
Mumbai, September 13

FOR INVESTORS, Rohan Bhushan Sheth was a successful share trader who hosted them at his luxury apartments in Sion and Matunga, showed statements recording profits and promised monthly returns of up to 5%. When payments stopped, so did the calls. His flats were locked and he had left Mumbai with two large suitcases.

The Economic Offences Wing (EOW), which arrested Sheth, 56, in Valsad on July 3, says the man who had disappeared had also lived under two other identities, used a wig while meeting investors and had a luxury lifestyle including three flats and high-end cars.

The agency filed a charge-

sheet against Sheth, alleging he ran an investment scheme using fabricated profit statements to make investors believe their money was being traded in the share market. The EOW has identified 42 investors from Maharashtra and Gujarat, including an NRI woman, who invested around Rs 5 crore.

The case began with a complaint by Sanjay Hiralal Shah, 60, a retired Kandivali resident, who approached Mumbai police commissioner Deven Bharti in April and alleged that he and his family had been cheated of more than Rs 10.81 crore.

According to the complaint, Sheth came in contact with Shah's son, an IT engineer, in 2020 when he hired him to develop a mobile application for share-trading. The app was later

named Investok. During the Covid-19 pandemic, Sheth offered to teach him share trading and promised returns of about 1% a month, later raising this to 3-5% for large investments.

Shah allegedly invested Rs 97.50 lakh after borrowing around Rs 1 crore and received about Rs 50.61 lakh as purported profit or returns, but claimed that around Rs 1.02 crore remained payable. His wife allegedly invested Rs 1.44 crore and his son Rs 8.31 crore.

The EOW alleges that Sheth used the same pitch with other investors — inviting them to his luxury apartments, explained his investment strategy sheets recording profits with alleged manipulated figures.

When investors sought withdrawals, Sheth allegedly delayed

• Aliases he used over the years

JAYESH HASMUKHBHAI SHAH
STUDENT YEARS



Rohan Bhushan Sheth used a wig while meeting investors

RAHUL ATULBHAI PAREKH
FOR A DECADE IN DELHI; GOT MARRIED, HAD KIDS



ROHAN BHUSHAN SHETH
AFTER MOVING TO MUMBAI

of the investigation. Four luxury vehicles, and around 14 imported watches, including Rolex, Hublot and IWC, were also seized.

They found that he had allegedly used three identities. He was known as Jayesh Hasmukhbhai Shah during his college years. He later allegedly spent nearly a decade in Delhi as Rahul Atulbhai Parekh, under which identity he married and had children. After separating from his wife, he allegedly moved to Mumbai as Rohan Bhushan Sheth.

Sheth allegedly wore a high-quality wig. The detail became significant when police began looking for him in Gujarat.

The alleged fraud began unravelling in December 2025, when Sheth stopped making

payments to investors. When Shah contacted him, Sheth allegedly said the money had been invested with another person, Jaideep Parekh, who was in the US. In March, he promised an RTGS transfer. It never came.

By April, Sheth's phones were switched off. Shah found the Beaumont flat locked and was allegedly told by security staff that Sheth had left about a week earlier with two large suitcases.

Investigators learnt that Sheth had fled to Gujarat. The breakthrough came while examining records linked to his second wife, whom he allegedly married in 2021 and who later died due to an illness. A credit card in her name had recently been used in Gujarat. Police traced the transaction to a shop where a mobile phone had been

bought and obtained its IMEI number. But Sheth repeatedly switched off the phone. Investigators then followed his BMW, using GPS data and toll plaza transactions. After a week, they established he was in Valsad.

Even then, police faced a problem. Security guards and housekeeping staff in Valsad did not recognise him from Sheth's photograph with the wig.

Police waited near his residence for three days to arrest him. The chargesheet, filed on September 1, names 37 witnesses, including salon workers who allegedly maintained Sheth's wig. Their statements helped investigators establish that the bald man arrested in Gujarat was the same man who had appeared before investors in Mumbai, police said.

EXPRESS special

‘What kind of father doesn’t care for daughter’s child?’ Amanpreet Kaur lives to tell the story

A Jat Sikh woman, married to a Mazhabi Sikh man, ended up in a canal, 5-month pregnant and given up for dead

Divya Goyal Gopal
Gidderbaha (Muktsar), September 13

AMANPREET KAUR keeps feeling her stomach every few minutes, to check. “I am scared something may happen to the baby,” says the 22-year-old, admitted to Gidderbaha Civil Hospital in Punjab’s Muktsar district. It’s five days since she and her baby survived an assault by her family, with Amanpreet hiding in the water and holding on to a plant for half-an-hour to float, after being thrown into a canal. It’s been three years since she and Satnam Singh got married, two years since they went to court to get police protection, and several months since the couple dropped their guard, finally feeling “safe”. All that was washed away on September 7 morning. Amanpreet is frail, her thin frame occupying barely a corner of the hospital bed, her eyes tired and wary. Satnam, 30, his head bandaged, a cut running through his hand from the attack on him, sits beside her. At the “*waddi nehr* (Rajasthan Feeder Canal)”, Amanpreet says: “My father and cousins Sukhpreet and Lovepreet looked around to ensure that no one was watching. Then, they pushed me into the water. My father saw me going under. My cousin said, ‘*Gai* (she is gone), let’s go.” Amanpreet recalls thrashing about and getting hold of a wild

plant. “I clung to it and kept hiding. Had they seen me alive, they wouldn’t have spared me. I was in the water for 20-25 minutes. I don’t know how to swim, I kept going under. I was more worried for my baby,” she says. After they were gone, she crawled out, slipping multiple times as she climbed up. “Finally I saw a man and asked for his phone. He said he could not make outgoing calls, but went and informed the sarpanch of Middukhera. The sarpanch called the police and an ambulance,” says Amanpreet. She believes it is her baby — she is five months pregnant — that provoked this attack by her Jat Sikh family, who never reconciled to her marrying Satnam, a “Mazhabi Sikh (a Dalit convert)”. Police have booked six men on charges of attempt to murder and kidnapping — Amanpreet’s father Baljeet Singh, her younger brother Noorpreet, her cousins Lovepreet, Sukhpreet and Novalpreet, and an alleged accomplice, Lovesh. While Novalpreet is under arrest, the others are “absconding”, says Muktsar SSP Abhimanyu Rana. ‘Never touched drugs’ Amanpreet and Satnam belong to Karaiwala of Muktsar, their houses on either ends of the village. She says they fell in love five years ago. “First, he became my friend, then best friend, and soon I realised I loved him. The biggest reason



Amanpreet and her husband Satnam Singh at Gidderbaha Civil Hospital in Sri Muktsar Sahib. GURMEET SINGH

was he never touched any *nasha* (intoxicant),” Amanpreet says, adding that one of her own brothers is an addict. When she told her family about Satnam, Amanpreet says, “My parents got my name struck off from school after Class 10 and forced me to stay at home. I cleared 12th through correspondence. My father made it clear that he would never let me be with Satnam.” They got married in secret in a temple in Muktsar on December 1, 2023, Satnam says. “We lived at our respective homes separately for some months. Then, in August 2024, we moved the Punjab and Haryana High Court seeking police protection against Amanpreet’s family as we feared for our lives.” Amanpreet told police she wanted to live with Satnam. “Her family said she had died for them... We then started living in Chandigarh,” says Satnam. Satnam worked as a security guard, and Amanpreet took up a job as a saleswoman at a store. In November 2024, they returned to the village after facing health and financial issues in Chandigarh, Satnam says. The High Court order and police’s warning to Amanpreet’s family to stay away from the couple reassured them. Gidderbaha DSP Jatinder Singh says: “On September 7, 2024, the two recorded a statement before police saying they don’t face any threat now, don’t need gunmen, and don’t want any further proceedings on their HC writ... Everything had been peaceful for nearly two years.” The nightmare returns Amanpreet thought the worst was over. Then, on the night of September 6, around 9 pm, just as they were sitting for dinner, she says, Noorpreet, Novalpreet, Lovepreet, Sukhpreet and Lovesh stormed into Satnam’s house with rods and weapons. “They started assaulting my husband. They were ready to shoot us. My mother-in-law intervened, and she was also thrashed. They dragged me by the hair and forced me into a car.” Amanpreet says they drove

to her house, where her father Baljeet got into the vehicle. They pressed her to submit a statement against Satnam, saying he consumed drugs and beat her, and that she wanted a divorce. Amanpreet refused. “My father tried to strangle me, but one cousin said don’t kill her this way. Then they took a U-turn and took me to Malout, to an uncle’s house.” They stayed for the night there, she says. “In the morning, around 7 am, they drove me to the canal. They said, ‘There’s no point keeping her alive, she will not change her statement.’” The three got out, grabbed her and threw her into the water, she says. Karaiwala village sarpanch Gurjit Singh says police called him the night Amanpreet was taken away. “But I had already slept.” Amanpreet’s family might have done what they did in “anger”, Gurjit adds. “Villagers told me the family was provoked by Satnam, that he went to their house drunk and shouted: ‘*Tussi mama bannan waale ho* (You are going to become an uncle).’” Satnam denies this. “In two years, I never went to their house. Why would I go now?” Amanpreet says as recently as Raksha Bandhan on August 28, her father called her up, asking her to come home and tie Rakhi to her brothers. She was happy, she says... “I am the only daughter in the family.” Satnam stopped her from going. “He felt something was fishy,” Amanpreet shudders. “How can you call such a man a father who did not think about his daughter’s unborn child? Wasn’t he happy when my brother and I were born?”

Key Ladakh demand met: Families of four killed get Rs 15L each

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, September 13

THE LADAKH administration has announced compensation for the families of the four persons killed in the police firing in Leh on September 24 last year — fulfilling one of the demands of the two representative bodies of the Union Territory. The administration has also announced compensation for the people injured during the protests for the statehood for Ladakh. “While no compensation amount can replace a life lost or erase the pain endured, the Ladakh administration firmly stands beside every affected family in its journey towards healing and overcoming the grief,” Lt Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena said on Sunday. Of Rs 1.52 crore sanctioned for compensation, Rs 15 lakh each has been announced for the families of four persons killed during the protests. The administration has announced Rs 3 lakh each for people with major injuries and Rs 1 lakh each for protesters with minor injuries. Officials said while Rs 60 lakh have been earmarked for the families of four deceased persons, Rs 72 lakh has been approved for 24 persons with major injuries. For the 20 people with minor injuries, Rs 20 lakh have been approved. ‘A measure of support, solidarity’ “The compensation is intended as a measure of support and solidarity with the affected families and individuals,” an official release said. “The Lieutenant Governor expressed his deep gratitude to Hon’ble Union Home Minister Shri Amit Shah for his sensitive, humanitarian and guiding approach, and for always standing in solidarity with the victims and their families.” Four protestors were killed and 44 injured as police fired after a protest for statehood and



Ladakh Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena being felicitated during his visit to Tso Kar region on Sunday. PTI

“Ladakh administration firmly stands beside every affected family in its journey towards healing and overcoming the grief”

L-G VINAI KUMAR SAXENA

sixth schedule for Ladakh turned violent in Leh on September 24 last year. The violent protests erupted after the student and youth organisations had called for a shutdown in Ladakh after two elderly persons fainted while on hunger strike during a fast announced by climate activist Sonam Wangchuk. The killing of protesters had only increased the confrontation between Centre and the two representative bodies of Ladakh — the Apex Body Leh (ABL) and the Kargil Democratic Alliance. The compensation for the victims of police firing was one of the major demands of the two bodies. As a confidence-building measure, the Centre had shifted the then Lt Governor of Ladakh, Kavinder Gupta, and police chief S D Singh Jamwal from Leh. Gupta was replaced by Saxena in March this year.

Saibaba event: Another former TISS student gets Mumbai Police notice

Sadaf Modak
Mumbai, September 13

DAYS AFTER a magistrate court granted bail to a former student of Tata Institute of Social Sciences (TISS) in a case related to his alleged participation in a gathering to mark the death anniversary of former Delhi University professor G N Saibaba in 2025, the Mumbai Police has now sent a notice to another former student in the same case. The notice in connection with an FIR filed nearly a year ago, was issued last week, directing the former student to remain present before the investigating agency for interrogation. The person was not named in the initial FIR. On September 10, the magistrate court granted bail to a 30-year-old student, over a month after his arrest in connection with a gathering held on October 12, 2025, at the institute’s Deonar campus. The court held that there was no material to link him to Maoist or anti-national mindset, as alleged by the police. The court also cited the Bombay High Court granting interim relief from arrest to another student last month. The notice issued to another former student was under section 35(3) of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023. The Trombay police had filed an FIR in October 2025, naming nine persons — all students at the institute then — for the gathering, based on the complaint of an associate dean. It was alleged that the students had gathered to pay homage to Saibaba, without permission from the institute. Saibaba, a former Delhi University professor, was convicted in 2017 on allegations of being a Maoist but was acquitted by the Bombay High Court in 2024. The nine had then filed anticipatory bail pleas before the sessions court. While they were granted interim protection pending hearing, orders on the pleas came only on August 7 this year, with anticipatory bail granted to seven, while denied to two. Of the two, one of the former students was arrested the same day. Police alleged that slogans were raised seeking Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam’s release; and that they possessed downloaded books and other material that the prosecution said reflected Maoist ideology.

Tension in Meerut over murder of youth, 2 held

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, September 13

HASTINAPUR IN Meerut district of UP is tense following the murder of a young man on Friday evening while he was returning home on a bike with his friend. Police have deployed a large contingent of force in the area, while the houses of three accused have been partly demolished over alleged illegal construction. For 27-year-old Nitin Nagar, a bike ride with a friend turned

fateful as the bullet shot by assailants to kill his friend, Prince, killed him instead. Nitin was returning home after his daily workout routine. He had cleared the written examination for the post of constable in the Delhi Police and was awaiting his physical test. He had got married four months ago. Police said that one of the accused, identified as 29-year-old Mitthu, wanted to kill Prince, with whom he had a long-time rivalry over local domination. According to police, Nitin was riding pillion while his friend, Prince, was driving the motorcycle when they were attacked. A bullet struck Nitin, and he was rushed to hospital, where he died during treatment. “There was no dispute between the accused and my son, Nitin. Yet he lost his life. Nitin, who had married just four months ago, was our only son, and this loss is irreplaceable for his wife and me. I gave my child the best education so that he could live a peaceful life — I never imagined a tragedy like this could befall him,” said Nitin’s father, Satish Kumar, a resident of

Makhan Nagar village in Meerut. Satish, who saw the video clip of his son’s murder that was recorded by a CCTV camera installed near the crime spot, has named five persons — Mitthu, Rishabh, Goldy, Shakti, Utsav — and one unknown person — for his son’s murder. Police have so far arrested two men, including Mitthu, the prime accused. Following the murder, Nitin’s family members and villagers protested by placing his body on the Bijnor-Meerut Highway. They refused to con-

duct the final rites until the accused were arrested. Police said that after prolonged persuasion by senior officials and local UP Minister Dinesh Kumar, the protesters lifted the blockade. Meanwhile, the district administration razed alleged illegal constructions at the houses of the three accused — Utsav Yadav, Mitthu and Goldie. “We are investigating the murder. Two persons have been caught,” said Superintendent of Police, Meerut, Abhijeet Kumar. The other person arrested is Utsav, said sources.

Mandatory presence, no receipt for papers: Karnataka voters worry over SIR notice

Akram M
Bengaluru, September 13

ON THE morning of September 9, a man visited the Booth Level Officer (BLO) at Ujire Gram Panchayat in Karnataka’s Dakshina Kannada district with a set of documents. He was among the 1,000 odd voters in the panchayat’s draft electoral roll who were served notices for identity verification during the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR). “The notice was issued due to the difference in my name from that in the 2002 electoral roll. Since I worked abroad, I had to add parts to my name. That is why I was served the notice,” he explained. Like elsewhere in the state, around 10 per cent of voters in the village have received similar notices. Like his father-in-law, whose initials were expanded while applying for a passport. He too visited the gram panchayat and submitted the relevant documents. “I submitted the documents. However, there was no acknowledgement confirming that they had been accepted and that I would remain on the final electoral roll,” the man told *The Indian Express*. Both men returned after being told that they would know their status when the final rolls are published on October 27. Puttappa, a resident of the neighbouring Laila panchayat, said that his son, Suresh P, has received a notice. “He has been working abroad for the past 10 years. Now, a notice was issued regarding ‘name mismatch’. When I enquired with the BLO, I was informed that my son has to be present on the date of hearing, failing which his name would be struck off,” he said. Puttappa asked how authorities could demand physical presence at a short notice. “Many, including my son, work in small companies and do not get leaves at will. How can he attend the hearing within days of

the notice being served?” he said. While such cases reflect concerns among voters who have submitted one of the 11 documents listed by the ECI, others such as Zakariya wonder why they received notices in the first place. “According to officials, the notice was issued because the age difference between me and my grandparents was less than 40 years. However, none of my four elder brothers received a notice,” he said. Zakariya submitted his documents at Ujire panchayat last week. “If the ECI can alert us about the notice using our phone numbers, why can’t it provide an acknowledgement about whether our documents have been accepted?” he asked. Karnataka Chief Electoral Officer V Anbukumar said there was no mechanism to inform voters in the notice phase that their documents have been accepted. “If it is accepted, they will know it on the spot,” he said. On physical presence, sources said that this was being done as per ECI directions. “Physical presence is mandatory. While their relatives can submit enumeration forms on behalf of the voter during the earlier phase of SIR, voter presence is mandatory during the notice and verification phase,” an official said. On notices on age difference being served to only a few siblings in a family, the official said they were looking into the complaints. Bengaluru-based firm MAC Insights has analysed the 43.81 lakh notices generated in Karnataka. The analysis showed that a little over half the notices (23.28 lakh) were for voters who were unmapped during the last SIR. For instance, the entire family of entrepreneur Nandan Nilekani was issued notices citing this reason. “Self name mismatch” is the second most common reason, with around 5.2 lakh voters getting notices for this reason.

● KOLHAPUR DISTRICT DISASTER MANAGEMENT AUTHORITY HAS TRAINED 15 TRANSWOMEN SO FAR

From hiding identity to pulling people to safety: Meet the transwomen rescue squad

Shubham Kurale
Pune, September 13

IN THE last week of August, a group of people gathered at Rajaram Lake, pulled on orange life jackets, checked their ropes, and spent 10 days practising rescue drills in the water. It looked like routine disaster-response training — until you learned who they were. They are part of the transgender disaster management and rescue team, for whom the life jacket has come to mean something far bigger than safety gear.

A new first

The Kolhapur District Disaster Management Authority has trained over 2,500 volunteers in the last decade. In 2019, it created the state’s first all-women rescue unit, the ‘Aapda Sakhi’ team, which now counts more than 500 trained volunteers. But ahead of this year’s monsoon, officials decided to try something unique. “We thought, why not train a transwomen team,” said Prasad Sankpal, District Disaster Management Officer, Kolhapur. “So a first-of-its-kind transgender disaster management and rescue team initiative was begun in the country.” The first batch of 10 transwomen, all associated with the Kolhapur-based Maitri NGO, went through their inaugural training module from May 26 to 28. Since then, the district has trained 15 transwomen in total, with fresh rounds of practice held every three months — the most recent a 10-day exercise at Rajaram Lake in the last week of August. Recruits learned rescue



Aboard a motorboat during a training exercise. EXPRESS

swimming, how to operate an inflatable rescue boat, dry and wet lifesaving techniques, motorboat handling and maintenance, and First Aid and CPR. “So far the results are excellent,” Sankpal said. “The institutional strengthening is already visible — the volunteers now help victims of road accidents without any instructions.” More than a rescue team For the women themselves, the initiative is about something the training manual doesn’t cover. “Even today, people see us as sex workers or beggars,” said Mayuri Alvekar, founder of Maitri NGO, who brought the other volunteers on board. “Believe that such opportunities of working with the administration would help promote inclusivity and give us space in mainstream society, while changing the perspective towards us. We have been helping people during disasters or rescue needs but faced discrimination. However, now we are getting recognition and, most importantly, an identity.” “To take the initiative further, I have also created a similar volunteer team in Dhule and Parbhani,” Alvekar added. Suhasini Devmane, another team member and Maharashtra’s first transgender tourist guide, spent eight years as an ayurvedic panchakarma expert while hiding who she was. “Despite a desire to contribute to society, many of us had previously been unable to participate in social initiatives due to a lack of opportunities,” she said. “For over eight years, I had to hide my identity — else I would have lost my job, and my financial situation didn’t allow for that risk then. I believe this training will not only change society’s perspective towards transgender people but also boost the self-confidence of individuals within the community.” Shivani Gajabar, who is currently pursuing a Master of Social Work degree at Shivaji Uni-

versity, Kolhapur, says the acceptance hasn’t fully arrived yet. “Even today, transgender community members feel alienated from mainstream society,” she said. “Though giving us a platform in the disaster management rescue team is a welcome step and would help bring inclusivity — and we all would give our best while saving lives — I feel there is a long way ahead to fill the gap. Even when I go regularly to attend classes, no one sits on my bench. I’m all alone.” Her family cut off contact when she left home in Class 7. “They used to think I could not do any considerable work,” she said. “However, now, being part of the disaster management rescue team, my family members have started communicating with me again.” What next The administration isn’t stopping at floods and drowning rescues. “There are around 30 categories of man-made and natural disasters, including wildlife rescues involving snakes and crocodiles in Kolhapur, and the transwomen volunteers will gradually be trained for these as well,” Sankpal said. One gap the authorities want to close: money. The volunteers currently work for free. “We are also planning to deploy them for crowd management during upcoming festivals such as Navaratri, Anant Chaturdashi, and the Jyotiba Yatra among others. Also, efforts are underway to grant home guard status to the transwomen volunteers, which would come with an honorarium,” Sankpal told *The Indian Express*.

Indian seafarer missing after attack on tanker off Oman coast

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 13

AN INDIAN seafarer is reportedly missing after the vessel he was on, a Panama-flagged oil tanker, was attacked off the coast of Oman on Sunday. The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) has condemned the attack, adding that efforts are underway to rescue the other 13 Indian crew members of *MT El Gaia*. “We condemn the attack on the commercial vessel *MT El Gaia* off the coast of Oman earlier today. Of the 14 Indian crew onboard, 13 Indians have been rescued so far,” it said. “Search and rescue operations for the missing Indian are continuing. Our embassy in Oman is closely monitoring the situation and proactively coordinating with the Omani authorities in the ongoing search and rescue operation,” the MEA said in a statement. “The targeting of commercial shipping, seafarers, civilians, and civilian infrastructure in the region is unacceptable,” it added. Speaking at the BRICS Leaders’ Summit on Saturday, Prime Minister Narendra Modi proposed the creation of a ‘Seafarers’ Emergency Support Network’ to safeguard them from security risks due to regional conflicts.

UNIVERSITY OF RAJASTHAN, JAIPUR
(NAAC Accredited 'A+' Grade University)

Notification for Rajasthan University PhD Admission (Reserved Category Seats Only)
Online applications are invited from reserved category (SC/ST/OBC/MBC/EWS) candidates for admission to the vacant seats in PhD programmes in selected few departments/Centers of the University of Rajasthan. Online applications may be submitted on <https://rupauniraj.org> from **18th September 2026 (11 am onwards) to 28th September 2026**. For more details on the programmes, please visit the University website. (<https://www.uniraj.ac.in>)
Mr. Kalu Ram, Registrar**Convener, RUPA-2025**

At BRICS, more options, a win for diplomacy

THERE CAN be two views about BRICS and almost every multilateral forum at a time of churn in global politics. According to the first, such forums are ineffectual pagentry, while the second paints them are merely vehicles for the great powers to build their spheres of hegemonic influence. The New Delhi Declaration 2026 underlines a much-needed third view. It holds that diplomacy, cooperation and exchange of ideas, goods and services need not be beholden to the ideologies and interests of great powers. There is room for different political systems and even states on opposite sides of military conflicts to sit together, to agree, and agree to disagree. The strength of the New Delhi Declaration, then, lies in the spectacular headlines it did not make, and in reasserting the importance of diplomacy as-usual.

As West Asia continues to suffer from prolonged conflicts — Israel and Palestine, Iran and Lebanon and now, Yemen — the consensus between Iran and the UAE that calls for “exercising maximum restraint, as well as avoiding actions that could further aggravate the situation” is an unambiguous victory for diplomacy. Beyond West Asia, the Declaration focuses on the issues that will outlast the current moment’s rhetoric. Over 130 paragraphs of the 45-page document focused on “unilateral coercive measures” and “unilateral sanctions”, “unilateral blockades” — a comment on, and a push back against, the excesses by Washington under Donald Trump. The message is clear: Supply chains and trade routes of essential commodities, including and especially hydrocarbons, must not be weaponised. For developing countries of the Global South, the energy question is particularly salient. Rather than chasing the chimaera of a BRICS currency, the Declaration does well to focus on linking payment systems among member states. India’s UPI architecture has great potential here. The focus on AI capacity building and digital resilience also carries Delhi’s imprint.

When it was first formed in 2006 and through its early years, BRICS was meant to act as a forum for united action by emerging powers in a unipolar world. Its grand ambitions of “de-dollarisation” and multipolarity have led its detractors to paint it as an attempt to be “anti-West”. In fact, few of the group’s core members, and its expanded roster, hold such a view. China is looking for accommodation with the US, many countries from West Asia are practically allied with Washington; Vladimir Putin shares a personal rapport with Trump; India is looking to firm up a trade deal with America and do more business with Europe. In 2026, an expanded BRICS balances the views and needs of its many members. The New Delhi Declaration emphasises that a plurality of voices must be heard and heeded.

After oil surge, Fed rate hike will shape challenge

ON WEDNESDAY, Brent crude traded above \$100-per-barrel for the first time after May 26, touching \$110 during the week before closing at \$104.6. This week could see the US Federal Reserve raise interest rates when the central bank’s open market committee meets on September 15-16. Unlike oil — where the trigger for the recent price surge has been the Iranian-aligned Houthi militia’s seizure of virtually Yemen’s entire Red Sea coast, threatening navigation through the vital Bab el-Mandeb Strait — the markets have already priced in the Fed’s rate hikes. Ten-year US Treasury bond yields are almost at 5 per cent, the highest since October 2023. The West Asia conflict’s ripple effects are also being felt through US producer price inflation hitting 5.4 per cent year-on-year in August and diesel prices soaring to a record \$6.20 a gallon.

All this matters greatly for India, as an importer of both energy and capital. The higher the prices of oil, and the longer they stay so, the more the impact, in terms of inflation and growth slowdown. The same goes for interest rates. When yields on 10-year government securities are near 3 per cent in Japan, 5 per cent in the US and 5.4 per cent in the UK, why should foreign investors put money in India, where returns aren’t as assured or high, after adjusting for currency depreciation risks? Elevated international energy prices widen India’s current account deficits. These become harder to finance in a rising global interest rates scenario, as capital flows shift to the safe-haven assets of industrialised countries. India has weathered the Iran war-induced energy supply shock relatively well so far. The \$127.2 billion of FCNR(B) deposits mobilised through the RBI’s special dollar-rupee swap facility has also stemmed the run on the rupee.

In the short run, the hope is of some kind of a deal to manage shipping through the effectively shut Hormuz as well as the now-threatened Bab el-Mandeb chokepoints. The important challenge for India, however, lies in boosting its export competitiveness and attracting long-term foreign investor interest. Key to the first is elimination of duties on imported raw materials and components, besides continued investments in roads, railways, inland and coastal waterways, and port infrastructure. The latter entails creating an environment where investors are confident about India not just being a robust long-term growth story, but offering policy predictability and stability. On top of these is the need for fiscal prudence and to guard against government overspending spilling over into higher current account deficits.

FREEZE FRAME BY EP UNNY



The Editorial Page

MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 14, 2026

India & China are at a Nash equilibrium. Will it hold — that’s the question

ARE WE any the wiser about the course of India-China relations after the Eight Points of Outcomes and Consensus statement on the border issued on August 25 and the meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping at the just-concluded BRICS Summit?

What the August statement and the two readouts from India and China after the summit indicate is that, with respect to the border, the two sides are at a Nash equilibrium. For the Economics 101-challenged like me, a Nash equilibrium is an outcome in a non-cooperative game in which “no player’s expected outcome can be improved by changing one’s own strategy” (according to Britannica online). In essence, India and China, at least tacitly, recognise that in any foreseeable future they cannot aspire to and achieve a better position in the border quarrel. They may well spar diplomatically and militarily occasionally, as they have since 2013. But the intermittent war of words and of hardware over control of the high Himalaya can only move the Line of Actual Control slightly.

The border quarrel can only be solved to the maximal satisfaction of India and China by negotiation or by force. India and China have been negotiating a border deal almost without interruption since 1981 — the Secretary/Vice Minister-level talks (1981-88), the

Joint Working Group (1989-2005), and the Special Representative Mechanism (2003-present). Over more than 45 years, they have met once a year on average.

After all those years of talking, the only agreement of substance is the 2005 “Political Parameters and Guiding Principles for the Settlement of the India-China Boundary Question”. The most important parameters and guidelines were that a settlement would be reached as a package (nothing is settled until everything on the border is settled). The final agreement would be a “political settlement” that would consider strategic concerns, history, national sentiment, practicality, geography, and the interests of settled populations in the borderlands.

The August 2026 eight-point statement, enjoining the negotiators to seek an early and substantial harvest with respect to the border, does not violate the idea of a package deal. Rather, it suggests that the two sides should focus on success in one area instead of negotiating everything everywhere all at once. Having achieved success in one section, they should then move on to another section of the border. Yet, as per the 2005 agreement, each sectional success would only be finally accepted and ratified when the entire border is settled.

Nothing in the Modi-Xi BRICS readouts alters the basic 2005



KANTI BAJPAI

Two things can disturb the Nash equilibrium (apart from bad defence or internal political collapse): The transition to a successor Dalai Lama, and an India-Pakistan fight that draws China directly in

agreement or the eight-point early harvest statement. The negotiation process has been somewhat nudged by the eight-point statement, but it is hard to imagine that diplomatic bargaining now or in the future can give India or China their maximal objective. For India, the maximal objective is to get back Aksai Chin up to its original claim and to keep everything it has in the other sectors. For China, it is to get Arunachal Pradesh all the way to the southern slopes (which is most of the state) and to keep everything else it has in the other sectors. It is inconceivable that Indian or Chinese negotiators can achieve their maximal objectives.

Nor can they do so by force. India cannot conquer Aksai Chin up to its original claim line, and China cannot conquer Arunachal Pradesh up to the southern slopes. Terrain, climate, logistics, and military defences make any dramatic — and lasting — military gains almost impossible. Short of extremely bad strategy by their commanders or internal political chaos that distracts from deterrence, the status quo on the border is stable.

Two things can disturb the Nash equilibrium (apart from bad defence or internal political collapse): The transition to a successor Dalai Lama, and an India-Pakistan fight that draws China directly in and leads to a two-front war for India.

● WORDLY WISE
You can disagree without being disagreeable.
— Ruth Bader Ginsburg

Eventually, Beijing will appoint its preferred Dalai Lama. The Tibetans will almost certainly choose their own. New Delhi will be caught in the middle. India-China tensions could consequently spiral, and China could lash out as it did in 1962 when the instabilities in Tibet were a factor leading to war.

Alternatively, another India-Pakistan fight could spiral. In 2025, New Delhi detected a Chinese helping hand to Pakistan during Operation Sindoor. In a future South Asian confrontation, China might be more ostensively involved. New Delhi or Beijing may then find themselves drawn into a fight that would threaten the status quo.

Beyond the border negotiations and all the other good things that the present détente with China promises — trade, visas, supply chain resilience, river water cooperation — New Delhi should be thinking about the strategic challenges that could disturb the current Nash equilibrium. Can India-China relations be insulated from a Tibet transition and a future India-Pakistan fight? Can the fruits of détente help build sufficient insulation? What more needs to be done with China?

The writer is visiting professor, International Relations, Ashoka University, visiting senior fellow, Centre for Social and Economic Progress, and emeritus professor, Lee Kuan Yew School of Public Policy, National University of Singapore

The rebuilding of the city must begin, after Satya Niketan



GAUTAM BHATIA

EVERY YEAR, after the monsoon arrives, streets get flooded, and as more rain washes the city and water wends its way into basements and foundations, walls buckle, and buildings collapse. People are trapped inside; some die. At Satya Niketan, 50 Delhi University students were huddled in a makeshift arrangement in an unauthorised building. Seven died, and many others are in serious condition in local hospitals. Could the tragedy have been averted? Given the building’s condition, its age, its unauthorised status, and location in a dense neighbourhood, the answer is a resounding no. As climate change alters weather patterns, causing flash floods and drenching cities with sudden and enormous quantities of rain, it is critical to build physical safeguards that, along with civic governance, can be effectively enforced. For that, several steps are required.

First is the physical mapping of Lal Dora areas, the shadow pockets that evade municipal planning and exist in virtually all big cities. Almost 60 per cent of Delhi’s population currently lives in unauthorised structures — mostly in slums, low-rise makeshift tenements, or high-density four-to-five storey buildings in urbanised villages. While street maps of most illegal colonies exist, there needs to be a building-by-building documentation of the types and sizes of all structures, an assessment of their physical condition, along with an enumeration of the inhabitants. Advanced infra-red and other imaging techniques allow for a reasonably accurate assessment of the buildings’ structural condition.

Gone are the days when buildings were made to last for generations. The life-span of structures built in this century is barely 30-40 years; for those in Satya Niketan — because they follow none of the required safety codes — even less. Even within this short time frame, buildings need to be checked regularly, and if need be, demolished partially or wholly, and replaced.

Most buildings are designed for a specific function — their inappropriate use and heavy load on floors can weaken and damage the structure. A block of flats is designed for domestic use, but in unauthorised colonies many are converted into stores and restaurants, thus increasing the number of occupants and altering the weight on floors. Even makeshift hostels compromise living space to give a more lucrative return to the property owners. Unless building authorities approve a designated building function and allocate minimum floor space per person, no oc-

cupancy permit should be issued.

What then of the density of the colony layout? Builders take no responsibility for the ground they share with neighbouring buildings, but a spatial evaluation of the overall surrounding layout becomes essential to establish safety standards. Is there adequate natural ground around the structure to absorb rainwater? Are there enough wide-mouth drains to move water quickly? Local storm drainage conditions and the open ground available need to be assessed. In most cases, too much building in too small a ground area traps excess water, directing it into basements and foundations, eventually destabilising the structure.

Finally, there is the question of urban governance. Are political parties and their municipal agencies capable of being effective civic authorities? Or should all control of roads, buildings, transport and other infrastructure come under one legal entity, say, the mayor? What indeed is the value of the battery of bye-laws if they can’t be enforced? What is the point of the structural evaluation of buildings if inspectors and site engineers can be easily bribed?

Some years back, a newly constructed apartment in Bengaluru crumbled into a heap of dust just as soon as it was completed. It was approved as a three-storey structure, but the builder decided to increase his profit by adding two more floors illegally, thereby weakening the structural capacity of the columns. The collapse killed 12 people. What was the square-foot gain in income for every life lost? How do you monitor construction activity that could harm, even kill, its occupants?

In the Satya Niketan case, alterations were being carried out in the basement, potentially risking damage to the building. More rooms to house more students, a canteen perhaps? What was happening there was anybody’s guess, but it was enough to destabilise a structure almost half a century old, and bring it crashing down.

By 2030, Delhi will have a population of nearly 40 million, making it one of the world’s densest cities. More students and more migrants from nearby towns will make this their home. Soon civic authorities will need to ask more difficult questions. Can the city continue to accommodate people in every possible leftover space, without services or security? Will builders merely build higher with more unauthorised floor space, and endanger more lives? Or, is it time to seek thoughtful and radical alternatives? Is there space in the municipal mind for new and experimental ideas?

The writer is a Delhi-based architect

The choice is between AI applications and AI frontiers



SUVRAT RAJU

INDIA IS facing a technological crisis. Even as US and Chinese firms have released a parade of increasingly capable AI models this year, India has no competitive frontier model and no realistic prospect of producing one without significant policy shifts. The anticipated impact of AI can be separated into two categories. First, AI can diffuse through the economy by automating some routine jobs. Each industry will require specialised applications built on foundation models. India has an active start-up ecosystem devoted to building such applications, and businesses have rapidly adopted AI tools. However, AI will also have a strategic impact on research, cybersecurity and defence. AI models have been used to solve some of the most important open problems in mathematics. Anthropic’s Mythos model has formidable cybersecurity capabilities; it has not been released publicly, and is available only to selected organisations.

Currently, consumers have access to other frontier models, including Chinese open-weight models. But it is unrealistic to expect this to continue indefinitely. Earlier this year, the US temporarily imposed export restrictions both on Mythos and on a version of Mythos with guardrails called Fable. It is likely to restrict and regulate AI to “achieve global dominance”. US industry leaders and academics have advised India to focus on applications rather than the frontiers — a position supported by sections of the Indian IT industry. But countries that fall behind in frontier AI risk suffering the fate of those that missed the Industrial Revolution: A small business elite might find a niche and prosper, but ordinary people will suffer disempowerment.

India can still catch up to the frontier with a focused effort. The algorithms underlying modern AI models are widely understood. The industry has exploited “scaling laws” that predict how a model’s performance improves with its size and the computing power used for its training. So, while better algorithms improve efficiency, the basic formula for producing frontier models is to scale compute and data. Lack of computing power has bottlenecked sovereign Indian model development. The IndiaAI mission has a pool of 45,000 GPUs. But this is only a fraction of the capacity controlled by a single US frontier lab. The mission allocated 4,096 GPUs to Sarvam AI to train India’s flagship model. This is about 50 times smaller than what is used to train frontier models. No amount of ingenuity can compensate for this resource gap. A number of data centres, with significant computing capacity, are coming up in various states. But these will primarily serve MNCs, and their location in India offers no tangible benefits. Most of the announced capital investment will be directed to electronic equipment, and the employment they create will be limited to a few construction and maintenance jobs. Large data centres have a significant environmental impact. In India, this impact will be borne disproportionately by local communities.

India could use these data centres to alleviate its compute shortage with a “compute tax”: Any data centre established in India would be required to reserve, say, 25 per cent of its computing capacity for a publicly administered national compute pool. This capacity would remain physically within the data centre, but could be allocated by a central scheduler to Indian institutions. MNCs are likely to resist, but their bargaining position is weak given the growing hostility to these installations elsewhere. Such a tax would not obviate the other data-centre concerns. But together with environmental safeguards and welfare measures, it might open a narrow route to building a frontier model in India.

The writer is professor of Physics, International Centre for Theoretical Sciences, Bengaluru. Views are personal

40 YEARS AGO

September 14, 1986



Early state polls likely

SIMULTANEOUS ELECTIONS to the Kerala, West Bengal and Haryana assemblies are likely to be held early next year as the Congress (I) leaders are considering advancing the poll date. The tenure of these assemblies is to expire in June next year. The elections may be held six months before the expiry of the tenure.

Sevend gunned down in Tripura

SEVEN PERSONS, including six policemen, were killed and several others injured when armed Tribal National Volunteers (TNV)

extremists ambushed a police jeep on the Ambassa-Ganganagar road in North Tripura about 90 km from Agartala, officials said. About eight policemen were on their way to the Ambassa market from the Ganganagar Tripura Armed Police outpost around 10.30 am, when about 10 extremists opened fire.

Punjab CM on migration

THE PUNJAB Chief Minister, Surjit Singh Barnala, said the people must frustrate the terrorists who wanted to achieve Khalistan by forcing migration of the population along communal lines. Barnala, who was addressing a public meeting attended mostly by the

Punjabis of Jaipur, said the Punjab government was determined to persuade the Hindus who had migrated from the state to return to their homes.

Panther in concrete jungle

A FULL-grown panther that strayed into the concrete jungle of Secunderabad was captured alive and taken to the Nehru Zoological Park in Hyderabad by the zoo staff with the help of the police. The spotted cat measures nearly 5.5 feet, nose-to-tail-tip, and weighs 60 kg. It had no man-eating tendencies according to the zoo staff, who managed to tranquilise it after a two-hour battle.



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A blueprint to create productive jobs, a lesson from Tiruppur



FROM PLATE TO PLOUGH

BY ASHOK GULATI AND
SULAKSHANA RAO

IN HIS Independence Day address from the Red Fort's ramparts, Prime Minister Narendra Modi placed "manufacturing power" as the first among the seven Saptadharma streams that are to take India towards a Viksit Bharat. He also said this effort would fully harness the potential of India's youth. The pertinent question is, which manufacturing sector can actually deliver jobs at the scale India needs?

Our research at ICRIER points to the textiles and apparel (T&A) sector. But first, why is creating jobs urgent? India's growth story will have little meaning if it fails to create jobs for the masses, and that too in the formal sector. India had 61.6 crore employed persons aged more than 15 years (2025), but agriculture still accounted for 43 per cent of employment, compared with 12.1 per cent in manufacturing (PLFS 2025). Even a 1 per cent point shift in employment from agriculture to manufacturing would involve moving a large number of workers. The NDA had promised to create 2 crore jobs every year, but reality is nowhere near that. The recent student agitations over paper leaks reflected an underlying frustration: Even after acquiring a "three Rs" education, respectable jobs in the formal sector remain scarce. Unemployment among those aged 15-29 was 9.9 per cent, rising to 13.6 per cent in urban areas, while 25 per cent were neither in employment nor in education or training (PLFS 2025). Female labour force participation was 40 per cent, compared with 79.1 per cent for men.

A large share of India's workforce remains in informal employment, without the stability and social protection of formal jobs. The PLFS usual-status measure includes people who worked for a long part of the year

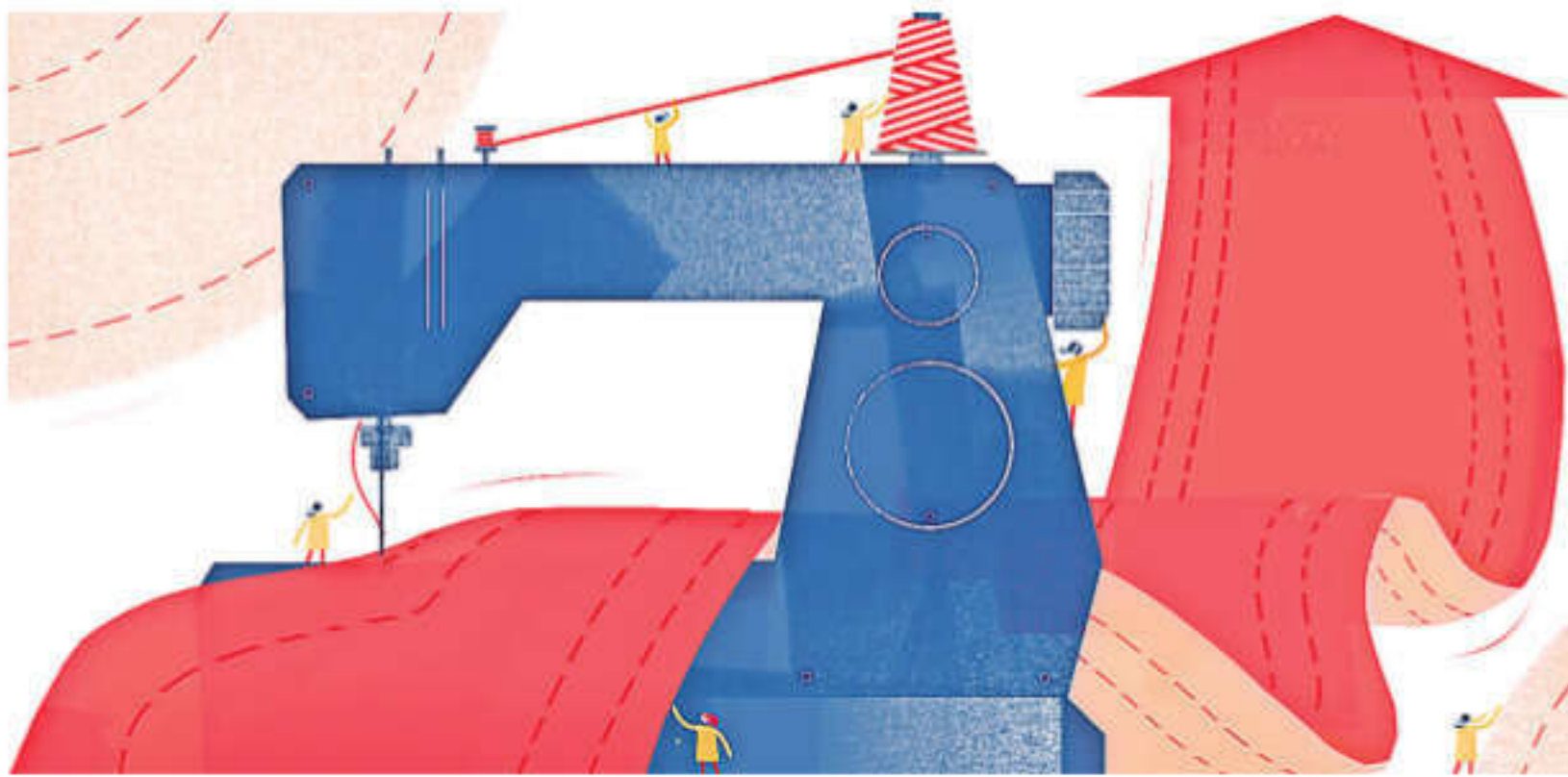


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

as well as those who undertook economic activity for at least 30 days during the year. Being counted as "employed" does not necessarily mean having a regular/formal job. For workers to build economic security and resilience, the shift must therefore be towards regular, formal employment with social-security benefits like Employees' Provident Fund (EPF) and Employees' State Insurance (ESI). This is where the apparel sector matters. It is labour-intensive, employs women in large numbers and can train workers in short periods, about 60 days for specific production roles.

India has set an ambitious target of \$100 billion in T&A exports by 2030 (from \$36 billion today). Of this, \$40 billion is for apparel exports specifically (from \$15.7 billion today). But our interactions with exporters suggest that these targets are not grounded in current realities. They are more likely to be achieved by 2035, not 2030.

One good thing is that India has recently closed the tariff gaps with competitors like Bangladesh and Vietnam in major markets like the EU and the UK. But market access alone does not ensure exports. Take the example of the India-Japan agreement (2011). India's apparel exports to Japan fell from \$229 million in 2013 to \$203 million in 2024.

The Tiruppur Exporters Association played an important role in building collective capabilities, while infrastructure such as the Netaji Apparel Park supported its expansion

We need the scale and capacity to tap the potential of free trade agreements. The solution is not more factories, but creating a competitive ecosystem around them.

Tiruppur, an organically grown knitwear cluster, is perhaps the most compelling example. Its knitwear exports rose from \$3.3 billion in 2020-21 to \$5.3 billion in 2024-25 (TEA, 2026). The cluster accounts for about 68 per cent of India's knitwear exports and supports the livelihoods of more than a million workers, around 70 per cent of them being women. Within roughly 20 km, yarn, knitting, dyeing, printing, stitching, finishing, packaging and dispatch are woven into one production ecosystem. Nearly 20,000 units operate across different stages, from knitting, dyeing and printing to garmenting and ancillary activities. This is the ecosystem effect where firms specialise,

workers specialise, and thousands of jobs are created around a common market.

So how did Tiruppur do it? Over decades, entrepreneurs, industry associations and government built the institutions and common infrastructure that enabled this ecosystem to grow. The Tiruppur Exporters Association, under the leadership of A Sakthivel, and the

South India Hosiery Manufacturers Association played an important role in building collective capabilities, while infrastructure such as the Netaji Apparel Park supported its expansion. The cluster's collective strength was evident in tackling the environmental crisis. After the Madras High Court's 2011 order on units failing to meet zero-liquid-discharge (ZLD) norms, the cluster invested more than Rs 850 crore in common effluent-treatment infrastructure. Tiruppur also shows what it takes to create the next 1 million jobs. The cluster depends heavily on migrant workers from Odisha, Jharkhand, Bihar and elsewhere, making worker housing and retention important challenges. The cluster plans to foray into man-made fibres, technical textiles and high-value sustainable manufacturing to expand both exports and employment.

But Tiruppur alone cannot help achieve the target of \$100 billion in T&A exports by 2030. India needs many more such clusters. Some policy steps in this direction were taken by the government in 2021 in the form of announcing seven PM MITRA parks. But till date, only one such park seems operational (the Warangal one). Others are still in the planning stages. Such a snail's pace in the execution of even good ideas does not inspire confidence that India can achieve its target of \$100 billion exports by 2030. That would also limit the speed at which jobs can be created.

Our humble submission is that the Prime Minister needs to give special attention to this sector if India is to create 20 million meaningful jobs every year. Chip-making, AI and other advanced technologies are important for India's future, but they are for the highly skilled workforce, while the majority of India's labour force is at the bottom end. The T&A sector offers higher employment intensity at relatively low cost. China, Bangladesh, and Vietnam have followed that path, and India needs to learn from them.

The real test of Viksit Bharat is whether it can create enough productive jobs. T&A offers a clear opportunity. But it needs the PM's focus to expedite its execution.

Gulati is distinguished professor and Rao is senior fellow at ICRIER. Views are personal

Anganwadis shape the future. They are our responsibility



ANNPURNA DEVI

THE BHARAT of 2047 will be built by children who have not yet entered school. Their journey towards a healthy, confident and capable adulthood begins much earlier, most decisively in the first 1,000 days of life. For millions of Indian children and their mothers, that journey is supported by a familiar neighbourhood institution: The anganwadi.

Long before entering the classroom, children are weighed and measured at an anganwadi, get a warm meal and hear rhymes outside the home. Expectant parents also receive counselling. Today, 14 lakh anganwadi centres serve as the first point of contact between the citizens and the state, reaching over 8.9 crore children, women and adolescent girls. The 25.2 lakh anganwadi workers and helpers are drawn from the communities they serve. The anganwadi has always belonged to the neighbourhood.

This institution became the foundation of a national movement when Prime Minister Narendra Modi launched POSHAN Abhiyaan in March 2018. The ninth Rashtriya Poshan Maah began on September 9 with the theme "Hamari Anganwadi, Hamari Jimmedari". The government's commitment to providing quality services is unwavering. But an anganwadi centre truly flourishes when the community embraces it as its own. A Viksit Bharat can be built only through *sabka prayas* (everyone's effort). Nutrition cannot be seen only as a government service.

Community ownership has too often remained an appeal. This year, it becomes an institution. Anganwadi management committees bring parents, panchayat representatives and self-help groups into the centre to ensure every eligible child is reached. Social audits enable communities to review services, verify entitlements and record findings. Accountability becomes verification from within by the families served.

Mothers are at the heart of this process. The menu board of the Supplementary Nutrition Programme (SNP) displays daily entitlements for the hot meals and take-home rations. When a mother knows what her child is entitled to, transparency becomes a habit. The community becomes an informed partner in ensuring quality. During Poshan Maah 2026, committees, social audits and menu boards are being activated, alongside Tithi Bhoj, tasting sessions and recipe demonstrations.



A Suposhit Bharat requires balanced meals — cereals and millets, pulses, nuts and seeds, milk and milk products, eggs, fruits and green vegetables. The Comprehensive Guidelines for SNP 2026, released in July, define hot cooked meals and reinforce micronutrient norms under the National Food Security Act, 2013.

The second is early learning. What a child eats and learns are deeply connected. Anganwadi workers track 34 developmental milestones in a child's first three years. The Navchetna and Aadharshila curricula carry nutrition and care into school readiness.

The third begins before the child arrives. A mother's nutrition in pregnancy shapes her child's start in life. This Poshan Maah marks 10 years of the Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana, reflecting the Prime Minister's conviction that no woman should have to choose between earnings and health. A decade on, 4.65 crore beneficiaries have received Rs 21,511 crore directly into their accounts. Strengthened under Mission Shakti, it provides an additional benefit for a second girl child. The Economic Survey 2025-26 makes clear that such a transfer achieves its full purpose when it travels with counselling that enables informed decisions within the household. Reviewing Rajasthan's Cash Plus model, which paired these transfers with sustained behaviour change communication, it records that the share of women spending the benefit on food rose from 30 per cent to 89 per cent, and that myths surrounding maternal nutrition receded as husbands and families were drawn into the conversation. Partnership grows around anganwadis because a mother's nutrition was never hers to secure alone.

Community ownership cannot mean placing the entire burden of nutrition and early childhood care on the anganwadi worker. It must mean respecting, supporting and strengthening her. This September, I call upon every citizen to visit at least one anganwadi centre in their locality. Speak to the worker, read the menu board and ask how you can support them. Fathers, grandparents, panchayats and self-help groups all have a role. The children being weighed at anganwadis this September will be in their twenties when India completes a century of independence. The health and confidence they carry into that year are being shaped today. When every community takes responsibility for its anganwadi, Bharat takes responsibility for every child's future.

The writer is Union Minister for Women and Child Development

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

New Delhi Declaration

BRICS MEMBER countries, undoubtedly, have conflicting interests, and amid these divergences, the adoption of the New Delhi Declaration is no mean feat ('As walls rise, BRICS speaks', *IE*, September 13). The fact that Iran and the United Arab Emirates softened their stances reflects an earnest attempt by the grouping to reach a consensus. Not to mention, the grouping is a force to be reckoned with, especially when the world is in the throes of wars and economic uncertainties. Having said that, India has displayed dexterous and mature diplomacy.

Aanya Singhal, Noida

THE ADOPTION of the BRICS New Delhi Declaration stands as a remarkable triumph for Indian diplomacy ('As walls rise, BRICS speaks', *IE*, September 13). Mediating consensus among an expanded grouping that includes nations with competing geopolitical interests — most notably Iran and the UAE amidst the escalating crisis in West Asia — underscores India's growing stature as a bridge builder on the global stage. By steering the document forward, New Delhi successfully navigated sensitive regional fault lines without alienating key partners.

Sanjay Chopra, Mohali

AI risks

EXTREME PREDICTIONS should neither be dismissed nor accepted without scrutiny ('AI can kill humanity in a decade? Get in line', *IE*, September 12). The response lies in preparedness. Governments should require rigorous safety testing, independent audits and accountability for high-risk AI systems, while researchers study catastrophic risks. International cooperation is essential because unsafe development in one country can affect others. Public debate should distinguish evidence from speculation. Responsible regulation, rather than panic or complacency, offers the best protection.

SP Suganya Devi, Coimbatore



CARSTEN SCHNEIDER

THE FOURTH Indo-German Environment Forum, held in Delhi on September 1, focused on climate change and biodiversity conservation. Since the first forum in 2008, global environmental crises have intensified. The political environment for resolving these crises, too, has deteriorated, especially because wars, tariffs and market protectionism have undermined multilateralism. These tensions will have a bearing on India's attempts to simultaneously combat energy poverty and decarbonise its economy.

Yet, there are positive developments. The international community has concluded important agreements, notably the Paris Agreement, the Kunming-Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework and, most recently, the BBNJ Agreement to protect the high seas. India and Germany remain committed to multilateralism, working with partners worldwide to promote stability, reliability, peaceful development and a rules-based international order.

A good example of this is the India-EU trade agreement, concluded in January. Germany, as the EU's strongest economy, is committed to creating new opportunities for growth and jobs for companies in the two countries. Our combined markets serve a population of almost 2 billion people.

India and Germany have been strategic partners for 75 years. In March, we celebrated the anniversary of our diplomatic ties. In January, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chancellor Friedrich Merz met

In January, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chancellor Friedrich Merz reaffirmed their commitment to the Partnership for Sustainable Green Development

in Delhi and reaffirmed their commitment to the Partnership for Sustainable Green Development, established in 2022. Cabinet minister-level consultations are planned for 2027 in Berlin.

Both countries are aware of what happens when pressure is placed on the environment. This summer was the hottest on record in Western Europe. India is facing water shortages; large parts of the country faced heatwaves in summer, and then Assam was hit by floods. The devastating flash flood in neighbouring Nepal, which also affected many Indians, has shocked us all. At the same time, India is also proving that climate action and industrial development can go hand in hand through initiatives such as solar parks.

At last year's UN Climate Change Conference in Brazil, we jointly advocated for ambitious climate targets. Climate resilience is becoming an increasingly important goal. The fourth Indo-German Environment Forum was, therefore, fittingly titled "Together for Greater Resilience". With the Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry and the Asia-Pacific Committee of German Business (APA), the forum brought together policymakers, business leaders, scientists and representatives of civil society. My counterpart, Bhupender Yadav, and I agreed to pursue technical dialogues on climate adaptation and learn from each other's experiences. We also signed a Dec-

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More than 2,000 German companies operate in India. Nearly three-quarters of them expect sales to rise this year. More than half plan to increase their investments in 2026. More than 60 per cent manufacture goods in India to meet local demand. One particularly interesting example is the partnership between BHEL and the Dortmund-headquartered Thyssenkrupp Nucera.

The FTA offers significant potential for the development of environmental technologies and a circular economy. The private sector in both countries is already focused on these areas. This also involves the decarbonisation of industry, for example through green steel and low-carbon cement. German and Indian municipalities are working with companies to develop standardised collection and recycling systems, digital traceability chains and tailor-made financing solutions.

I am impressed by India's ambitious targets for solar energy, green hydrogen and growing domestic manufacturing. Germany brings a wide range of experience in grid integration, storage systems and regulation. Through joint initiatives — ranging from the integration of renewable energies to green industrial clusters — we can reduce emissions.

The writer is federal minister for the environment, climate action, nature conservation and nuclear safety of Germany

India, Germany & a green partnership for the future

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In January, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chancellor Friedrich Merz reaffirmed their commitment to the Partnership for Sustainable Green Development

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To decolonise Hindi is to embrace its many voices

erary texts moved across Devanagari, Kaithi, Gurmukhi, and Perso-Arabic scripts.

This porous linguistic landscape was altered by the colonial state's obsession to classify, count, and simplify governance. The initial rupture occurred in the 1830s when the East India Company replaced Persian with vernacular languages in the lower courts, setting up a competition between the sister registers of Hindi and Urdu. The 1900 court resolution in the United Provinces, which permitted Devanagari alongside the Persian script, politicised the issue, turning languages into rigid communal markers.

The decisive partition came with the Pig-gott Commission of 1912-13. When the policy of maintaining a "common language" collapsed, the colonial government prescribed separate standardised supplementary readers for Hindi and Urdu in 1916, delegit-

imising rich oral traditions and languages like Bhojpuri, Awadhi, and Braj Bhasha.

Early nationalist institutions did not dismantle this British formulation. Organisations like the Nagari Pracharini Sabha and the Hindi Sahitya Sammelan aggressively promoted a highly Sanskritised, Devanagari-based register of Khari Boli as the only "pure" (*shuddh*) national language. Under the editorship of Mahavir Prasad Dwivedi, the journal *Saraswati* became an apparatus for language policing, standardising grammar and purging Arabic and Persian loanwords.

Perhaps the real lesson of Hindi's history is that its greatest strength has never been purity. It has been absorption

Common Hindustani words were substituted with *tatsama* Sanskrit terms. The word for white (*safed*) was replaced by *shvet*, angry (*naraz*) with *krুদ্ধ*, etc.

To legitimise this artificial creation, these authors performed a double move of historical appropriation and modern exclusion. They expanded the definition of "Hindi" when looking at the past — claiming all medieval poetry, from the Apabhramsa of the *Prithviraj Raso* to the Braj of Surdas and the Awadhi of Tulsidas — even as they restricted its present-day form to one standardised Khari Boli register. The past became plural so that the present could become singular. This created severe internal hierarchies. Braj Bhasha was dismissed as didactic and erotic. Popular folk forms such as nautanki and oral ballads were devalued. Urdu was alienated. True cultural decolonisation requires us

to dismantle these structures of linguistic policing. The linguistic world of North India was built through encounters, borrowings and adaptations. Perhaps the real lesson of Hindi's history is that its greatest strength has never been purity. It has been absorption.

On this Hindi Diwas, we should remember that languages do not grow through walls. The Hindi of the future will be strongest not when it forgets its Persian, Urdu, Braj, and Awadhi inheritances, but when it embraces them as part of its history. To decolonise Hindi is not to make it purer. It is to make it historically whole, embodying the PM's vision of Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat, where unity is not sameness, but the harmonious coexistence of our many voices.

The writer is a PhD scholar, Department of History, University of Delhi



Residents leave a building during a Russian drone strike in Odesa on Sunday. REUTERS

‘Causing a shortage’: Trump asks Ukraine to halt attacks on Russian diesel hubs

Reuters
Doonbeg, September 13

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump on Sunday called on Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy to halt strikes on Russian diesel, saying the attacks are causing a fuel shortage.

Trump was asked by a reporter if he had spoken with Zelenskyy following his recent conversation with Russia's Vladimir Putin. Trump responded by calling on Zelenskyy to halt strikes against Russia.

"Mr. Zelensky has to do one thing. He has to stop knocking out diesel fuel in Russia," Trump told reporters on the sidelines of the Irish Open, which is being played at his Doonbeg golf club.

"Let him go after targets but not diesel fuel, because he's causing a shortage of diesel fuel."

Ukraine's long-range strikes have been targeting Russia's oil and gas industry for months, which Kyiv says both funds and directly fuels Moscow's more than four-year-old invasion of its neighbour.

The Ukrainian drone campaign has caused fuel rationing across Russia, despite the country being a key oil and gas exporter. Other Ukrainian strikes targeted major Russian online retailers, bringing the war ever closer to the public.

Russia has also ramped up its air campaign against Ukraine in recent weeks, using

‘Very negative forces’ raising exaggerated concerns over AI: Trump

Reuters
Doonbeg, September 13

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump on Sunday likened critics of AI to "very negative forces" bringing up scenarios that will not happen.

"We're leading China in AI. We're the most sophisticated country in the world, and frankly I want to keep it that way because whoever wins AI wins," Trump told reporters when asked if the AI industry should slow down or be more regulated.

"We could put guardrails. We can do this and that. But I think you have a lot of very negative forces that are bringing it up that

Russian drone hits passenger train

A RUSSIAN drone hit a passenger train on Ukraine's border with NATO member Poland on Sunday, shortly after former British Prime Minister Boris Johnson and other European diplomats had used the same line. The train, on a route frequently used by foreign delegations returning from Kyiv, was attacked just 2 kilometres from the Polish border, Ukraine's railway operator said. "This wasn't our train, but the one just minutes after us by the border crossing. It was evacuated as the drone approached and no one was hurt," Carl Bildt, former Sweden's PM said on X. **AP**

ballistic missiles and jet-powered drones to pierce Ukraine's defenses. Moscow's attacks have targeted Ukraine's power grid ahead of winter in what officials say is meant to demoralize civilians.

Also on Sunday, Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov said Moscow is open to restarting peace talks in autumn featuring Russia, Ukraine and the U.S. "We are not ruling out that possibility. We are specifically talking about the foreseeable future. That is, October cannot be ruled out," Peskov told reporters.

NO COMMENT BY U.S. MILITARY — WHICH HAS STRUCK IRANIAN VESSELS PREVIOUSLY

Iranian commercial ship hit near Hormuz, 1 dead

Four persons have been injured in the attack: Report

Associated Press
Cairo, September 13

AN IRANIAN cargo vessel was struck early Sunday off Qeshm Island in the Strait of Hormuz, Iranian state media said, a day before Tehran plans to brief countries in the region on its contested efforts to manage shipping traffic there.

The attack, which the reports said killed one and wounded four, drew attention back to the strait after threats to shipping in the region intensified last week when Iran-backed Houthi rebels captured an island on the Bab el-Mandeb Strait in the Red Sea.

Iran's state-run IRNA news agency quoted the Qeshm governor as blaming a "terrorist enemy" for Sunday's attack.

Turkey launches crackdown on LGBTQ+, HIV support groups

Associated Press
Istanbul, September 13

TURKISH AUTHORITIES cracked down on multiple LGBTQ+ groups and individuals early Sunday morning, detaining dozens of members, breaking into association offices and raiding popular hangouts.

In an escalation of its decade-long hostility toward LGBTQ+ groups, particularly in the lead-up to elections, simultaneous police raids beginning at 1 am took place in the major cities of Istanbul, Ankara, Izmir, Aydin and Mersin.

Justice Minister Akin Gurlek announced on social media that the investigation into 162 suspects, nine associations and 13 businesses was to "protect children, the institution of the family, and public order" in line with President Recep Tayyip Erdogan's 10-year executive order relating to families and children.

Pak PM to meet Trump on sidelines of UNGA in Sept

Islamabad: Pakistan PM Shehbaz Sharif is scheduled to meet US President Donald Trump on September 23 on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly session, according to a media report.

The US President and First Lady Melania Trump will host a reception dinner for heads of state and government attending the UNGA at the Lotte New York Palace Hotel on Madison Avenue on the evening of September 23. The News reported on Sunday that Sharif has received an invitation to the dinner, which will be attended by several world leaders. **PTI**



Houthi fighters near vehicles abandoned by Saudi-backed forces during a Houthi advance at an undisclosed location in Yemen. AP

There was no immediate comment by the US military, which has struck Iranian-flagged vessels during its blockade of Iranian ports and faces a new threat from Iranian ballistic missiles launched at its warships.

The United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations monitor said a vessel was hit by a projec-

tile while transiting the strait, though it wasn't clear if this was referring to the same attack.

The monitor said a fire had broken out and that local authorities were evacuating those on board. Qeshm Island, about 14 miles from the port city of Bandar Abbas, is key to Iran asserting control over the Strait of Hormuz.

Trump: US could stay in Iran and keep the oil, like Venezuela deal

Doonbeg: President Donald Trump suggested on Sunday the US could stay in Iran and "keep the oil", drawing a parallel with a US push to take control of a fifth of Venezuela's vast oil reserves. "We'll ultimately get out (of Iran), unless we decide to stay and keep the oil like Venezuela," Trump said. On a trip to Ireland for meetings and to watch golf, he reiterated that he still expected the Iran war to end this year, possibly just after midterm elections due in the US in November. Speaking at the Irish Open golf championship, Trump added that the price of gasoline would "drop like a rock" once the Iran war ended. **REUTERS**



Gone With The Wind

People fly kites during the annual Festival of the Winds at Bondi Beach in Sydney on Sunday. REUTERS

Swedes vote in polls that could usher the Far-Right into power

Greta Rosen Fondahn & Tom Little
Stockholm, September 13

SWEDES WERE voting in a closely fought election on Sunday that will either bring a Far-Right party into government for the first time or shift the country back towards the liberalism it has long been known for.

Sweden's Centre-Left opposition held a narrow lead over the ruling Right-wing bloc ahead of the September 13 election for parliament, several opinion polls showed this week.

But Prime Minister Ulf Kristersson, who has trailed in opinion polls throughout his four years in office, has been catching up in the final weeks of campaigning, with rival Magdalena Andersson and her Social Democrats losing ground. Kristersson has pledged to



Swedish PM Ulf Kristersson with his dog Winston after casting his vote during the general elections, in Strangnas, on Sunday. REUTERS

bring the Far-Right Sweden Democrats into government if his bloc wins.

"We can unify parties, voters and issues into joint action. That's why we get things done," he told reporters this week.

Critics say his government's agenda is undermining civil liberties while forcing immigrants to conform more closely to Swedish cultural norms or leave the country, urged on by both inducements and penalties.



Rescuers carry a survivor on a stretcher after a ferry sank in the Java Sea, upon arrival at a port in Banjarmasin. AP

Search underway for 129 people after ferry overturns in Indonesia's Java Sea

Associated Press
Jakarta, September 13

THE SEARCH is continuing for at least 129 people missing after a ferry overturned in bad weather in Indonesia's Java Sea on Sunday.

At least 108 people were rescued, and the bodies of six passengers were recovered as the search operation expanded around the vessel's last known position.

The ferry, with more than 240 people on board, was travelling from Surabaya in East Java to Banjarmasin in South Kalimantan province, on Borneo Island, officials said.

The captain had reported rough seas with waves up to 3 metres (10 feet) before issuing a distress call, saying the ship was listing, said I Putu Sudayana, who heads the Banjarmasin Search and Rescue Office. Authorities later received information indicating the vessel

had overturned.

The rescue agency in Banjarmasin said it received a report two hours after contact was lost with the Virgo Transport 8 at about 2 am Sunday.

A rescue ship was headed to the vessel's last known position, the agency said, and by Sunday afternoon authorities were deploying teams supported by a dozen vessels, including four navy ships, and two helicopters. Initial information indicated

the vessel's last known position was in the Java Sea, about 148 kilometres from Banjarmasin. The ship's manifest said it was carrying 243 people — 213 passengers and 30 crew members — although it is common in Indonesia for the number of passengers to differ from the manifest. Sudayana, who is coordinating the search, said teams, assisted by nearby tugboats and other passing vessels, had rescued 107 people and recovered 6 bodies by afternoon.

In a snub to US, Carney pushes for making Canada 'associate member' of EU: WSJ

Reuters
Brussels, September 13

CANADA'S PRIME Minister Mark Carney wants a closer relationship with the European Union and is exploring whether his country could become an "associate member" of the bloc, the Wall Street Journal reported on Sunday.

The EU, which has not been flexible about membership rules in the past, is open to the idea of granting Canada a yet-to-be-created status of associate membership, the newspaper reported, citing unnamed officials both from the EU and Canada.

Canada's embassy in Brussels and spokespeople at the European Commission did not respond to separate requests for comment. Canada's escalating trade war with the United States has added urgency to its strategic pivot towards other trading partners.

Relations between Ottawa and Washington have deteriorated sharply since President Donald Trump returned to the White House last year due



Canada's PM Mark Carney

to disagreements over trade and other issues. The trade dispute has led to tariffs on tens of billions of dollars in cross-border trade.

Canada and the EU are discussing ways of allowing Canada's goods, services and workers involved in strategic supply chains such as energy, AI, defence and critical minerals to move freely, thus effectively shifting the EU border, the Wall Street Journal said.

Canada and the EU are also talking about laying underwater cables, jointly constructing data centres, cloud storage and new satellite networks as well as infrastructure to ship Canadian energy to the EU, the newspaper said.

● MAGGIE GYLLENHAAL-LED JURY ANNOUNCES THE WINNERS AT THE 83rd VENICE FILM FESTIVAL

Woman Unknown wins Golden Lion, Malkovich ‘humbled’ by Best Actor award

Lindsey Bahr
Venice, September 13

WOMAN UNKNOWN, a drama about Denmark in the aftermath of the Nazi occupation directed by May el-Toukhy, won the prestigious Golden Lion at the 83rd Venice Film Festival on Saturday.

The Maggie Gyllenhaal-led jury announced the winners, which included a best actor prize for John Malkovich for his performance in the dark CIA comedy *Wild Horse Nine*.

Malkovich was not in attendance at the ceremony, but he sent a video message, explaining that he is shooting in Montreal. "I am humbled to be chosen for this award which has been given to so many wonderful actors," Malkovich said.

El-Toukhy, who was the only woman to have solely directed a film in the main competition this year, is the eighth woman to have won the festival's top prize.

"To me personally, *Woman Unknown* is about the female body as a battleground," el-Toukhy said. "At the same time the film tells the tale of women who are unseen, invisible and voiceless." She thanked Gyllenhaal for using her voice to shine a light on unequal opportunities for women in moviemaking.

The film, which does not yet have distribution in North America, is centred on a young nanny and housemaid who is about to marry her wealthy employer in the immediate aftermath of the war. But she harbours a secret past intimate relationship with a German soldier that threatens to upend her reputation. The lead, Mathilde Arcel, won the festival's best actress prize. Arcel was visibly emotional as she accepted the award, which she placed on the floor as she spoke as she said it was very heavy. "This is my first lead role in a movie and my first time at a film festival," she said. "I'm extremely honoured."

South Korean auteur Lee Chang-dong's poetic portrait of class and labor, *Possible Love*, won the Silver Lion grand jury prize. *Possible Love* is Lee's first film in eight years, following his acclaimed *Burning*.

"We are living in an era where the meaning of labor is fading and human connections are increasingly becoming severed," Lee said through a translator. "I made this film to ask



Mathilde Arcel, left, winner of the Coppa Volpi for Best Actress for the film *Woman Unknown*, with director May el-Toukhy, winner of the Golden Lion for Best Film for *Woman Unknown*, at the 83rd edition of the Venice Film Festival on Saturday. PTI

what cinema can and should do in times like these. I take this award as a sign that you want me to keep asking these questions."

"NAZA," a harrowing documentary about military strategies employed in the war in Gaza from Israeli filmmakers

Yuval Abraham and Rachel Szor, was awarded a special jury prize. "It's honestly not very easy to stand here, thinking of all the people, the Israeli politicians, the journalists back home who are attacking this film, denying it without even seeing it," Abraham said. "It is really, especially important to us that Israelis watch this film."

The was added to the main competition late — at the request of the filmmakers — and debuted late in the schedule as well, but its impact was felt as it received a record-breaking standing ovation, lasting some 25 minutes, after its premiere.

Shot on the rooftops of Tel Aviv at night in extreme secrecy over three years, *NAZA* features testimony from 24 Israeli military insiders including intelli-

gence officers and soldiers give who insight into the war in Gaza and what they say is the systemic killing of Palestinian civilians.

The jury gave the Silver Lion for directing to Ilya Krzhanovskiy for his film *Dau*, a project about the Soviet physicists who built the atomic bomb that has taken over 20 years to make. Krzhanovskiy, who renounced his Russian citizenship in protest of the war in Ukraine, dedicated the prize to Ukrainians, including his mother who was born there.

French director Stéphane Brizé's won the screenplay prize for his corporate drama *A Good Little Soldier*. Malou Khebeiz was given the Marcello Mastroianni award for emerging actor for her role in Cédric Kahn's *A Place to Heal*, which is set in an adolescent psychiatric

ward in a public hospital.

The jury this year included *The Voice of Hind Rajab* director Kaouter Ben Hania, English composer Daniel Blumberg, French filmmaker Xavier Giannoli, Afghan filmmaker Shahrbanoo Sadat and Hong Kong filmmaker Johnnie To.

Aside from Malkovich's win, the starrier, Hollywood films playing in competition were shut out of the awards, including *Primetime*, *Bunker* and *Ink*. Some look to the Venice Film Festival awards for early indications of who might be in with a shot at Oscar nominations and wins. In recent years, Venice has launched winning best actor campaigns for people like Brendan Fraser and Adrien Brody.

Malkovich has yet to win an Oscar. **AP**

INDIA-EU FREE TRADE AGREEMENT PROVIDES MARKET ACCESS FOR 16 CATEGORIES OF STEEL EXPORTS

India gets 1.64 mt EU steel quota, imports of EU cars may rise 6-fold

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, September 13

AMID TENSIONS over steel exports to the European Union (EU) due to regulations such as the Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM), India has secured 1.64 million tonnes (mt) of steel export quota, across 16 categories, including specialised items like metallic coated sheets and stainless hot-rolled quarto plates, to the EU under the free trade agreement (FTA), as per draft India-EU deal released by Brussels.

The total country-specific quota falls under two parts, whereby the FTA component comes in at 0.69 mt and the most favoured nation component, available to all partner countries, stands at 0.95 mt. This means that only the FTA component of the quota is assured and India's products will have to compete with other countries in the rest of the categories. India's steel exports to the EU currently stand at 4 mt. The TRQs (Tariff Rate

Quota) follow the EU's Steel Overcapacity Regulation, which came into force on July 1 this year. In trade parlance, TRQ is a tool which limits the trade of quantity of a particular item eligible for lower duty. It aims to ensure protection for the EU's steel industry against the effects of global overcapacity. It sets free-of-duty quotas at 18.3 mt, with a 50% duty for out-of-quota imports and a melt-and-pour regime to enhance transparency.

As per an Indian Council for Research on International Economic Relations (ICRIER) note, shifting toward higher-value-added steel products will reduce the applicable CBAM tax burden and improve India's competitive position in the EU market. India has received quotas on several value-added categories too. "This structural transition should be supported by industrial policies that integrate Production Linked Incentives with dedicated research and development funding. Targeted financial and technical assistance, in-

• EU'S STEEL IMPORT RULES

INDIA'S STEEL exports to the EU currently stand at 4 million tonnes

ONLY 17,191 cars were imported by India from the EU in 2025

EU HAS won a first year tariff-rate quota of 100,000 completely built-up internal-combustion and non-plug-in hybrid cars

THE QUOTA rises to 160,000 cars



by the 10th year, but only for cars priced above €15,000

cluding concessional financing, access to clean technology, and investment guarantees, is essential to ease the disproportionate compliance burden on MSMEs," the ICRIER note said.

The draft also showed that EU has won a first-year tariff-rate quota of 100,000 completely built-up internal-combustion and non-plug-in hybrid cars, which is almost six times of the current imports. India imported only 17,191 cars from EU in 2025.

The quota rises to 160,000 cars by the 10th year. But the concession applies only to cars priced above €15,000. For cars priced between €15,000 and €35,000, the in-quota duty falls from 110% to 35% in the first year and down to 10% in the 5th year of the deal coming into effect. To protect Indian car manufacturers, India has given no concession to cars below €15,000. For cars priced above €35,000, tariffs decline from 66% to 30% in the first year

to 10% over the same period. The quota is divided among three price bands, with 43,000 units reserved for cars priced above €50,000 from Year 5 onward.

Think tank Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI) said the EU becomes the second major trade partner after the UK to secure automotive tariff concessions from India under an FTA. GTRI said these precedents could prompt other key trade partners, like Japan and South Korea, to seek similar preferential market access and TRQs.

On electric vehicles (EVs), the draft deal said concessions on battery-EVs, plug-in hybrids and cars using other technologies beginning in 5th year apply only to vehicles priced at €20,000 or more. Their Completely Built Unit quota starts at 20,000 cars in the 5th year, rises to 50,000 in the 10th year and reaches 90,000 from 14th year onwards. Electric and other eligible cars priced below €20,000 get no concession. **FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM**

India's semicon sector draws \$1.4 bn funding

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, September 13

INDIA'S SEMICONDUCTOR sector has attracted \$1.4 billion in all-time equity funding across 281 funded companies, with nearly half of this amount — \$701 million — raised since 2025 alone, according to data from Tracxn. The findings come days ahead of SEMICON India 2026, the country's flagship semiconductor conference and exhibition, which will be held from September 17-19 at Yashobhoomi in Dwarka, New Delhi.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will inaugurate the fifth edition of SEMICON India 2026 on September 17, a mega-event set to bring together global semiconductor industry leaders, government officials, state representatives, and sector experts as India builds on the momentum of its growing semiconductor ecosystem.

Why shareholders cut stake sales in NSE's IPO

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, September 13

THE NATIONAL Stock Exchange's (NSE) much-awaited IPO is finally materialising as the issue is set to begin on September 17 (Thursday) with the price band fixed at Rs 1,700-1,785 per share.

While there is buzz all around the market for the blockbuster IPO, the shareholders selling in this issue have significantly cut their stake sales. The exchange is now expected to raise around Rs 22,562 crore from the offer-for-sale (OFS), down from the Rs 30,000 crore originally expected. The OFS route means any money raised will go directly to the selling shareholders, and the exchange will not receive any proceeds.

So, with the IPO expected to do well, why have these shareholders cut their stake sales, re-

MoSPI Secy: Nominal GDP revised down as informal sector data has improved

NOMINAL GDP estimates under the old 2011-12 series have been revised lower under the new series primarily due to a better picture of the informal sector, Saurabh Garg, Secretary in the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI), said in an interview with **Aanchal Magazine** and **Siddharth Upasani**.

Responding to questions raised about the new 2022-23 base-year GDP series — released back in February — that range from downward revisions and use of producer prices for double deflation, Garg told *The Indian Express* that MoSPI had made the best use of data and surveys and, so far, no one has pointed out "something obvious that we must do in the next (GDP series)". Edited excerpts:

What is the main reason for the reduction in nominal GDP in previous years, not just April-June 2025?

The primary reason for the downward revision in nominal GDP across all overlapping years (2022-23 to 2024-25 and subsequent quarters) is the transition from proxy-based estimates in the old series to direct, empirical annual surveys for the informal sector in the new series.

In the previous series, because regular surveys for the unorganised sector did not exist, MoSPI calculated Gross Value Added (GVA) for unorganised sector by multiplying estimated workforce counts by the Value Added per Worker derived from decadal surveys. This base year GVA was projected forward for over a decade using proxies like formal corporate growth rates, inter-survey growth rates, or historical tax collections as no regular data was available.

With the availability of annual survey evidence, it has become possible to better capture the distinct growth patterns of the informal sector. This has provided a stronger empirical basis for updating the estimates and improving their alignment with observed economic activity. Therefore, the single largest driver of the revision in GDP numbers is the improved measurement of India's informal services sector.



By replacing corporate proxies with actual empirical data from the newly institutionalised Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises (ASUSE) and Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS), MoSPI transitioned to direct annual measurements of unorganised productivity and workforce size.

One criticism that has come from former CEA Arvind Subramanian is that the GDP data does not capture the informal economy properly and we are extrapolating the performance of listed companies. Are we not using ASUSE data for quarterly GDP data?

We are using it. We now have ASUSE on a quarterly basis and PLFS on a monthly basis. So, we are using them; we are not using proxies.

Even in the earlier series, we weren't using only proxies for the informal sector; that was used only between the quinquennial surveys as you had to use something until the next five years. And that was from the previous base years, so that overhang was continuing.

So, the previous 2011-12 series was overestimating GDP?

No, that's the point I am trying to make: it's not an overestimation. GDP is an estimation and you make estimates based on the best data available.

When the 2011-12 and 2004-05 series were estimated, certain indicators were used and later changed, leading to better estimates. Now you have even better estimates. Saying it was an overestimation gives the impression there was a systematic bias. That's

alluding a bit much.

A question raised by Pronab Sen in an interview is the use of producer price data. Is the appropriate data available?

We had shifted the method of calculation to producers in the 2011-12 series of the WPI itself. That's the old series.

The only differences between WPI (Wholesale Price Index) and PPI (Producer Price Index) are that WPI does not have exports and imports and includes taxes and trade margins to some extent. Apart from that, our WPI was akin to a PPI. But we have made those corrections now. So, the data for the past 10 years has been collected from industry and that change was done way back.

Another criticism aimed at the GDP data is that this level of growth is not being 'felt' on the ground.

That, I think we need to recognise, is a larger question. I think the GDP is a very important indicator, no doubt. But there are a lot of other factors, uncertainties, and the global situation which determine how you 'feel'. It's like when someone mentions, 'We feel inflation (rate) should be higher'. So, individually, how you see the prices might be different from when they are aggregated across the country and across different areas. I really wouldn't want to comment on that issue.

Would you say that this new GDP series is by far the most superior so far?

Absolutely, without doubt. Every series, at that time, is the best series. There is no doubt (about that) because we are using the best available data.

Has there been any criticism of the new GDP series that you think is fair?

Obviously, I think this debate is unnecessary. Yeah, that's a good question. I really can't think (of any) because we have made the best use of data, digital data, and surveys. I don't think anyone has pointed out something obvious that we must do in the next (GDP series).

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Gas power generation up 80% amid shortfall

• Gas power: High demand, evening shortage

Year (September 1 to September 9)	Generation from gas-based sources (MU)
2026	1,088.64
2025	603.70
2024	669.94
2023	1,278.98
2022	558.45
2021	1,111.97

SOURCE: NATIONAL POWER PORTAL

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, September 13

AMID AN unusual surge in power demand in September, India is increasingly relying on gas-based power to meet evening shortfall as hydropower generation remains constrained and coal-fired plants are operating at near-maximum levels. Electricity generation from gas-based power plants rose 80.3% during September 1-9 from the same period last year, shows an analysis of data from the National Power Portal.

From September 1 to September 9, gas-based power plants generated 1,088.64 million units (MU) of electricity, compared with 603.70 MU during the same period last year and 669.94 MU during the corresponding period in 2024.

Generation during the period was also higher in 2023 and 2021, at 1,278.98 MU and 1,111.97 MU, respectively. The rise in generation is also reflected in purchases by gas-based power generators in the spot market between September 1 and September 10. Natural gas purchases by the power sector jumped to 30,53,300 metric million British thermal units (MMBtu) between September 1 and September 10, from Rs 1,013/MMBtu to Rs 2,420/MMBtu in the same period. While gas accounts for only a small share in the overall generation mix, it plays a key

balancing role in evening peak hours, when solar output falls.

This has become more significant as hydropower generation has declined amid a rainfall deficit. Unlike coal-fired power plants, gas-based plants offer greater operational flexibility and can ramp up or down quickly to meet fluctuations in demand, although their generation costs are higher. A senior government official said the Centre currently relies on at least 4.5-5.5 gigawatts (GW) of gas-based power to meet the evening shortfall. India has a total installed gas-based power generation capacity of 20.1 GW.

Data provided by Grid India show that on September 9, when peak power demand touched 267 GW, the night-time shortfall was around 77 GW. On September 10, when peak power demand reached 269 GW, night-time shortfall was at 6.1 GW. As per a senior official, coal-based power plants are operating close to their limits, leaving little room to ramp up generation. "Coal-based power plants are running neck-to-neck and there is no space left to ramp it up. No thermal power plant is left to which we can ask to increase generation. Plant load factor of most imported coal-based plants is around 70% or above. At the same time, hydro-power is going down and likely to go down further as reservoir level is very low in southern and western India," the official said.

Queries sent to Ministry of Power did not elicit any response till press time. **FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM**



Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman met Deputy PM and Minister of Economy and Finance of Republic of Uzbekistan Jamshid Kuchkarov on Sunday. The two sides discussed bilateral economic and financial cooperation, sharing views on areas of mutual interest. X/@FINMININDIA

High costs may hit local output: Nokia India chief

Ojasvi Gupta
New Delhi, September 13

INDIA WILL play a bigger role in Finnish telecom gear maker Nokia's global supply chains as the company proposes to make it a manufacturing and export base. But a fairly steep cost disadvantage for some locally-sourced components might emerge as a constraint in greater localisation, according to a senior company executive.

Expanding India's role in Nokia's global supply chain will depend in part on whether local suppliers can become

competitive as other hubs in Asia. "There are disabilities, as we call it. If you buy something from Vietnam or China, we've seen the differential in pricing is in the range of 20% to almost 80%, depending on different components," Vibha Mehra, India Country Manager, Nokia said in an interaction with *FE*.

A stronger domestic supplier base would reduce dependence on imports and help the company manage risks arising from import duties and geopolitical disruptions, Mehra said. *FE*

OpenAI CEO Altman rules out 2026 IPO amid AI safety risks

Los Angeles: OpenAI will not go public in 2026, CEO Sam Altman said in remarks published Saturday, citing safety concerns over AI that render "unacceptable" even a 10% risk that AI could cause extinction by decade's end. "I actually think that, given everything happening with safety, right now would be an ill-

advised moment to go public, and we don't feel pressure on that," he told business magazine *Fortune*. The comments come as more US lawmakers urge new rules to govern AI after warnings from OpenAI rival Anthropic reseeders that rapidly progressing AI may lead to human extinction. **REUTERS**

IBM, Blackberry to Nokia: How humbled tech giants reinvented for a comeback

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, September 13

IN THE electronics business, brands have a track record of reinventing themselves, exiting the products that made them household names and returning in a different avatar. Canadian smartphone maker BlackBerry, once pushed to the brink by the collapse of its handset business, is now a profitable enterprise and embedded software company, with its shares gaining more than 100% over the past year. Nokia, once the world's biggest mobile phone maker, today makes most of its money selling telecom and networking infrastructure, and is positioning itself as a supplier to the artificial intelligence (AI)

data centre boom. International Business Machines (IBM), which helped popularise the personal computer, exited PCs two decades ago and now centres its business around enterprise software, hybrid cloud, AI and high-end computing.

For these companies, the reinvention has followed the pattern that when a consumer hardware business is disrupted or commoditised — primarily for failing to capitalise on changing consumer trends — it forces the company to fall back on less visible technologies it developed along the way, such as software, patents, networks or enterprise infrastructure.

Such reinventions, though, are distinct from technology giants that started out in entirely

different businesses before finding their eventual calling. Samsung, for instance, began as a trading company dealing in dried fish and groceries before entering electronics three decades later, while Nintendo spent much of its early history making playing cards before moving into video games and handheld gaming consoles. Corporate turnarounds have their perils. Like people, according to Aswath Damodaran, Professor of Finance at NYU's Stern School of Business and corporate valuations experts, companies have a life cycle and a firm's valuation should reflect its position along the journey from startup to a declining elder. "More value is destroyed around the world by companies not acting their age.



Nokia led global mobile phone sales in the 2000s but struggled with the smartphone transition. **REUTERS**

Young companies trying to act old and old companies trying to be young again. And there's an entire ecosystem that feeds these companies. Consultants, bankers, essentially the plastic surgeons of business... If I give

you a facelift, you can be young again. And companies keep buying into this notion over and over again," Damodaran, a comeback sceptic, said at a Nordic Business Forum discussion on corporate makeovers. Chang-

ing the business model itself, though, sometimes makes the comeback more durable.

BlackBerry, Nokia's transformation

At its peak, BlackBerry was one of the defining brands of the smartphone era, known for its physical QWERTY keyboards and secure messaging services. But the arrival of Apple's iPhone and Android smartphones rapidly eroded its position. BlackBerry stopped making its own phones in 2016, effectively ending its life as a consumer hardware manufacturer. The company that remains is markedly different, with BlackBerry now focusing on two areas: QNX, its operating system and software plat-

form used in cars and other embedded systems, and secure communications software used by governments and businesses. The transition is beginning to show up in its financial position. BlackBerry recorded a positive cash flow in the quarter ending May for the first time since 2017, and its market value has recovered sharply. It is now worth around \$5 billion, still a fraction of its roughly \$83 billion peak valuation, but a key turnaround for a business that had become synonymous with technological obsolescence.

Nokia underwent an even more dramatic change. The company dominated global mobile phone sales in the 2000s but struggled with the transition to smartphones. In 2014, it com-

pleted the sale of substantially all its handset business to Microsoft. What remained was primarily a telecommunications infrastructure company. Nokia then expanded that business through its acquisition of Alcatel-Lucent, and more recently bought optical networking company Infinera. That infrastructure focus has given Nokia an entry into the AI boom. Its networking equipment connects servers, data centres and increasingly large clusters of AI chips. Nokia has made AI and cloud services one of its strategic priorities, arguing that the rapid construction of AI data centres will increase demand for high-capacity optical and IP networks. **FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM**

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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

• ENERGY

Limits to supply, rising demand: Behind Kerala’s electricity crisis

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, September 13

WITH A few weeks left for the southwest monsoon to withdraw, Kerala is facing an unusual power crisis. The Kerala State Electricity Board (KSEB) has instituted power cuts lasting between 30 minutes and an hour for managing peak-hour energy demand, including nighttime power cuts. Power demand rises at night, as domestic consumers make up 75% of the state’s power connections. The CPI(M)-led Opposition has blamed the ruling Congress for poor crisis management.

Low power generation

According to the KSEB, the state’s average daily demand for power in September 2026 was 5,000 megawatts (MW) as against 3,794 MW in September 2025. The state has met only 4,200 MW, resulting in a shortage. Kerala produces only 1,650 MW and gets 1,500 MW from the Central pool. The Union Ministry of Power periodically allocates power generation capacity to states from its pool of unallocated quota in Central Generating Stations (CGS), which are large power-generating stations. Electricity as a subject comes under the Concurrent List of the Constitution, meaning both the Centre and the states have jurisdiction over it. In general, the state generates only 25% of its actual requirement from various sources, including hydel, solar and wind. In comparison, Andhra Pradesh meets 86% of its power demand from its own generation and Tamil Nadu stands at 50%.

• SOLAR BRIGHT SPOT

Despite low power generation overall, Kerala is a leading state in rooftop solar power generation. Notably, Kerala is a leading state in rooftop solar power generation. Its solar production hit 2,508 MW by the end of May, with a vast majority being rooftop panels. Under the PM Surya Ghar scheme, Kerala has 2.96 lakh installations covering 3 lakh households. But this does not help meet the nighttime demand, given a lack of options to store it.

Storage Systems (BESS) that are yet to become operational.

Poor monsoon

The El Niño effect, or the abnormal warming of surface waters in the equatorial Pacific Ocean that can suppress the Indian monsoon, has been witnessed this year. The southwest monsoon has been weak during the June-September period, with Kerala recording a 26% deficit in seasonal rainfall till September 11. Official data shows that the water storage in all KSEB reservoirs was only at 63.75% of the maximum storage level as of September 10. This has forced the KSEB to throttle down hydropower generation, considering the withdrawal of the monsoon and higher temperatures in the next few weeks.

The poor monsoon and sudden temperature spike since late August have contributed to an increase in power demand, mainly from domestic consumers. The state disaster management authority has put Kerala on alert due to an unusual rise in temperature, with a departure of up to 4 degrees Celsius from normal. Rising night temperatures are further driving long-duration AC usage. The KSEB has also found that the nighttime demand is rising owing to the charging of electric vehicles. Kerala is ready to buy power at higher rates from power exchanges elsewhere, but it faces another grim prospect. Nationally, too, power generation has been low due to factors such as a poor monsoon and low coal stock at power plants. India is also witnessing an unusual surge in electricity demand this September, with peak power demand nearing the level recorded during peak summer.

• POLICY

Outstation students pouring in, why Delhi University doesn’t have enough hostels

Rishika Singh
New Delhi, September 13

THE COLLAPSE of a Paying Guest (PG) accommodation in South Delhi’s Satya Niketan recently, which led to the deaths of at least seven people, including students, has spotlighted the lack of hostels in Delhi University (DU) colleges. Over a PIL on auditing such buildings, the Delhi High Court has flagged “the absolutely inadequate number of hostels available to students”. Satya Niketan is one of the many localities that have emerged as hubs of private student housing over the decades, partly because of their proximity to DU colleges. But students often end up crammed in windowless rooms of badly constructed buildings, with poor quality of food and water.

The gap

The Delhi University Act of 1922 led to the establishment of one of India’s premier central universities. Section 33 states that, “Every student of the University (other than a student who pursues a course of study by correspondence) shall reside in a College a

Hall, or under such conditions as may be prescribed by the Ordinances.” “Hall” refers to student residence that the university provided, maintained or recognised. Over a century later, however, the university has significantly expanded in scale. DU’s Annual Report for 2024-25 notes that from three colleges and 750 students in North Campus, it spans 90 colleges, 20 standalone hostels and over 6 lakh students (those enrolled in person and distance learning) today. Around 2.5 lakh come under the conventional mode, and more than half of the students come from regions other than Delhi, the report said. Not all 90 colleges offer residence, and the university does not offer consolidated data on the total number of hostel seats. Around 2015, it was reported that against an estimated 1.8 lakh students enrolled with DU at the time, only about 9,000 seats were available in its hostels for both undergraduate and postgraduate students. Many colleges coming under the South Campus specially, which was established in 1973 to cater to growing demand, lack hostels, or have hostels that can cater to less

than 10% of the total student population. **The roadblocks** The demand for increasing the number of hostel seats has been raised repeatedly over the years. Haritama Chopra, principal at South Campus’s Maitreyi College, told *The Indian Express* that the share of outstation students has grown with deepening access to technology and the university’s admissions process shifting online about a decade ago. V S Negi, the president of the Delhi University Teachers’ Association (DUTA), said that the organisation has raised the issue in the past, but colleges have cited constraints. “Very little has been seriously done to provide hostel facilities to all students,” Negi told *The Indian Express*. Those within the administration, however, say that even with expansions, need for external accommodation will remain due to the sheer number of outstation students. Bijayalaxmi Nanda, principal of North Campus’s Miranda House, said their limitations range from space constraints to specific regulations that govern construction and expansion: “Every college has a par-



Satya Niketan, where the PG accommodation collapsed. PRAVEEN KHANNA

ticular capacity, based on its landholding size. Then say a building like ours, established in 1948; that is a heritage building in a sense.”

• ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

The problem in OpenAI’s Navier-Stokes ‘solution’



NAMEERA ANJUM

OPENAI’S CLAIM that its artificial intelligence (AI) agents have generated a solution to the Navier-Stokes Millennium Prize Problem has posed a new question for mathematical research: What happens when researchers’ work is fed into AI systems, and “de-identified” data from those interactions is later used to improve the models? The ChatGPT maker said its researchers and AI agents did not access specific user data to solve the problem. But in a blog post on September 8, the company also said it could not rule out the possibility that de-identified data from researchers’ use of its products had helped improve its models.

De-identified data refers to information from which personal identifiers — as to who generated the data — have been removed. But that does not necessarily mean the underlying information, ideas or content have not been used by a model.

The blog post has drawn scrutiny from mathematicians, particularly because New York University professor Tristan Buckmaster and Anthropic researcher Levent Alpöge had been working on related Navier-Stokes research using AI tools, including OpenAI’s Codex.

“De-identified use of a researcher’s conversations blurs the line between assisting someone’s thinking and drawing on it without their knowledge,” Vijay Keswani, assistant professor of computer science at IIT Delhi, told *The Indian Express*.

For Keswani, the issue goes beyond data privacy. It raises questions of “epistemic ownership”: whether AI companies can draw on ideas generated by researchers using their tools without clear acknowledgment or consent.

The controversy comes as AI systems are increasingly being used not just to assist mathematicians but to generate proofs and explore problems that have resisted human researchers for decades.

De-identification

The exact process OpenAI uses for de-identification in this context is not publicly

• A MILLION-DOLLAR PROBLEM

The Navier-Stokes Millennium Prize Problem is one of the seven mathematical problems identified by the Clay Mathematics Institute, carrying a million-dollar bounty for whoever cracks it

THE NAVIER-STOKES equations — which build on 19th-century work by Claude-Louis Navier and George Gabriel Stokes — describe how fluids move, taking into account factors such as pressure, velocity, and viscosity. They are used to model everything from water flowing around a boat and air moving around an aircraft to blood moving through the human body.

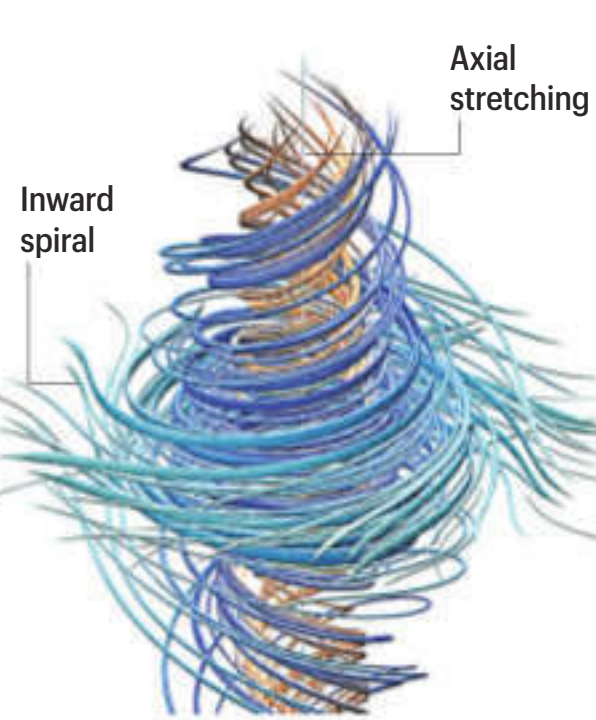
clear. This has become particularly sensitive in mathematics, because researchers increasingly use AI systems to discuss unfinished ideas, test approaches and work through problems before publishing them.

OpenAI has said no specific user data was accessed to solve the Navier-Stokes problem. But that is a narrower claim than ruling out the possibility that de-identified data from users’ interactions may have contributed to training or improving its models.

Keswani said the concern is amplified by the imbalance between individual researchers and AI companies. “Is it fair for a company to have visibility into researchers’ ideas and be able to leverage that visibility, combined with vast computing resources available only to them, to scoop the researchers whose thinking informed the result?” he said. He also pointed to a distinction between what may be permitted under a service’s terms and what researchers may reasonably understand as informed consent: “De-identified” use of a researcher’s conversations may be permitted under terms of service, but that is different from the researcher knowingly consenting to their ideas being used in a competing research effort.

OpenAI’s approach

In its blog post, OpenAI said 10,000 concurrently running AI agents — systems



A vortex demonstrating fluid flow under the Navier-Stokes equations. OPENAI

THE PROBLEM is whether, in three dimensions, a fluid that starts out behaving smoothly can always continue to do so — or whether its behaviour can become infinitely intense in a finite amount of time. In simple terms: if you start with a fluid whose motion is well-behaved, can the equations ever produce a point where the fluid’s velocity becomes infinitely large?

THIS POSSIBILITY is called a singularity or ‘blow-up’. The equations allow different scales and forces within a fluid to interact in complicated ways, and understanding whether those effects can lead to a blow-up is at the heart of the problem.

Blurred lines

De-identified data refers to information from which personal identifiers — as to who generated the data — have been removed.

But that does not necessarily mean the underlying information, ideas or content have not been used by an AI model.

that carry out tasks autonomously — cracked the problem in about 88 hours. The result was then formalised in Lean, a proof assistant used for checking mathematical arguments.

OpenAI said its paper constructs a mathematical fluid that starts from rest and, under a specially constructed smooth external force, develops a point at which the velocity grows without bound in finite time, while its overall energy remains bounded. The result has not yet been independently verified or accepted by the mathematics community. Clay Mathematics Institute continues to list Navier-Stokes among the unsolved Millennium Prize Problems, while the Poincaré Conjecture remains the only one of the seven to have been resolved.

Siddhartha Gadgil, professor of mathematics at IISc Bangalore, told *The Indian Express* that the use of formal verification could be significant as AI-generated mathematics becomes more common. “Lean provided hope for a superhuman level of correctness,” he said. “This can be much better than human evaluation for checking correctness,” although he cautioned that it is not foolproof.

A formally verified proof could also offer something beyond checking whether an argument follows logically from its formal assumptions. “Once we have a proof object in Lean — we can simplify it, view it in many ways, and try to extract insights,” he said.

But formal verification does not answer the question of how an AI model arrived at the result in the first place.

The question of whether an AI system can make a mathematical discovery is not entirely new. In May, one of OpenAI’s internal models successfully tackled the famous planar unit distance problem.

Notably, the previous breakthrough reflected AI’s reasoning and creation capabilities, as the “problem had no answer to retrieve. The model produced a new construction that humans had not found in 80 years of trying,” Sayan Ranu, professor of computer science at IIT Delhi, told *The Indian Express*.

Recognition and rewards

If an AI system produces a proof that humans had not previously found, mathematicians may have to grapple with a question that traditional math research has largely avoided: is producing a correct proof enough to count as mathematical discovery if the machine’s route to that result is difficult for humans to understand?

“We lack reliable tools to trace how a model arrived at a given output,” Keswani said. That makes it difficult to determine whether a result is a near-retrieval of something already present in a model’s training data, a recombination of existing ideas, or genuinely new reasoning.

According to Keswani, current AI systems have not demonstrated complete autonomy in scientific research, because humans continue to frame the problem, define the objective and determine what constitutes a successful result.

For Gadgil, the question also extends to how mathematics recognises and rewards discoveries. “The traditional systems of credit and evaluation, including the Millennium Prize Problems, will face many problems in the age of AI,” he said.

On Russian mathematician Grigori Perelman’s solution to the Poincaré Conjecture, Gadgil said “it was years before other mathematicians worked out the details and accepted this as correct”.

On Friday, 25 Fields Medal winners issued an open declaration titled “A Severe Misalignment of AI in Mathematics”, warning that the AI industry’s push to use mathematical problem-solving as a benchmark risks undermining the discipline’s focus on conceptual understanding and insight.

Meanwhile, OpenAI declined to claim the Millennium Prize for its result, saying that the aim behind releasing it was to report on the progress of its AI models.

• ECONOMY

Copper prices up: Fear of Trump tariffs amid US-China tensions

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, September 13

COPPER PRICES have surged in recent months to hit a record high of \$14,767.5 per tonne on September 9. Three-month copper futures, which are contracts for future purchase, on the London Metal Exchange (LME) remained above the \$14,000-per-tonne mark for most of August before climbing in September.

Why copper price rise matters

The red metal is essential to the modern economy, with uses ranging from housing and manufacturing to power grids, clean energy, artificial intelligence and defence. Thus, its price is often seen as a barometer of economic health. A rise in copper prices is considered a signal of robust economic growth, while falling prices tend to raise concerns about an economic slowdown.

However, the current rally appears to have a different story.

According to industry insiders, the surge is less about expectations of stronger global economic growth and more about concerns over potential tariffs by the United States, which could come into effect from January 2027.

US-led factors

While US President Donald Trump imposed a 50% tariff on semi-finished and derivative copper imports in August last year, refined copper has so far been exempted. However, there is a proposal to impose a 15% tariff on refined copper imports from January, to be increased to 30% in 2028.

“In anticipation of US tariffs, people are selling materials from LME warehouses to warehouses of US COMEX (Commodity Exchange). As a result, there has been a shortage of copper stocks that can be traded on the LME. That is why the futures prices have gone up,” an industry executive told *The Indian Express*.

This has resulted in a huge buildup of

Against trend

Copper price is often seen as a barometer of economic health. A rise in copper prices is considered a signal of robust growth, while falling prices tend to raise concerns about an economic slowdown.

However, the latest rise comes despite prospects of steady global economic growth clouded by trade tensions, the West Asia conflict, and uncertainty.

inventories in the US, two industry sources told *The Indian Express*. “Inventory at LME is currently at 2,65,000 tonnes, and inventory at Shanghai Futures Exchange (SHFE) is at around 63,000 tonnes. However, the inventory of US’ COMEX is at around 7,00,000 tonnes,” an industry source told *The Indian Express*.

Sumit Jhunjhunwala, Vice President & Sector Head, Corporate Sector Ratings, ICRA Ltd, also said that copper prices have remained elevated mainly due to constrained mine supply and the ongoing geographical rebalancing of inventories. “Any major delay or lower-than-expected US tariff could reverse these inventory flows, potentially releasing accumulated stocks into global markets and exerting downward pressure on copper prices,” Jhunjhunwala said.

Copper in US-China trade war

Last year, too, Trump’s imposition of a 50% tariff on semi-finished and derivative copper imports prompted US buyers to

stockpile the metal ahead of its implementation on August 1, heavily contributing to the surge in copper prices.

The move followed a report submitted by the US Secretary of Commerce, which claimed that copper imports threatened to impair US national security.

In 2025, the US imported \$16.2 billion worth of copper products. China accounted for 20% of these imports, followed by Mexico at 17%, the European Union at 14%, Canada at 10% and Vietnam at 8%, as per the US Congressional Research Service.

In April that year, Trump announced a 50% tariff on the full value of semi-finished copper products and a 25% tariff on the full value of copper-intensive derivative products. The latter rate was reduced to 10% where at least 95% of the copper, steel and aluminium used in the product was sourced from the US. These tariff measures are part of broader trade tensions between the US and China, with China being the world’s largest consumer of copper.

details; you have to undertake mapping and reach out to several agencies. An architect has to be involved, and the funding requirement runs into crores,” she added. For instance, with her college building located in the diplomatic enclave of Chanakyapuri, there were restrictions on the number of floors that could be built for the hostel, affecting capacity.

The alternative

With limited hostels, PGs have proliferated, charging monthly rent ranging from Rs 11,000 to as high as Rs 25,000 per person, which can be higher than the annual fee of some courses.

DU Vice-Chancellor Yogesh Singh recently held a meeting on the condition of student residence. Negi said that many colleges have now issued directives to students to provide information about their accommodations and PGs. Nanda said that colleges could be more “actively involved as stakeholders” in the process. For example, students at her college drafted a report on vetting private PGs last year.

Recently, the Delhi government too proposed a draft Bill to regulate PGs.

{ WEEKLY CAPSULE }

Early statin use lowers dementia

STARTING STATINS soon after a Type 2 diabetes diagnosis may do more than protect the heart. In a nationwide Danish study of more than 132,000 people, those who began statin treatment within a year of diagnosis had a 15 per cent lower relative risk of developing dementia over 10 years compared with those who did not start statins. According to the Lancet Commission, nearly half of dementia cases could theoretically be prevented by addressing 14 modifiable risk factors. One of those factors involves managing low-density lipoprotein (LDL) cholesterol beginning in midlife.



Rebuilding brain after stroke

BIOMEDICAL ENGINEERS at Duke University have created an injectable bio-material that may help the brain recover from damage caused by an ischemic stroke. In mice experiments, the material transformed the cavity created by lost brain tissue into a more favourable environment for healing. The treatment recruited the body's own immune cells, encouraged the formation of new blood vessels, supported changes in neural tissue and improved motor function. Emergency treatments can restore circulation and help save brain tissue that is still viable. Once brain tissue dies, even restored blood flow isn't much help.



Semaglutide for mental health

SEMAGLUTIDE, THE drug behind Ozempic and Wegovy, may have benefits that extend well beyond weight loss and diabetes. In a large Swedish study of nearly 15,000 people with bipolar disorder, its use was linked to a 21 per cent lower risk of psychiatric hospitalisation. Researchers think effects on inflammation and brain-related biological pathways could help stabilise mood, though other GLP-1 drugs did not show the same association. These effects could contribute to greater mood stability and a lower risk of relapse. Scientists believe semaglutide helps reduce brain inflammation and cellular stress.



Blueberries help you burn more fat

SCIENTISTS AT Shinshu University in Japan have identified a natural compound found in blueberries, grapes and other berries that may help muscle cells burn excess fat instead of storing it. The compound, pterostilbene, reduced abnormal fat build-up in cultured mice muscle cells by boosting fat breakdown and helping stabilise a key protein involved in fatty acid metabolism. Unlike fat stored under the skin, lipid droplets that accumulate within muscle cells can interfere with normal muscle function and make it harder for the body to efficiently use glucose and fatty acids.



Household toxin triples liver risk

A CHEMICAL COMMONLY used in dry cleaning and found in some household products may be an overlooked threat to liver health. Researchers at the University of Southern California-Health Sciences found that people with detectable levels of tetrachloroethylene (PCE) in their blood were three times more likely to have significant liver fibrosis, a dangerous buildup of scar tissue that can eventually lead to liver failure or cancer. The risk climbed sharply as PCE levels increased, even after accounting for factors such as age, sex, race, education, alcohol use, and metabolic conditions.





MAXIMS OF METABOLISM

DR ANOOP MISRA

EXECUTIVE CHAIRMAN,
FORTIS C-DOC, NEW DELHI

Should we be giving weight-loss drugs to children?

Consider long-term safety, nutrition and affordability, change family habits

A PHASE III TRIAL by Danish drugmaker Novo Nordisk has shown that about four in 10 children with obesity, who received once-weekly semaglutide, were no longer classified as having obesity after 68 weeks. The STEP Young trial, which involved children aged six to under 12 years, found that 40.4 per cent of children treated with semaglutide moved below the obesity threshold, compared with none in the placebo group. The trial met its primary endpoint, showing a greater reduction in body mass index (BMI) among children receiving semaglutide. The drug was studied alongside lifestyle modification. Both the semaglutide and placebo groups followed a reduced-calorie diet and increased physical activity throughout the 68-week trial. More than 85 per cent of the children enrolled had class II or class III severe obesity at the start of the study.

So, how significant is this result? In India, where childhood obesity is an escalating problem, a 40.4 per cent reduction to below the obesity threshold is clinically meaningful. Many children with severe obesity are already on a trajectory toward early-onset Type 2 diabetes, metabolic dysfunction-associated steatotic liver disease (MASLD), hypertension, polycystic ovarian syndrome (PCOS) and premature cardiovascular disease. Achieving substantial weight reduction within roughly a year, particularly in children with severe obesity, may alter their long-term metabolic trajectory and in fact, change their life completely. However, sustained benefits will depend on maintaining healthy behaviours and appropriate long-term management.

Even in the trial, both the semaglutide and placebo groups received a reduced-calorie diet and increased physical activity. Because both groups received lifestyle intervention, the difference between the groups largely reflects the additional effect of semaglutide. The substantial difference in weight reduction, therefore, demonstrates that semaglutide can provide an important incremental benefit when added to lifestyle measures. However, lifestyle modification remains fundamental. Children need to develop sustainable eating, activity, sleep and behavioural habits; medication should complement these changes, not replace them.



Watch eating, sleep, activity; medication is complementary, not a replacement

The bigger question is whether pharmacological treatment should be begun at such a young age? In carefully selected children with severe or clinically significant obesity, pharmacological treatment may help interrupt the progression toward adolescent type 2 diabetes, hypertension, fatty liver and other obesity-related complications. It may also improve physical functioning and reduce some of the psychological burden associated with severe obesity, including weight-based bullying and social stigma which may result in mental stress and depression.

The key concern about pharmacological treatment in primary school-aged children raises legitimate questions about long-term safety, effects on nutrition and development, duration of treatment, affordability and access. There is also a risk of medicalising obesity without adequately addressing the family and environmental factors that drive it. In India, the high cost and limited availability of these therapies mean that they are currently inaccessible to the vast majority of families. Cost consideration is particularly important given the possibility of long term therapy.

The available clinical trial data are reassuring, with no major adverse signals regarding growth or pubertal development over the relatively short period studied (68 weeks). However, these data cannot answer questions about decades of exposure, and long-term surveillance remains essential. Nutrition deserves particular attention in India because obesity can coexist with micronutrient deficiencies — the so-called double burden of malnutrition. Semaglutide markedly reduces appetite and food intake, so adequate intake of protein, micronutrients and other essential nutrients must be ensured during periods of rapid growth, when linear growth and acquisition of peak bone mass are especially important. Such attention to nutrition must continue during treatment and when treatment is being withdrawn.

Management should, therefore, be comprehensive: appropriate assessment of glucose metabolism, lipids and liver health; improvement in physical activity and fitness; adequate protein and micronutrient intake; reduction in excessive screen time and ultra-processed foods; and attention to mental health. Most importantly, parents need to modify household eating and activity patterns alongside the child.

Anonna Dutt

FOR NEARLY a year, 49-year-old Kerala lawyer Majida MA has started her mornings with a phone call from a friend. The call is a reminder to take the medicine that, in her words, is keeping her breast cancer at bay. After breakfast, Majida takes three tablets of the targeted therapy drug ribociclib, sold as Kryxana in India and Kisqali globally, and begins work from home. She has not been able to work from the office next to her house because it is not air-conditioned. The drug causes itching and mood swings, she says, making it difficult for her to work in the heat. "Other than that, and sometimes hair fall, body ache and some discolouration of the skin, I actually do not feel like a cancer patient at all," she says.

The tablets, however, come with a cost that is increasingly difficult to ignore. Each strip of 21 pills costs about Rs 25,000. Majida needs three strips a month, taking her monthly drug bill to around Rs 75,000–80,000 — a large part of her income as a practising lawyer. "How can I manage to spend Rs 80,000 every month just for the medicine?" she asks. "There are other expenses such as hospitalisation for chemotherapy, tests and doctor consultations. Then there are the fees for my two children — one is in the first year of college and the other in sixth standard." Her husband and both their parents also live with the family. Her elderly parents and in-laws have their own age-related illnesses and medication expenses. "All of this adds up," she says.

Initially, her health insurance covered the cost of the medicine. In recent months, however, her claims have been denied, leaving her to pay out of pocket. The fear is not simply financial. Majida knows what can happen when the cost of treatment becomes impossible to sustain. A relative with the same type of cancer had been prescribed the same medicine and took it for nearly a year before stopping because of the financial burden. She died later. "I do not want to stop taking this medicine," Majida says, who has now become a petitioner in a case before the Kerala High Court seeking greater access to expensive cancer medicines.

A legal battle over access

The case was originally filed in 2022 by a retired bank employee, who has since died. The Kerala High Court subsequently converted it into a Public Interest Litigation (PIL). Earlier this year, the Supreme Court registered a suo motu petition and directed the High Court to resolve the matter expeditiously. At the heart of the case is a question that is both legal and medical: How can patients gain access to an effective cancer treatment when the patented drug is prohibitively expensive? The petition seeks the use of provisions under the Patents Act that could allow the government to use the patented medicine or facilitate a compulsory licence for a generic manufacturer in circumstances such as a national emergency.

Dr Arathi PM, faculty at the School of Indian Legal Thought at Mahatma Gandhi University, became interested in the case after her friend Majida joined it. "While patients are necessary to motivate companies to develop newer therapies, if you look at the turnover of companies holding the patent for this molecule, they are making huge profits while patients are unable to access it," she says.

The problem, she says, is not necessarily that a drug does not exist but that its price can determine who gets the opportunity to receive it. The contrast became particularly stark when Arathi posted about the case online. An acquaintance in Oman contacted her to say she had the same type of cancer and was able to access the medicine through her husband's government coverage.



GETTYIMAGES

This cancer drug costs Rs 80,000 per month

Why a survivor fears she may have to give it up

For Kerala lawyer Majida MA, three tablets every morning have become a lifeline. She has now joined a legal battle seeking better access to a breast cancer drug that eats into her income



FIGHTING THE GOOD FIGHT: Kerala lawyer Majida MA

"But there were four other women undergoing treatment for the same type of cancer with her who were never even prescribed the medicine by the doctors because they knew they would not be able to afford it," Arathi says. That raises another question: what happens when affordability begins to influence treatment choices?

The medical question

The current debate before the court includes whether patients such as Majida could instead be treated with palbociclib, another drug in the same class for which cheaper generic versions are available. Both ribociclib and palbociclib are CDK4/6 inhibitors. They block proteins called cyclin-dependent kinases 4 and 6, which play an important role in the growth and division of cancer cells. But being in the same drug class does not automatically make two medicines interchangeable.

While the court asked National Cancer Institute, Jhajjar, and Chittaranjan National Cancer Institute, Kolkata to respond on whether the medicines can be used inter-



SCAN THE QR CODE TO READ MORE HEALTH SPECIAL STORIES

changeably, other doctors have weighed in on possibilities. Dr R Ravi Kannan, director of Cachar Cancer Hospital and Research Centre in Assam, says the evidence for the two drugs differs depending on the setting in which they are used.

Palbociclib has shown benefit in metastatic breast cancer, he says, but clinical trials have not demonstrated the same benefit when it has been used as supportive treatment after surgery for early-stage breast cancer. Ribociclib, along with another CDK4/6 inhibitor, abemaciclib, has shown gains in disease-free survival in selected patients with early-stage disease.

"Early-stage breast cancer is treated with curative intent," Dr Kannan says. "The goal is to eliminate any microscopic disease that could later metastasise. Effective adjuvant therapy or treatment given after surgery to reduce the risk of the cancer returning can drastically improve long-term survival," he adds. Dr Abhishek Shankar, an oncologist at the All-India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), Delhi, stresses that the choice of treatment has to be made in the context of the individual patient. "Ribociclib and palbociclib are both in the same CDK4/6 inhibitor group but they should not be considered automatically interchangeable," he says. "Both the drugs have different clinical evidence, approved indications, treatment duration and outcome data, particularly between early and metastatic disease." The decision, he says, should be based on the disease setting, clinical evidence, toxicity, availability and affordability.

The distinction matters because breast cancer is not one disease with one treatment. It is the most common cancer among women in India, with 2.37 lakh cases and more than 96,000 deaths reported in Globocan 2024 data. Majida's cancer — hormone receptor-positive (HR-positive) and HER2-negative — is the most common biological subtype. This is a common type in which the cancer cells are fuelled by hormones such as oestrogen or progesterone but do not have

unusually high levels of the HER2 protein, which can make the cancer aggressive.

But, as Shankar points out, that does not mean every patient with HR-positive, HER2-negative disease requires a CDK4/6 inhibitor. "HR-positive, HER2-negative disease represents a large proportion, roughly 70 per cent, of breast cancers, but this does not mean all these patients require a CDK4/6 inhibitor," he says. "The drugs are used in selected patients, particularly those with advanced/metastatic disease and, for certain cases, carefully defined high-risk early breast cancer." Even the National Cancer Institute, Jhajjar, in its affidavit concluded: "Both agents are acceptable preferred agents endorsed by multiple cancer societies across the world." But, it added the caveat that this conclusion applied only to metastatic, advanced stage breast cancer and not early stage breast cancer.

Affordability vs treatment

For patients who do need these medicines, the availability of cheaper alternatives can make a significant difference. "Access has improved substantially, particularly after the availability of generic palbociclib, which can be obtained at a much lower price than the innovative product," Dr Shankar says. But even a lower price can remain unaffordable when treatment continues for months or years. "Long-term monthly treatment remains a significant financial burden for many Indian families, especially when treatment is predominantly out of pocket," he adds.

That is the reality Majida is confronting. She says there is little scope for her to simply work more to meet the rising costs. She is already trying to maintain her legal practice while undergoing cancer treatment and managing side effects. For now, she continues taking the three tablets every morning. "I don't want to give up," she says. The question, therefore, is larger than one patient's monthly bill. It is about drugs that exist versus privilege that can claim them for use.

THE COST OF therapy

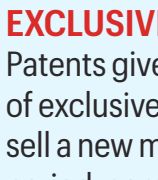
WHY ARE SOME CANCER MEDICINES SO EXPENSIVE?

The price of a cancer therapy is shaped by far more than the cost of making a tablet. Several factors can influence what patients eventually pay



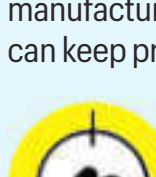
RESEARCH & DEVELOPMENT

Developing a new cancer drug can take years of laboratory research, clinical trials and regulatory review. Pharmaceutical companies seek to recover these costs from medicines that reach the market.



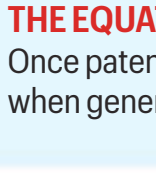
PATENTS AND MARKET EXCLUSIVITY

Patents give companies a period of exclusive rights to make and sell a new medicine. During this period, competition from generic



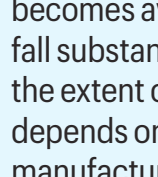
TARGETED MEDICINES

Many newer cancer drugs are designed to act on specific biological pathways involved in cancer. These medicines can be considerably more expensive than older, widely used drugs.



GENERICS CAN CHANGE THE EQUATION

Once patent protection ends, or when generic competition



INSURANCE MATTERS

The amount a patient actually pays depends not only on the listed price but also on health insurance coverage, reimbursement rules and whether the medicine is included in a particular policy.



THE RESULT FOR PATIENTS

Cancer treatment is rarely limited to the cost of one medicine. Hospitalisation, diagnostic tests, consultations, surgery, chemotherapy, radiation and supportive medicines can all add to the financial burden. This is why access to cancer treatment is increasingly discussed not only as a medical issue, but also as a question of affordability and financial protection.



WHAT DOES 'TARGETED CANCER THERAPY' MEAN?

Unlike traditional chemotherapy, which can affect both cancerous and healthy fast-growing cells, targeted cancer therapies are designed to interfere with specific molecules or biological pathways that help cancer cells grow, survive.

Think of cancer cells as having certain molecular "switches" that help them

multiply. Targeted medicines aim to identify and block some of these switches. Because they act on particular features of cancer cells, they can sometimes affect healthy cells less broadly than conventional chemotherapy. However, they are not free of side effects, and their benefits vary depending on the type and biology of the cancer.

Idea Exchange

MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 14, 2026

NEW S M A K E R S I N T H E N E W S R O O M

WHY ASHWINI BHIDE

Ashwini Bhide is the first woman municipal commissioner in the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation's (BMC) 133-year old history. Bhide has spearheaded Mumbai's most ambitious infrastructure projects including the Mumbai metro project and the coastal road project, gaining her the moniker of Mumbai's infra woman. Her appointment also comes at a time when the elected representatives return to Mumbai after a hiatus of four years with the Bharatiya Janata Party and Shiv Sena-led the Mahayuti regime being at the centre of BMC's affairs

Nayonika Bose: Mumbai's road network is barely comparable with other cities in the country. Why do you think we have not been able to develop Mumbai's roads?

It is not enough that we have just have a budget. Mumbai is a linear city. It is peninsular in nature and on three sides, there is the ocean, so we cannot expand. We have 448 sq km of suburb, with large chunks of the forest and the national park in it along the Coastal Regulation Zone (CRZ). So, the actual area available for development and road network is less. If you compare it to Delhi, which has a road network of more than 28,000 km, Mumbai has only 2,050 km. We have tried to bridge this by exploring underground corridors such as the Goregaon Mulund Link Road (GMLR) and the coastal ring road which will connect Marine Drive and Virar. As for the issue of road quality, we are concretising approximately 700 km. The road quality also gets affected due to frequent trenching. Unlike other cities, all utility corridors run beneath the road surface. We have roughly 27 to 30 utilities and they need to be constantly repaired or augmented for which trenching is critical. Currently, we are developing a trenching policy which will be designed to incentivise the use of dedicated ducts. The infrastructure deficit will have to be made up by public transport. For that, the entire metro network will need to be completed, which is expected in two-three years.

Pratip Acharya: The fleet of BEST buses is shrinking. Are we over investing in metros and do we need to focus more on other modes of transport for the last-mile connectivity?

We cannot say that there is an over investment in the metro as that is absolutely required. But I can say that there is an under investment in buses or other last-mile transport. However, the problem is the size of the fleet. In Mumbai, the bus fleet size is roughly 2,600-2,800 while the city needs 7000 to 10,000 buses. For a city where maximum trips are made on foot, our pedestrian infrastructure remains extremely poor. We are addressing this with our pedestrian-first policy, where we are prioritising by clearing encroachments near stations. Last-mile connectivity is not a simple, linear thing but a mix of multiple things. Action needs to be taken by different authorities, even people have to change certain habits.

Pratip Acharya: Despite BMC's mammoth budget, Mumbai always ranks low on the national Swachh Survekshan list. How is BMC working to improve cleanliness?

We collect 7,000 metric tonnes of solid waste and 8,000 metric tonnes of construction debris daily. The challenge lies in transporting it to the processing grounds and ensuring that nothing is left on the road or on open spaces. Our biggest challenge is that 40 per cent of our population is living in slums where waste collection is difficult. Since these are not organised households, they do not put their dustbins outside even if we go there daily at 7 am. We have identified garbage vulnerable points (GVPs). There are roughly 186 GVPs in the city alongside 200 garbage hotspots. We are attempting to eliminate them by deploying NGOs and using digital applications. But, as citizens, we also need some self-discipline and should not litter.

Shubhangi Khapre: The 2005 floods in Mumbai highlighted the absence of adequate storm water drainage. How challenging are mitigation efforts given different climatic challenges?

We are far better equipped today than we were in 2005. However, the challenge of climate change, erratic and extreme weather events still looms. Currently, our drainage has the capacity to handle 55 mm rainfall in an hour, which is more than adequate in normal situations. However, when rainfall crosses more than 100 mm to 300 mm in low-lying areas within a short timespan, then this network may fall short. There are temporary storage solutions too, such as underground tanks, identification of areas with water-logging and restricting people's movement there. Additionally, we have submitted an urban flood mitigation plan to the Central government which will be funded under the National Disaster Relief Fund. The central part is early warning for which we have been leveraging help from IIT Bombay which gives us three day's localised predictions daily. Accordingly, we ensure that the pumps are working, traffic police are informed and rerouting is done.

Mohamed Thaver: There is also anxiety among people about the boom of data centres. Many are concerned about the water they use.

The state government has a Green Data Centre Policy, which mandates data centres to use recycled water. Since data centres are also major consumers of energy, the policy requires them to procure or generate green energy as well. Many of the new data centres coming up in Navi Mumbai and surrounding areas fall under CIDCO and the Navi Mumbai Municipal Corporation, which have water treatment plants. These plants treat sewage, and the treated water undergoes further processing through what

ON STATE OF MUMBAI'S ROADS

The road quality gets affected due to frequent trenching. We have roughly 27 to 30 utilities that need constant repair. We are developing a trenching policy to incentivise the use of dedicated ducts



ON DATA CENTRES AND WATER

The state government has a Green Data Centre Policy, which mandates data centres to use recycled water... So, in local areas where there are conflicts, there are ways of addressing them

'You cannot say that data centres should not be there. It creates jobs, but regulations will be put in place'

Ashwini Bhide, Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation Commissioner, on managing floods and air pollution, addressing concerns about data centres and what other cities can learn from Mumbai. The session was moderated by Nayonika Bose, Senior Correspondent, and Pratip Acharya, Principal Correspondent, *The Indian Express*



Ashwini Bhide, Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation Commissioner, at the Mumbai office. GANESH SHIRSEKAR

is known as advanced tertiary treatment. The water can then meet very high quality standards, while data centres may carry out additional treatment as required for their operations. Therefore, data centres do not necessarily depend on potable water supplied by municipal corporations. In Mumbai, seven sewage treatment plants (STPs) are currently under construction. Mumbai requires around 4,100 MLD (million litres per day) of water every day, of which approximately 2,400 MLD is converted into sewage. Of the 2,400 MLD, we have so far been treating it only through secondary treatment before releasing it into the sea. However, with the new STPs, this sewage will undergo primary, secondary and tertiary treatment. We expect to recover around 1,200 MLD of water that can be reused in the city for non-potable purposes. This water can be supplied to data centres and other organisations that require water for non-potable uses. It could also eventually be used in households, although that would require separate plumbing systems.

Zeeshan Shaikh: The other concern is the increase in ambient temperature and the noise the data centres generate. In places like Thane, data centres are coming up near residential areas. Do you think there is a need for a policy on where data centres should be located?

Mumbai attracts so many data centres due to undersea marine cables that are located near Mumbai and (also in) Chennai. You cannot say that data centres should not be there, we have to co-exist. We have to draw boundaries between the habitable areas and the industrial areas. So, in areas where there are conflicts, there are ways of addressing them. It is a business, it generates jobs, it creates an ecosystem for development. But regulations will be put in place.

Pratip Acharya: There's more

redevelopment in the suburbs. Why has south Mumbai not seen as much redevelopment?

Redevelopment will come to the city because ultimately it is an economic activity and the function of profitability also plays a part. In our existing scheme, we have guaranteed free housing for people. Even for cessed buildings (pre-1969 structures), there is free housing. Once you give a house free, then it needs to be compensated by somebody. Due to this, even though the city has redevelopment potential, developers weigh their options as to where it would be financially viable. In some areas, there are high restrictions, in some areas, land becomes an issue. In south Mumbai, cessed property, tenanted properties, especially those on BMC and state lease are getting redeveloped but private

properties will weigh their options.

Nayonika Bose: These projects also churn out large quantum of Construction and Demolition (C&D) waste. Is the city really equipped to handle it and how do we bridge the capacity?

We generate almost 8,000 metric tonnes of C&D waste every day and BMC themselves have set up plants up to 1200 MT. But, the generated C&D waste is often dumping illegally in old quarries or protected government land. That now needs to be streamlined. What we need is recycling because often C&D waste gets mixed with wood, PoP, stones and bricks. Therefore, we need facilities to segregate and reuse the materials, so that they can go back into other construction work. We have also prepared a portal on the lines of



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ON CREATING OPEN SPACES

Where land is scarce, we have to be innovative. Currently, the coastal road gardens are being planned. With that, we will create almost 70 hectares, for sports, performances and open gardens where people can gather or just loiter



in its first project, worked with consultants but later, it developed its own capacity to execute and plan projects. Now it itself is a consultant. I keep telling my BMC officers that there are certain areas where only BMC works, nobody else. So, we should be in a position to start our own consultancy at some point of time. Today, DMRC's major revenue comes from their consultancy services because you can't earn revenue only through tickets.

Nayonika Bose: The change in reservation of Neville D'Souza football ground has once again brought to fore the lack of open spaces in Mumbai. Despite being a coastal city, we have not even been able to develop our seafront to the best capacity. How is the BMC planning to bridge this gap?

In a city where land itself is a scarcity, we have to be innovative in creating spaces. Currently, the coastal road gardens are being planned and that is being beautifully designed. With that, we will create almost 70 hectares, for sports, performances and just as open gardens where people can gather or just loiter. These are the opportunities which we should utilise.

Zeeshan Shaikh: Do you think we're doing enough for green cover and parks for the residents in Mumbai?

Given the area we have, our per capita green space is more than enough. But yes, we can always do better. As city planners, we need to strike a balance with the reality of Mumbai. We have around 30 to 32 lakh trees in the city, when we include trees from Aarey forest. Out of that 2 lakh trees are along the road. This number is good, but equitable distribution is an issue.

Dharavi has less tree cover, which leads to heat generation, making the standard of living even poorer. But, we can do better. We are also mandated to have compensatory re-plantation when trees are required to be cut. There are times we are required to plant 200 trees for five trees cut. Unfortunately, for re-plantation there is no land available, and we plant in the peripheral areas like Panvel or Palghar. In BMC, we have now said that whenever large development happens, and certain amenity plots open up, they will be inventoried and put on GIS. Among those plots, some will not be put to any recreational use but will remain available as gardens. Small plots with trees will therefore be available across the city. With Miyawaki plantation, we can plant almost 1 lakh trees on these plots.

Sadaf Modak: There are avoidable deaths every monsoon due to landslides and building collapses. Is there any mechanism that needs to be put in place, like forceful evacuation or temporary accommodation?

Yes, we will at some point look at forceful evacuation. But temporary accommodation is not available as an option in all cases. There is a system for that. From our side, we have now decided, along with the Collector, that after monsoon, we will find out some of the most vulnerable places, and we will try to demolish some of these structures in advance. We will request people to move from those areas, because there is no other alternative.

Ritika Chopra: If Mumbai were to become a blueprint for development for other megacities, what is the one lesson other cities could emulate and one lesson that they need to avoid?

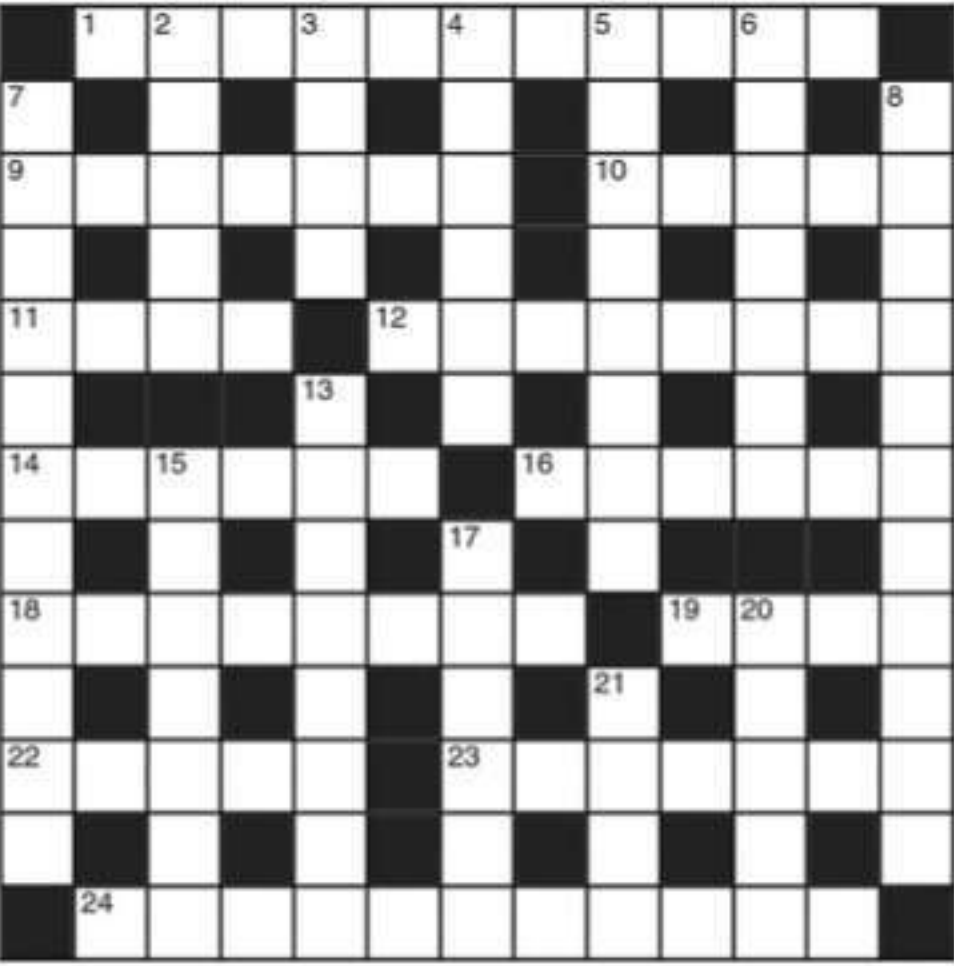
I think the first thing is the metro master plan. It was prepared in 2004, and done in a very scientific way. MMRDA conducted a comprehensive transport study for the entire MMR region. They created various futuristic scenarios and picked the most realistic one. So what other cities should do is make a detailed plan for their infrastructure, see where exactly the city is going, what its strong points are, what its weak points are, and which areas need a boost.

Another strong point is that why we complain about the multiplicity of agencies, Mumbai has various agencies which have the nimbleness and action orientation to quickly gear up for taking on big projects. Maybe other cities can think of having specialised agencies or project implementation agencies. What is to be avoided is probably that you can't — you should not — take up so many projects at one go. You should at least plan in such a way that some projects are completed within a short span of time, and then you take up further projects.

Pratip Acharya: How is the BMC looking at addressing air pollution?

We cannot look at it in isolation. One of the biggest reasons for air pollution, which is not discussed enough, is the air movement in the whole MMR region and how the wind and dust from these areas circulate. What lies in our hands is how to control the pollution. First is construction activity and the BMC is now monitoring more than 3,000 construction sites where we have mandated full covers, AQI monitors. Our officials have a dashboard to monitor the compliance. Even the RMC plants and sites are now fully covered. Another key factor is vehicular pollution and therefore, the shift to public transport, electric vehicles is also very important. It will happen with time.

CROSSWORD



ACROSS
1 Seen in a list prepared but it's not necessary (11)
9 Married wrong lover (7)
10 Permission to depart (5)
11 Capricious youngsters (4)
12 State of a malformed holm oak (8)
14 Pub arranged to have meals in every bar (6)
16 This seat is uncomfortable for a nap (6)
18 Blunt lie about a report (8)
19 Go to get some citrus flavouring (4)
22 Reversible revolver (5)
23 Stop for Jack to revive (5,2)
24 Informal description of a promotional competition? (4-3-4)

DOWN
2 He has no settled occupation (5)
3 His place was among the lesser fellows (4)
4 Well-known bather's shout (6)
5 Misinformed I led a lot astray (4,1,3)
6 Bewildered by how a bankrupt business was run (2,1,4)
7 Bet on songs being out-of-date (4,7)
8 Not a crime but it may need a lawyer's help (5,6)
13 Happy-go-lucky benefit of a welfare state? (8)
15 Brace of fresh lobster (7)
17 It may bring colour to a typist's work (6)
20 They're used for cutting borders (5)
21 A country one's entered before (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6092 ACROSS: 1 Bunion, 4 Bludgeon, 9 Almost, 10 Aglitter, 12 Reed, 13 Smear, 14 Sty, 17 Clears the air, 20 Above average, 23 Bets, 24 Aspen, 25 Crop, 28 Extremes, 29 Frieze, 30 Suspense, 31 Census
DOWN: 1 Boat race, 2 Numbered, 3 Oust, 5 Luggage label, 6 Drip, 7 Estate, 8 Nurses, 11 Empty vessels, 15 Arabs, 16 Liver, 18 Fairness, 19 Helpless, 21 Abbess, 22 States, 26 Here, 27 Urge.

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Reading is to the _ what exercise is to the _ - Sir Richard Steele (4,_,4)

AROID

EOOWDD

ADDNY

ENOTBM

- Sir Richard Steele

ANSWER: Reading is to the mind as the body is to the body.

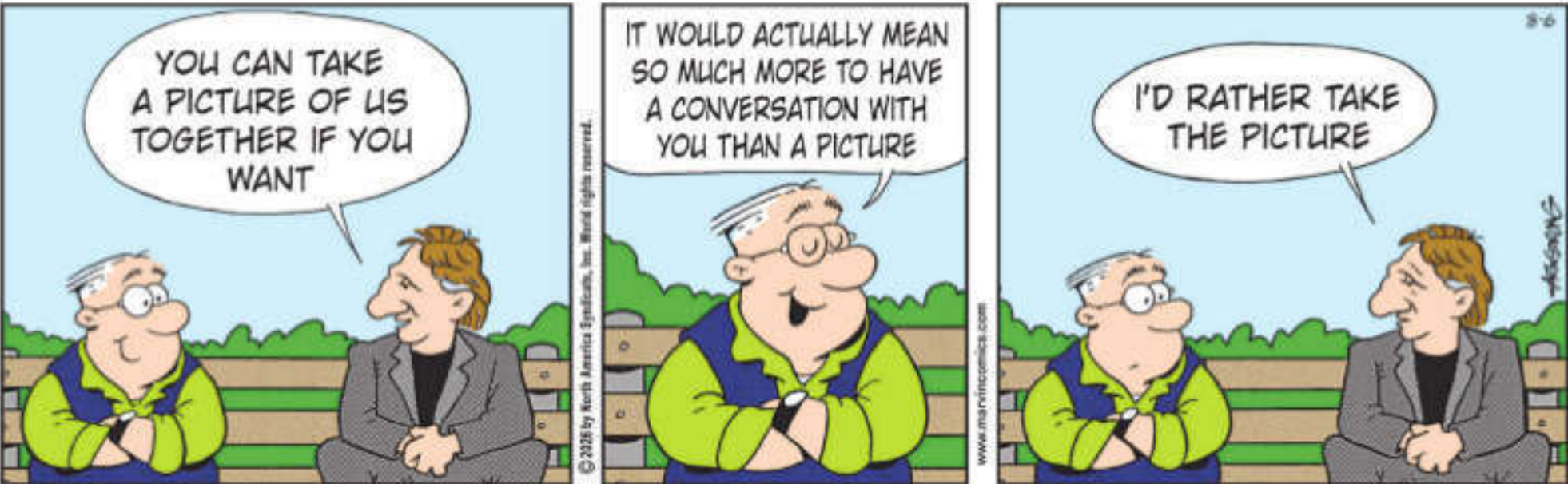
OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



SUDOKU 6441

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 1s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6440

		2	4		8	6		
5	8		9			2		
		6		5	2		7	3
7			6	2				8
	3						9	
4				1	9			5
6	2		8	9		1		
		7			1		8	4
		5	3		7	9		

BY MICHAEL FRY & T LEWIS

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): You'll be pleased with how much you accomplish today. This is because Mars is boosting the Sun while it is travelling through your House of Employment. Tonight: Check your finances.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Your choices are wide open today. You can work in a productive way. Or you can use this same driving energy to explore sports events, fun activities with kids, the arts, the entertainment world or the hospitality industry. Tonight: Listen and cooperate.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): You have lots of energy to make home improvements today. You also might be more involved with a parent than usual. Meanwhile, relations with co-workers are wonderful. Tonight: Get organised.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Enjoy a short trip. Take care of appointments and errands. Explore your ability to sell, market, talk or teach. Oh yes, you're bright-eyed and bushy-tailed! You're active, confident and keen to express yourself. People will listen to you. Tonight: Socialise.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): You have strong moneymaking ideas, plus the energy to make money. You might do this in a public way or quietly behind the scenes. This is also an excellent day to entertain at home, because relations with family members are loving. Tonight: Relax at home.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): This is a positive day. The Sun is in your sign getting a boost from fiery Mars, while the Moon is lined up with Venus in your House of Communications. You're in the right place, at the right time, saying the right thing to the right person. Tonight: A lively discussion.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Today you might choose to play things low-key and work behind the scenes. Nevertheless, you'll accomplish a lot. With Mercury in your sign, you're keen to express your ideas to others. Meanwhile, shopping is appealing for you. Tonight: Check your belongings.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Today the Moon is lined up with Venus in your sign, which is a winning combination. You're charming with everyone. This is why everyone wants to be in your company. Tonight: You win.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): You make a strong impression on everyone today because the Sun is at the top of your chart casting you in a flattering spotlight, while Mars amplifies this energy, making you virtually shine in the eyes of others. Tonight: Enjoy time alone.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Grab every chance to travel today or do something to expand your horizons. Enjoy learning through film, study or meeting new people. You'll also get a kick out of the stimulation of a new place, anything different. Tonight: Be friendly.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Discussions about shared property, taxes, debt and insurance issues will be lively today. And because both the Moon and Venus are lined up at the top of your chart, not only will you be noticed, it is likely that these discussions will go in your favour. Tonight: You're admired.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): You might attract someone to you today who is forthright and direct. However, it will also encourage fun socialising and physical activity. Tonight: Explore and learn something new.

Government of Madhya Pradesh
Higher Education Department,
State Project Directorate, Satpura Bhavan,
Ground Floor Wing "Khao", Bhopal (MP)

Tender Notice -NIT No: 146/SPD/RFP/2025/Comp-lab 323 HEI & Science-lab 200
HEI/Retender 11-09-2026

The State Project Directorate (SPD), Higher Education Department, Madhya Pradesh invites Request for Proposal for Selection of Agency for **Supply, Installation, Commissioning and testing of 20-seater Computer Lab on Turnkey Basis at 323 Govt College & Digitalization of Science Lab on Turnkey Basis at 200 Govt College under Department of Higher Education, Bhopal, Madhya Pradesh.** Interested bidders are requested to view the mptender.gov.in e-Portal for the Bid information from **11-09-2026** onwards. Last date of Submission date **05-10-2026**. This Tender Notice Information will also be available on <https://www.highereducation.mp.gov.in>

Sd/-
Commissioner and Project Director
State Project Directorate Higher Education Department

G-18527/26

indianexpress.com

I arrive at a conclusion not an assumption.

Inform your opinion with detailed analysis.

The Indian EXPRESS
JOURNALISM OF COURAGE

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Shehbaz @ Nehna, S/o: Aas Mohammad, R/o: Village- Jharokadi, PS Bicchor, Distt. Nuhun Mewat, Haryana** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.: 606/2023, U/s: 411 IPC, P.S. Sunlight Colony, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Shehbaz @ Nehna** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Shehbaz @ Nehna** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Shehbaz @ Nehna of P.S. Sunlight Colony, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **14.10.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Divyram Lila
JMFC-07, South East Distt., Room No. 508, Saket Courts, New Delhi

DPI/12994/SE/2026

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

BORDER SECURITY FORCE
CONSTABLE BIKRAM SINGH
50 BN BSF
26.02.1973 – 14.09.2002

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Bikram Singh on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries in a fierce encounter with militants in Budgam area, J&K and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE

Veer Balidani	DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Head Constable Pritam Singh of 10 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice in an encounter with militants on 14 September 1989. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
Head Constable Pritam Singh	
10 Bn	
21-1-1941 To 14-9-1989	

Veer Balidani Naik Krishna Mohan Jha 113 BN 12-6-1958 To 14-9-1995	Veer Balidani Lance Naik Jagdish Singh 113 BN 8-3-1961 To 14-9-1995	Veer Balidani Constable C.H. Rameshwar Rao 113 BN 20-5-1972 To 14-9-1995

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to three valiant troopers of 113 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely countering an ambush by insurgents on 14 September 1995 in Tripura. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.

CENTRAL INDUSTRIAL SECURITY FORCE
SI/EXE BIRENDR KUMAR SINGH
CISF UNIT HPCL VIZAG

CISF proudly remembers the supreme sacrifice of this brave-heart. On this day, he laid down his life at the altar of duty while saving the lives of his colleagues and employees of HPCL when explosion in LPG Pipeline occurred. His courage and bravery would remain an abiding source of inspiration for the force. The force will remain eternally indebted to him for his noble deed

INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY, CHENNAI - 600 038

Tender Notice No. ICF/PCMM/EOT/37/2026 Dated: 11.09.2026

The following e-tenders are published in IREPS website. Firms are requested to login to www.ireps.gov.in and quote against these tenders. Manual quotations will not be entertained for these tenders. Closing and Opening time for all tenders are 14.15 hrs. Hindi version of tender notice is available on website www.icf.indianrailways.gov.in.

Sl.No.	Tender No	Tender Title	Quantity	Due Date/ Time
01.	07262438	S&I C/S OF SEATS-MEMU-J&NDMC	100 Sets	25/09/2026
02.	04261067	Molykote P40 - Metal free Paste V1 (or) Molykote 111 for VBFS coaches	449 kg	25/09/2026
03.	01265386	SS and SC CENTER LATHE All Geard Type	2 Nos	28/09/2026
04.	07262425	UNF HINGE BRACKET FOR LSCNEOG	212 Sets	29/09/2026
05.	06262311	Rate Contract for VB LED LIGHTS	Refer IREPS Web site	29/09/2026
06.	08261775	VCB for VB SPARE	15 Sets	30/09/2026
07.	06261551	UIC RUBBER VESTIBULE	788 Nos	01/10/2026
08.	03262038	SS SHEET SUS 301L-DLT - DULL FINISH	Refer IREPS Web site	01/10/2026
09.	02261781	SET OF MOUNTING BRACKET FOR BIO TOILET TANK (VB SLEEPER MC, TC, NDTCT)	179 Sets	05/10/2026
10.	02261910	S & I BODY SHELL ITEMS, PARTITION FRAMES & FLOOR SUPPORTS	167 Sets	06/10/2026
11.	02261808	KIT ITEMS FOR UNDER FRAME, FRAME WORK (VB SLEEPER DTC)	17 Sets	07/10/2026
12.	02261787	S & I OF BODY SHELL ITEMS AND PARTITION FRAMES (VB SLEEPER DTC)	37 Sets	07/10/2026
13.	02261933	UNDER FRAME (EMU C HC)	8 Nos	07/10/2026
14.	02261973	SHELL KIT (RAPID METRO C HC)	7 Sets	08/10/2026
15.	02261915	UNDER FRAME (VB Sleeper NDTCT)	18 Nos	08/10/2026
16.	02261650	C/S OF BODY SHELL ITEMS AND PARTITION FRAMES (MEMU/DMC)	122 Sets	08/10/2026
17.	03262353	SECONDARY VERTICAL DAMPER FOR NON AC COACHES WITH FIAT BOGIE	5286 Nos	08/10/2026
18.	02261736A	Shell Kit (MEMU DMC CGPCIL)	6 Sets	09/10/2026
19.	02261739A	Shell Kit (MEMU DMC CGPCIL)	6 Sets	09/10/2026
20.	02260103	C/S of Frame work, Welding parts and Carline (VB Sleeper NDTCT)	25 Sets	12/10/2026
21.	02261958	UNDER FRAME (VB Sleeper MC)	108 Nos	12/10/2026
22.	02261982	COACH SET OF SIDE WALL AND ROOF COMPLETE (KM MC RVNL)	62 Sets	13/10/2026
23.	02261965	S & I OF NOSE CONE (MEMU/DMC)	54 Sets	13/10/2026
24.	02261953	FRONT PART WITH DIRECT MOUNT BIO TOILET TANK (LWSCZ)	89 Nos	14/10/2026
25.	02261941	S & I OF BODY SHELL ITEMS & PARTITION FRAMES (KM MC & TC)	214 Sets	14/10/2026

CORRIGENDUM NO.37
Corrigendum has been issued to the following tender. Please check IREPS website for further details:

Sl.no	Tender No.	Existing value	Modified value
01.	02261677	11/09/2026	21/09/2026
02.	02251848	Item Description Modified and Additions of Documents. Please refer Tender Document for details in IREPS website.	
03.	02261732	Item Description Modified. Addition and Deletion of drawing. Please refer Tender Document for details in IREPS website.	
04.	02261811	15/09/2026	22/09/2026
05.	03261849	Additions and Deletions of Special Condition, and Documents. Please refer Tender Document for details in IREPS website	
	EMD	723810	869890
	Quantity	164010 Kgs	197111 Kgs.
06.	03262239	Item Description Modified and Additions of Documents. Please refer Tender Document for details in IREPS website.	
	EMD	416640	431140
	Quantity	66173 Kgs	93395 Kgs
	Item Description Modified-Please refer Tender Document for details in IREPS website.		
07.	07252641	Item Description Modified-Please refer Tender Document for details in IREPS website.	
08.	07262219	09/09/2026	16/09/2026

SOUTH EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE NO. NIT/07/SEP/95265921/01 Dtd. 07.09.2026
E-TENDER NOTICE NO. NIT/07/SEP/95265528A/02 Dtd. 09.09.2026

For and on behalf of the President of India the Sr. Divisional Materials Manager, South East Central Railway invites E-Tenders for supply of the following items:

Item Sr. No.	Short Description of item	Qty.	Tender Notice No.	Estimated Tender Cost	Due Date	Due Time	EMD
i)	Power Printed Circuit Board.	04 Nos.	952655921	7742857.92	07/10/26	10.30 AM	154860/-
	Pendulum W. Linear Dist. Sensor.	02 Nos.					
ii)	Air Generation & Treatment Unit.	04 Nos.	95265528A	5613930.24	09/10/26	10.30 AM	112280/-

Note:- Above mentioned tender is E-Tender and all tenderers are requested to submit their bids on-line through the IREPS website at <https://www.ireps.gov.in> for more details regarding the above mentioned tenders and other supply tenders please visit IREPS website.

Sr. Divisional Materials Manager/SECR/Nagpur
PAM/44/112

f South East Central Railway X @secrail

AXIS FINANCE LIMITED
(CIN U65921MH1995PLC212675)
Axis House, C-2, Wadala International Centre, Pandurang Butkar
Mang. Work. Mumbai - 400 025

Under Section 13 (2) of the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 ("Act") read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 ("Rules"). Whereas the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Axis Finance Limited (AFL) under the Act and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13 (12) read with Rule 3 of the Rules already issued detailed Demand Notice dated below under Section 13(2) of the Act, calling upon the Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Guarantor(s) (all singularly or together referred to "Obligors")/Legal Heir(s)/Legal Representative(s) listed hereunder, to pay the amount mentioned in the respective Demand Notice, within 60 days from the date of the respective Notice, as per details given below. Copies of the said Notices are served by Registered Post A.D. and are available with the undersigned, and the said Obligor(s)/Legal Heir(s)/Legal Representative(s), may, if they so desire, collect the respective copy from the undersigned on any working day during normal office hours.

In connection with the above, Notice is hereby given, once again, to the said Obligor(s) /Legal Heir(s)/Legal Representative(s) to pay to AFL, within 60 days from the date of the respective Notice/s, the amount indicated herein below against their respective names, together with further interest as detailed below from the respective dates mentioned below in column (d) till the date of payment and / or realization, read with the loan agreement and other documents/writings, if any, executed by the said Obligor(s). As security for due repayment of the loan, the following Secured Asset(s) have been mortgaged to AFL by the said Obligor(s) respectively.

Sr. No.	Loan Account No.	Name of Obligor(s)/ Legal Heir(s)/ Legal Representative(s)	DETAILS OF SECURED ASSET	Total Outstanding Dues (Rs.) as on below date	Date of Demand Notice	Date of NPA
1.	0456MLA00002879	Gitesh Devi & Praveen Kumar	All the Piece and Parcel of the property bearing No.- Property Building Property No. 23, Khasra No. 642 Village Chandrawali, Railway Road Teliwara, Shahdara, New Delhi NORTH EAST DELHI Delhi-110032 admeasuring 50 Sq. yds BOUNDARIES OF THE SUBJECT PROPERTY: North:- House No. 24. South:- House No. 22. East:- Other (Mr. Jain). West:- Gali 10 Ft Wide.	INR. 27,75,737/- (Rupees Twenty Seven Lacs Seventy Five Thousand Seven Hundred Thirty Seven Only) due as on 08th September 2026	09.09.2026	03.09.2026

*with further interest, additional Interest at the rate as more particularly stated in respective Demand Notices dated mentioned above, incidental expenses, costs, charges etc incurred till the date of payment and/or realization. If the said Obligor(s) shall fail to make payment to AFL as aforesaid, then AFL shall proceed against the above Secured Asset(s)/Immovable Property (ies) under Section 13(4) of the said Act and the applicable Rules entirely at the risk of the said Obligor(s)/Legal Heir(s)/Legal Representative(s) as to the costs and consequences.

The said Obligor(s)/Legal Heir(s)/Legal Representative(s) are prohibited under the said Act to transfer the aforesaid Secured Asset(s)/Immovable Property(ies), whether by way of sale, lease or otherwise without the prior written consent of AFL. Any person who contravenes or abets contravention of the provisions of the Act or Rules made thereunder shall be liable for imprisonment and/or penalty as provided under the Act.

Place: Delhi

For Axis Finance Limited
Authorised Officer

BY MICHAEL FRY & T LEWIS

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): You'll be pleased with how much you accomplish today. This is because Mars is boosting the Sun while it is travelling through your House of Employment. Tonight: Check your finances.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Your choices are wide open today. You can work in a productive way. Or you can use this same driving energy to explore sports events, fun activities with kids, the arts, the entertainment world or the hospitality industry. Tonight: Listen and cooperate.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): You have lots of energy to make home improvements today. You also might be more involved with a parent than usual. Meanwhile, relations with co-workers are wonderful. Tonight: Get organised.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Enjoy a short trip. Take care of appointments and errands. Explore your ability to sell, market, talk or teach. Oh yes, you're bright-eyed and bushy-tailed! You're active, confident and keen to express yourself. People will listen to you. Tonight: Socialise.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): You have strong moneymaking ideas, plus the energy to make money. You might do this in a public way or quietly behind the scenes. This is also an excellent day to entertain at home, because relations with family members are loving. Tonight: Relax at home.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): This is a positive day. The Sun is in your sign getting a boost from fiery Mars, while the Moon is lined up with Venus in your House of Communications. You're in the right place, at the right time, saying the right thing to the right person. Tonight: A lively discussion.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Today you might choose to play things low-key and work behind the scenes. Nevertheless, you'll accomplish a lot. With Mercury in your sign, you're keen to express your ideas to others. Meanwhile, shopping is appealing for you. Tonight: Check your belongings.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Today the Moon is lined up with Venus in your sign, which is a winning combination. You're charming with everyone. This is why everyone wants to be in your company. Tonight: You win.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): You make a strong impression on everyone today because the Sun is at the top of your chart casting you in a flattering spotlight, while Mars amplifies this energy, making you virtually shine in the eyes of others. Tonight: Enjoy time alone.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Grab every chance to travel today or do something to expand your horizons. Enjoy learning through film, study or meeting new people. You'll also get a kick out of the stimulation of a new place, anything different. Tonight: Be friendly.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Discussions about shared property, taxes, debt and insurance issues will be lively today. And because both the Moon and Venus are lined up at the top of your chart, not only will you be noticed, it is likely that these discussions will go in your favour. Tonight: You're admired.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): You might attract someone to you today who is forthright and direct. However, it will also encourage fun socialising and physical activity. Tonight: Explore and learn something new.

epaper.indianexpress.com

New Delhi

ASIAN GAMES | AICHI-NAGOYA | SEPTEMBER 19 TO OCTOBER 4

Protagonist, Paraphernalia & Podium: It takes three elements to complete sport. *The Indian Express* presents the stories about the personality, the equipment and the opponent who will bring the slash of strokes and dash of colour to the Asian Games

Coach who thought out of the box

India's only Greco-Roman world medal traces back to one man's unfunded trip to study a rival nation's training methods

Pritish Raj
Sonipat, September 13

KULDEEP SINGH walks around instructing coaches as four Greco-Roman wrestlers battle it out on the two mats laid at the Raipur Akhada in Sonipat, Haryana. One of the medal favourites walking these same mats towards the Asian Games, freestyle wrestler Sujet Kalkal, was shaped here under Kuldeep's eye. Two more of his students, Aman (77kg) and Nitesh Siwach (97kg), will make up half of India's Greco-Roman contingent in Nagoya.

"Coaching is something that came naturally to me," Kuldeep told *The Indian Express*. "I have been wrestling since school days, so there is nothing I know better than this. I don't think there was anything I could have done better than preparing wrestlers."

He started as a freestyle wrestler in 1982, won multiple national medals in the discipline, then switched to Greco-Roman after turning 28. "Once I was done with freestyle, I thought that let's try Greco one," he said. "Once I started it, I enjoyed it a lot. However, there comes a point when one has to take the call. I realized that I can't play further, so I decided to do the next best thing to competing, that is coaching."

He now trains more than 250 wrestlers at the centre, and his own coaching record carries the name of the only Greco-Roman World Championships medalist India has produced, Sandeep Tulsi Yadav, bronze in Budapest in 2013, alongside a run of freestyle internationals. When Sunil Kumar won a Greco-

Roman bronze at the 2023 Asian Games, ending a 13-year wait for the discipline, Kuldeep was in the corner.

His students describe a man still restless about his own craft after four decades in it. "Coach Sahab is like a curious child," said Nitesh Siwach, one of two Kuldeep-trained wrestlers heading to these Asian Games. "He is still constantly finding new innovations or trying to improve how we train constantly. Everytime I play a new opponent, he has all the analysis ready for me."

Japanese education

That restlessness once took him to Japan alone, in the early 2010s, with nothing but a question he couldn't answer at home. "I did it on my own," Kuldeep said. "There was not much technical literature here available. I wanted to understand what Japanese are doing so well. When I went there, the training processes and their routine amazed me. I came back and tried to implement it here. I always try to stay updated on what the world is doing, as that is where the competition lies for my students."

What he brought back built toward Sandeep Tulsi Yadav's bronze, still India's only Greco-Roman medal at the World Championships. Since then, more Asian Championship medalists have followed, but Kuldeep believes the discipline itself hasn't caught up. "Freestyle always had the elite status in the country," he said, "but Greco-Roman was an afterthought, with a lot of wrestlers taking up Greco-Roman later in the career." That late start, he explained, is the root of a



Kuldeep Singh (R) trains his wards at the Raipur Akhada in Sonipat. GAJENDRA YADAV

● FACT FILE

KULDEEP SINGH SEHRAWAT
(Head coach at Raipur Akhada in Sonipat)

- Former national coach of Indian Greco-Roman team
- Coached India's only World

Championships Greco-Roman medalist (Sandeep Tulsi Yadav, 2013 edition)

- Head coach of Services and Navy wrestling team
- Trains 250 wrestlers in Sonipat

- Coach of two medal contenders at Asian Games 2026: Sujet Kalkal (Freestyle 65kg), Nitesh Siwach (Greco-Roman 97kg)

“ON COACHING Coaching is something that came naturally to me. I have been wrestling since school days, so there is nothing I know better than this. I don't think there was anything I could have done better than preparing wrestlers.”

KULDEEP SINGH

“ON HIS JAPAN EXPERIENCE I wanted to understand what Japanese are doing so well. When I went there, the training processes and their routine amazed me. I came back and tried to implement it here. I always try to stay updated on what the world is doing.”

KULDEEP SINGH

Greco-Roman wrestler Nitesh Siwach. UWW

SPORT LAB

Faster, smarter, tinier: How gizmos are powering athletes

Inside swim caps or strapped to shoulder blades, devices are decoding elite athletic responses

Amit Kamath
Mumbai, September 13

A LITTLE button-like gizmo that can be tucked inside a swim cap to track a swimmer's heart rate. A device that looks like a flattened computer mouse that fits snugly between a hockey player's shoulder blades to tell them if they are putting more load on one leg while running in straight lines. A tiny monitor that can be fixed to the back of a swimmer's head that breaks down their stroke rate and the speed of their push off.

As high-performance athletes strive to get faster, higher and stronger, the devices that are aiding them with intricate data points in training and competitions are getting tinier. Smaller than the palm of your hand in fact.

Take, for example, the GPS tracker from Catapult Sport that is used by PV Sindhu, the Indian women's hockey team and even pace bowlers. Despite its compact size — players tuck it into the back of a vest — it comes equipped with an accelerometer, a GPS, and a gyroscope.

Wayne Lombard, the head of athletic performance for the Indian women's hockey team, uses this device to track the



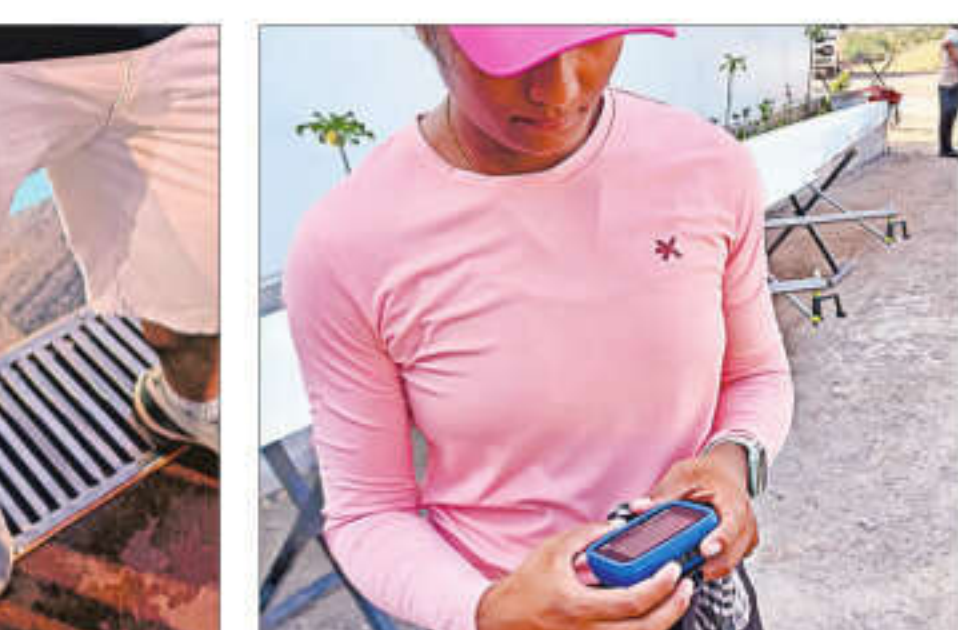
Sandeep Sejwal holds up the Polar Verity Sense device that swimmers use at the Inspire Institute of Sport in Vijaynagar. EXPRESS PHOTO

players' external load (physical exertion data). Then, that data is used to help coaches figure out how hard they should be training so actual matches feel less gruelling than a training session.

"In hockey, we use it for training as well as in matches to understand the distance players cover, the speed they're covering it in, and the repeated sprint efforts by a player. But it also gives us running symmetry data: how much load a player is putting on each leg in every single run that they do," explains Lombard.

This running symmetry data can also help warn that a player is vulnerable to soft tissue injury or is fatigued on one side of the body. "Using this device with Sindhu, we mapped out what her match intensity looks like, and then we mimicked that in training," says Lombard.

Swimmers too have their own tiny gizmos like the Polar Verity Sense and the TritonWear device that help them glide through water effectively.



A rower shows the device that rowers use to calculate stroke rate and distance covered at the IIS. EXPRESS PHOTO

"The Polar Verity Sense device is one of the most used heart rate sensors for swimming. We use it to track the energy zone that swimmers are training in," says Asian Games medal-winning swimmer-turned-coach Sandeep Sejwal, who trains Sajjan Prakash at the Inspire Institute of Sport at Vijayanagar. "It's mostly used to keep swimmers in control and not go over the effort that they are required to do in order to develop their heart rate."

Polar is a circular device, slightly bigger than a blazer button, which can store up to six hundred hours of training data and shows heart rate, pace, and distance in the water.

Sejwal adds that high-performance swimmers also use the TritonWear device that is tucked behind the swimmer's skull. The Swimming Federation of India has given its top swimmers this device. "It tells you your stroke rate, the speed, time between two strokes, speed

of the push off, time you are taking every lap," said Sejwal.

Rowers too have their stroke rate monitors. As Samuel Pullinger, the head of sports science at IIS, explained, "Rowers have these tiny devices that you can clip on both oars, and it provides data of the speed of the boat and stroke rate."

For decathlete Tejaswin Shankar, Lombard has an Eagles lactate monitor (which acts a bit like a blood glucose meter) which he purchased in South Africa. The idea is to check Tejaswin's lactate levels after as many of his events as possible.

"That's to figure out things like how fatigued he could possibly be based on how quickly the lactate comes down. We take it after as many of his events as logistically possible. If it's not coming down quickly enough, it means that we need to do something different in his recovery strategy to make sure he's recovered for the next event," says Lombard.

PATH TO GOLD: MIRABAI CHANU, WEIGHTLIFTING

In her quest for Asian Games medal, collision with Fang Wan-ling imminent

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, September 13

FOR NEARLY three years, Ri Song-gum disappeared.

There was no retirement, no long injury lay-off. The North Korean weightlifter simply vanished from international competition when her country withdrew from global sport during the pandemic.

When Ri returned, she was stronger than ever.

For Mirabai Chanu, chasing the one medal missing from her glittering collection, that is the problem. Ahead of her is Ri Song-gum, the two-time defending champion and world-record holder, chasing a third consecutive Asian Games gold.

Behind, or alongside, her is Fang Wan-ling, a two-time Olympic finalist who can push the total to 200kg. Even then, Mirabai can finally win the medal that has so far eluded her by simply matching or coming close to her personal best.

"The good thing is Mira is injury free, and after studying all opponents, I can safely say we are among medal spots," coach Vijay Sharma says.

The colour of the medal, however, is open for deliberation. Standing between her and a potential gold is a 477" dynamo from North Korea.

Ri's story is one of sustained domination punctuated by disappearance. She won silver at the 2014 Youth Olympics and Asian Games gold in Jakarta four years later. After North Korea's absence from international sport during the Covid-19 pandemic,



Mirabai Chanu

EVENT Weightlifting-49kg

CWG GLASGOW — Gold in 48kg

WORLD CHAMPIONSHIPS — Silver in 48kg

2026 NATIONAL C'SHIPS — Gold in 48kg (205 kg, National record)

she returned at the Hangzhou Asiad in 2023 and retained her title with a 216kg total.

Then came the numbers that established her as one of weightlifting's most formidable figures.

At the 2024 Asian Championships, Ri lifted a world-record 125kg in clean and jerk. At the World Cup in Phuket, she matched Chinese Olympic champion Hou Zhihui's 97kg snatch before finishing with 124kg in clean and jerk for a world-record 221kg total.

The numbers matter par-

ticularly to Mirabai because Ri's greatest weapon is the lift that has defined the Indian's career.

Mirabai has built her reputation around the clean and jerk. Ri has taken it further.

Their meeting at last year's World Championships showed the scale of the challenge. Ri lifted 91kg in snatch and 122kg in clean and jerk for a 213kg total. Mirabai finished with silver after lifting 84kg and 115kg for 199kg.

Fourth-time lucky

A 14kg gap is substantial in the 49kg category. Ri is therefore the clear favourite in Nagoya. Yet, Mirabai's Asian Games contest is not solely about catching her. With China absent at 49kg and Thailand's World Championship silver medalist Thanayathon Sukchareon not competing — Suthasini Kaeosingkhon will compete instead — Mirabai needs to ensure she stays ahead of Fang Wan-ling.

deeper shortage.

"One of the biggest problems is the lack of technical wrestlers. As wrestlers start late they are not able to become technical. The scoring areas are less in Greco, and that is why more explosive power is needed."

Student of the game

Two of his students carry that fight into Nagoya. Sujet, the reigning Asian and U23 World champion in freestyle's 65kg, has trained under Kuldeep alongside his own father, Dayanand Kalkal. "Coach Sahab is a thinking coach," Sujet said. "I am privileged to have my father and Kuldeep sir as the coaches. My endurance and power improved, and once it started improving, I started doing well at the senior level."

Nitesh, silver medalist at the 2026 Asian Championships in Greco-Roman's 97kg, has waited four years for this moment. "Kuldeep sir has been on my side throughout that," he said. "Nobody has done well at the Asian Games in my weight category, but coach Sahab has been constantly motivating me apart from the usual training we have."

Kuldeep doesn't separate his own learning from theirs. "If I have to train students, I have to be a student of the game," he said. "The sport is evolving at a rapid pace and wrestling at world level is very competitive. The sport has moved leaps and bounds from what it was a decade back, and if we don't learn everyday, we will fall behind. I want to be ready to answer all the questions my students have, as they are also becoming smart. If a coach can't explain to his students why they are doing something, there is no point being a coach."

Wrestling begins on September 30 at the Inae Sports Center in Nagoya.

Kuldeep won't be on the mat. He'll be exactly where he's been for four decades, watching, still looking for the thing he doesn't yet know.

Rybakina pips Sabalenka to lift maiden US Open

Bhuvan Gupta
New Delhi, September 13

WHEN ELENA Rybakina won Wimbledon, she raised her right arm in muted celebration. "Maybe one day you will see (a) huge reaction from me," she said then. Four years have passed. She has won two Grand Slams in a season and become world No. 1. The celebration has remained muted.

An ice-cool Rybakina raised both arms and allowed herself a tiny smile on Sunday. She had just beaten two-time defending champion Aryna Sabalenka 6-4, 5-7, 6-2 in the US Open final, a tenth career win over a world No. 1, sixth of those against Sabalenka alone. And to think she was not even sure of being able to play the tournament.

An achilles injury in Cincinnati had forced her off the court for a week. She began her Flushing Meadows campaign tentatively, three days after that. Rybakina's performance through the next 10 days was a testament to her fortitude and phlegmatic manner.

In sharp contrast stood Sabalenka. The top seed, impressive in all senses of the word, fought against her own emotions. She had seemed invincible in her semifinal; opponent Jessica Pegula remarked, "I don't really think there was much I could have done today." The same Sabalenka was shrieking in despair two days later, unhappy with herself and the world.

The cause was Rybakina's hard-hitting brilliance in the first set. The Belarusian is not used to playing fetch at the baseline, she is generally the one subjecting others to that treatment. Forced to defend and retrieve left-right-centre, Sabalenka wilted.

This, even though Rybakina's serve, her prime weapon, was out of order. The Kazakh landed just eight of her 30 first serves in the opening set. Yet she held sway, conducting traffic from the back of the court.

Sabalenka served her way out of trouble in Game 3, saving three breakpoints. She could not repeat it. A double fault broke her serve in the fifth game, her internal disarray made visible. She smashed a ball into the stands for a code violation, and the frustration only deepened when she was left harried on set point. It worked, for a while. She returned with her groundstrokes deep and powerful again, the errors fewer.

Meanwhile, Rybakina's serve firmed up but her forehand fell apart in Set 2. She leaned on her down-the-line backhand to bail her out, repeatedly. Sabalenka had two break points, set points both, in Game 10. She could not take either. Another chance came at 6-5. Rybakina fluffed a forehand at deuce and netted her first serve at advantage. Sabalenka pounced on the second and was third-time lucky.

The match was level, and a thrilling decider looked ready to arrive. Rybakina snuffed it out immediately, levelling up her forehand returns in the third game of the final set. Sabalenka's serve buckled under the pressure, errors arriving in her pursuit of perfection. Rybakina broke again in the seventh game, moved within touching distance of the title, and sealed it with an ace, her twelfth of the match.

WOMEN'S ASIA CUP FINAL

Shafali, Mandhana make it open & shut case for India

A 129-run stand for opening wicket ensures Harman & Co make light work of Sri Lanka

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, September 13

WHEN SMRITI Mandhana was offered a hint of width by Mithali Ayodhya off the first ball of the Women's Asia Cup final, she opened the face and guided it past point for four. Little did Sri Lanka know it was the start of a very long evening.

Sri Lanka's best chance of putting India under pressure was to dismiss the in-form opening duo of Mandhana and Shafali Verma early. When they failed to do so, the defending champions were left chasing leather as India's openers put together a 129-run stand before Sree Charani ripped through Sri Lanka's chase to complete a 72-run victory in Dubai on Sunday and seal India's record-extending eighth Asia Cup title.

It was Shafali who initially set the pace. She slog-swept Kavisha Dilhari for her first boundary before collecting two more fours off Ayodhya in the third over. The real acceleration came when Sri Lanka captain Chamari Athapaththu brought herself on in the fifth. Shafali greeted her with a boundary through mid-wicket before clearing the ropes twice in the same over. She took 20 runs from the seven balls she faced from the Sri Lanka captain.

By the end of the powerplay, India had raced to 57/0. Shafali then went after Chamudi Praboda, one of Sri Lanka's most economical bowlers. Two fours in three balls took her into the forties before she brought up her fifty off 24 deliveries — the fastest fifty in Women's T20 Asia Cup history.

While Shafali had done most of the early damage, Mandhana was content to play second fiddle. At the end of



Shafali Verma was India's highest run-getter in the final, scoring 68 off 39 against Sri Lanka. CREIMAS

eight overs, she was 24 off 23 balls. But with Shafali having already put Sri Lanka under pressure, the left-hander began to accelerate.

Mandhana used her feet against Praboda and lofted her over long-on before taking on Athapaththu in the following over, getting to the pitch of the ball and lifting her over extra cover. Another six followed before a cut took her to a 35-ball fifty. The change of gears meant Sri Lanka were no longer dealing with one aggressor. By the time the partnership reached 100 in the 11th over, both openers were finding the boundary and Sri Lanka were struggling to slow them down.

Praboda eventually provided the breakthrough in the 13th over when Shafali, found Athapaththu to depart for 68 off 39 balls, with nine fours and two sixes.

Mandhana followed soon afterwards for 59 off 39 thanks to a bad call from Harmanpreet Kaur. At 132/2, India had the platform for a towering finish. Sri Lanka, however, clawed back well. Richa Ghosh, promoted to No.4, struggled for

timing despite briefly breaking free with a six and a four off successive Ayodhya deliveries. She was dismissed for 17 off 13 when she toe-ended Athapaththu to cover.

Harmanpreet, promoted to No.3 after an unconvincing knock in the semifinal against Bangladesh, could not provide the required acceleration either, falling for 14 to Ayodhya.

India had not fully cashed in on their opening stand, but G Kamalini supplied the final push. Drafted into the XI for Pratika Rawal and walking in at No.7 in the final over, she made an unbeaten 15 off five balls. Her six over wide long-on from the final delivery carried India to 183/5.

Charani shines

Just over a year since making her debut, Sree Charani showed she has established herself as one of the mainstays of the attack. On the night, the left-arm spinner delivered again, finishing with 4/20.

Charani first removed Harshitha Samarawickrama, whose unbeaten 69 had taken Sri Lanka past India in the 2024

final, with a sharp return catch. She then struck twice in three balls in the 16th over, dismissing Kavisha Dilhari and Nilakshika Silva, before completing a wicket-maiden final over by having Sugandika Kumari caught at deep square-leg.

Deepti Sharma also did her bit. Having entered the final as the tournament's joint-highest wicket-taker with 11, she outfoxed Athapaththu, having her stumped for 36, before bowling Vishmi Gunaratne three balls later. She returned to claim the final wicket and finish with 3/19.

The rout had been set up by India's pacers. Nandani Sharma and Kranti Gaud denied Sri Lanka early momentum, with Athapaththu taking eight balls to get off the mark and the required rate climbing from the outset. From there, India never allowed Sri Lanka back into the contest.

BRIEF SCORES: India 183/5 in 20 overs (Shafali Verma 68, Smriti Mandhana 59) beat Sri Lanka 111 all out in 20 overs (Chamari Athapaththu 36; Sree Charani 4/20, Deepti Sharma 3/19) by 72 runs.

Women's team refuse Asia trophy from Naqvi, repeat men's stance

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, September 13

LESS THAN a year after India's men's team refused to accept the Asia Cup trophy from Asian Cricket Council president Mohsin Naqvi in Dubai, the women's team followed suit at the same venue on Sunday. After beating Sri Lanka by 72 runs to win a record-extending eighth Women's Asia Cup title, Harmanpreet Kaur and her teammates refused to receive the trophy from Naqvi during the post-match presentation.

There was also a lengthy wait before the presentation began, with around 40 minutes passing between the fall of Sri Lanka's final wicket and the start of the ceremony.

The match officials were first presented with their mementos before Sri Lanka captain Chamari Athapaththu and her teammates and coaching staff came forward one by one to receive their runners-up medals. Athapaththu then collected the runners-up cheque from Naqvi, who was present in his capacity as ACC president, before speaking to the broadcaster.

The broadcast ended following Athapaththu's interview, without showing India's players receiving their winners' medals or the Asia Cup trophy.

To collect or not

According to a source, the women's team had been told not to collect the trophy from Naqvi. "It was decided that if India wins the final and Naqvi was to present the trophy, the team would not accept it from him," the source said.

The incident brought back memories of the men's Asia Cup final at the same venue last September, when India's refusal to receive the trophy from Naqvi led to a presentation ceremony that stretched for more than an hour after the match had ended.

India beat Pakistan by five wickets in the men's Asia Cup final in Dubai last September, with Tilak Varma finishing with an unbeaten 69. The drama, however, continued



Harmanpreet Kaur & Co decided to not collect the Asia Cup trophy from Mohsin Naqvi, mirroring the stance of the men's team. CREIMAS

The broadcast ended following Athapaththu's interview, without showing India's players receiving their winners' medals or the Asia Cup trophy.

for more than an hour after the winning runs were hit.

India refused to accept the Asia Cup trophy from Naqvi, who is also Pakistan's Interior Minister and chairman of the Pakistan Cricket Board. The tournament was played against the backdrop of heightened tensions between the countries following the Pahalagam terror attack and the military conflict in May.

India had also declined to shake hands with Pakistan's players during their three meetings in the tournament.

The presentation was delayed by more than an hour as an impasse developed over who would hand India the trophy. The Indian team made it clear that they would not receive it from Naqvi. Reports at the time said India were willing to accept the trophy from Emirates Cricket Board vice-chairman Khalid Al Zarooni, but Naqvi insisted on presenting it as ACC president.

Individual awards were still handed out. Kuldeep Yadav, Abhishek Sharma and Tilak received their awards

from other dignitaries while Naqvi was present on stage. Pakistan captain Salman Agha collected the runners-up cheque before presenter Simon Doull announced that he had been informed by the ACC that India would not be collecting their team awards.

The ceremony then ended without the champions receiving either the trophy or their winners' medals. An official removed the trophy from the presentation area, leaving India to celebrate without it. Suryakumar and his teammates responded by mimicking a trophy lift during their celebrations. Suryakumar later said the decision not to accept the trophy from Naqvi had been taken by the players themselves and that nobody had instructed them to do so. He also expressed disappointment that the champions had been left without the silverware they had won.

The BCCI backed the team's position. Secretary Devajit Saikia said India had decided not to receive the trophy from Naqvi because of his position as a senior Pakistani political leader, but argued that this did not entitle the ACC president to withhold the trophy and medals. The board subsequently said it would raise the matter at the ICC.

The dispute continued after the tournament. Naqvi maintained that India could collect the trophy from him, while reports in October said the silverware remained at the ACC headquarters in Dubai.

WITH INPUTS FROM DEVENDRA PANDEY.

Abhishek's blitzkrieg rounds off clinical 7-wicket win over Afghanistan

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, September 13

IN THE immediate aftermath of the 2026 T20 World Cup, India found themselves grappling with problems rarely associated with it. That the champions of the format — a status underlined by both the trophy and their position atop the ICC rankings — went seven consecutive games without a win, before the redemption in Zimbabwe, was surprising enough. Perhaps more surprising still was that spin, had become India's Achilles' heel.

At the World Cup, few had found answers to Varun Chakravarthy and Axar Patel. On home soil, the leggie and left-arm orthodox spinners shared 25 wickets between them at 8.8 and 19.68. In stark contrast, their combined numbers dropped to

12 wickets at 10.58 and 44.09 in the following five months. It will have come as a relief, then, that the pair looked back to their best on their return to home conditions, technicalities aside, as India beat Afghanistan by seven wickets in the first of a three-match T20I series on Sunday at the Arun Jaitley Stadium.

Prior to the game, the national song, Vande Mataram was played before the national anthem. Once done, the national treasure, Jasprit Bumrah announced his return. And all it took him was three attempts, and two legal deliveries. Rahmanullah Gurbaz, undone by the bounce, fell for his 11th T20I duck. Even so, with the next couple of overs yielding 22 runs, it briefly looked as though Afghanistan might stake their claim as Asia's second-best side.

The procession of wickets



Abhishek Sharma (L) and Ishan Kishan led the scoring for India with 82 off 32 and 42 off 33 respectively in a comfortable win. PRAVEEN KHANA

began in the fourth over — when Axar was introduced, although the first wicket stemmed not from his spin, but a mix-up between Ibrahim Zadran and Sediqullah Atal. It cost the Afghan captain his wicket, while Atal de-



parted five deliveries later.

At 39/3 after five overs, Afghanistan could have used a few loose deliveries to settle into. Instead, they were met with a sustained spell of precise, unrelenting spin. The next four overs

brought just 11 runs and two more wickets — Axar accounting for Gulbadin Naib, Varun for Darwish Rasooli.

By then, Afghanistan were playing for pride, and found some in an 83-run sixth-wicket stand between Mohammad Nabi and Azmatullah Omarzai. In particular, the latter impressed with his unbeaten 44-ball 64, courtesy of which Afghanistan posted a total of 157.

The all-rounder struck four fours and as many sixes, but neither of those came against Varun. Axar did concede a couple of wickets, but he also should have had Omarzai's wicket to his name, if not for Ishan Kishan dropping a regulation catch. Between them, the two spinners returned 43/2 from eight overs at an economy of 5.37. Arshdeep Singh was convincing, finishing with 4-0-19-3.

The redemption arc, however, did not come as a two-man act, but in a tripartite. Abhishek Sharma arrived under scrutiny over his form, having managed just 40 runs across his previous six innings.

Abhishek show

Today, Abhishek showed up. India had surprisingly taken Vaibhav Sooryavanshi off the firing line after performances against Zimbabwe. His replacement, Sanju Samson, did little to quiet the debate, falling for 10 off eight balls.

Yet the chase never once looked anything but comfortable, with India cruising on autopilot courtesy of Abhishek, who struck 82 off 32 balls — 70 of those runs coming in boundaries alone. For the tango, though, it took two — the supporting act being played by

Ishan Kishan. Fresh off a Duleep Trophy victory as East Zone's captain, Ishan Kishan can do no wrong in this phase of career, and there was hardly anything wrong about his 33-ball 42 anchor-job today.

Having lost six of their 10 T20I fixtures since the T20 World Cup, and their only victories coming against Zimbabwe, India could scarcely have asked for a more emphatic performance. If there is a note of caution, it is the fifth-bowler question: Nitish Kumar Reddy, Abhishek Sharma and Shivam Dube leaked 59 runs in four overs.

BRIEF SCORES: Afghanistan 156/8 in 20 overs (Azmatullah Omarzai 64 n.o.; Arshdeep Singh 3/19) lost to India 157/3 in 13.4 overs (Abhishek Sharma 82; Mohammad Nabi 2/28) by 7 wickets.

● INTERACTIVE EXPERIENCE

Headphones, 'Play Along', Festival Zone: Chess's bid to cut ice with spectators

Mayank Chaudhary
Bengaluru, September 13

CHESS HAS been considered a difficult sport to watch from the stands. But the Global Chess League (GCL) is finding innovative ways to bring the board closer to the audience. Noise-cancelling headphones with live commentary, interactive fan engagement through the Play Along, a dedicated Festival Arena, and packed crowds: the fourth edition in Bengaluru is pulling out all the stops to create a genuinely immersive experience for the fans.

Watching a live chess game has its own charm, but the gap in understanding between a casual fan and a titled player is vast. The Esports World Cup in Paris tried something similar last month, but with a different approach. Competitors there wore wired earphones and noise-cancelling headphones

so they couldn't hear the live commentary, while the audience followed the game through live screens and commentary. The GCL has taken that idea and flipped it on its head. Here, the headphones aren't for the players. They're for the fans.

Pooja Sukhija was a little apprehensive when she walked into the hotel, the venue for the GCL with her 11-year-old son, Ahaan. She was unfamiliar with chess and had come to see her childhood hero, Viswanathan Anand. While Ahaan, enthusiastic about the sport, started playing chess with others in the festival zone, she had little else to do. But as soon as she walked inside, a small surprise awaited them. It was a compact controller connected to noise-cancelling headphones, and it was about to be a game-changer for many. "It really helped, and it kept

building the engagement. It was easy for us to navigate through the six boards because the commentators kept us updated about everything that was going around," she said.

After hosting the Global Chess League in Dubai and London for its first two seasons, the league shifted base to India. The third edition was held in Mumbai, and the ongoing fourth season is underway in Bengaluru. The organisers, who struggled to draw crowds in Mumbai, have actively worked to tap into Bengaluru's passionate chess community.

The response has been overwhelming, with packed stands throughout the event.

The headphones proved effective even for those who understand chess at a deeper level. Udaya Kumar, a 69-year-old retired government officer who runs a chess academy in Bengaluru, explained: "I liked



Fans were able to hear commentary for speed chess games while watching the match from the stands. GRAND CHESS LEAGUE

this innovation very much. It was really thrilling because with live engines and commentary, I was able to understand and get the true feel of speed chess. I was able to enjoy every move. It was like watching a thriller movie."

GCL is a team event where teams face off in a round, meaning six games are played

simultaneously. This is where live commentary truly helps. Watching live chess can sometimes feel disconnected. Apart from the usual predict-your-team and fantasy formats, GCL introduced "Play Along," an innovative way to hold viewers' attention while offering them something in return.

In Play Along mode in the

GCL mobile app, fans can choose any one of their favourite players. One can become a Magnus Carlsen, a Viswanathan Anand, or an Arjun Erigaisi. While the players compete in real time, fans get a small window to make their move and lock it in, to see if they and their favourite GMs think alike. From merchandise to flags, banners, and posters, the rewards for accumulating points with every correct guess are equally appealing.

The venue features a dedicated fan area called the Festival Arena, a space catering to audiences of all ages. There is something for everyone here: an enclosed glass box where commentators sit, chessboards for casual games, and counters for each team, offering merchandise, books, posters, and photographs. In collaboration with Bangalore Chess Club, Circle Chess, and Chess Klub, tour-

naments are being held throughout the GCL. From a women's-only blitz event to a senior citizens' tournament, the Festival Arena has something to offer everyone.

Lokesh Natoo, a corporate professional by day and chess influencer by night, explains the vibe. "From September 5 to 13, every day there is a different tournament, each catering to a different audience. The second half of the day is a mix of everything. There are masterclasses from Grandmasters, simul events, quizzes, puzzles, ticket giveaways, and meet-and-greet sessions with fans.

"I would sum it up like this: GCL is a 3:30 to 9 PM event, but the fan zone runs from 12 to 9:30," says Natoo, who is also the Head of Chess Activations and Community for Tech Mahindra at GCL.

(The writer is in Bengaluru at the invitation of GCL)

Nepo's win over Carlsen gives Ganges GCL title

FOR TWO-time World Championship challenger Ian Nepomniachtchi, the barrier has always been Magnus Carlsen. The five-time World Champion denied him the world title in Dubai in 2021. Then came the famous, or rather infamous, shared World Blitz title in 2024, after Nepomniachtchi once again failed to get past the Norwegian wall.

On Sunday, Nepomniachtchi finally had his moment, defeating Carlsen in front of a packed, passionate Bengaluru crowd to lead Ganges Grandmasters to the 2026 Global Chess League title. **ENS**

INDIAN ATHLETICS SERIES FINAL

Inside Nirbhay’s coach-less journey to national record

Hammer thrower, who watches *YouTube* videos to plan his training, came up with an effort of 71.02m

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, September 13

AWAY FROM the cheers and clapping at the Indian Athletics Series Final on the main track of JLN Stadium, 21-year-old Nirbhay Choudhary silently bettered the national record in men’s hammer throw with a mark of 71.02m.

With his throw, he erased the previous national record of 70.73m held by Neeraj Kumar from 2016.

The Asian Games-bound Damneet Singh and Praveen Kumar were also competing but it was the self-taught thrower from Delhi who became the first Indian to cross 71m legally.

Earlier, former India hammer thrower Kamalpreet Singh had recorded 72.86m in the USA but it was never ratified due to lack of dope control.

“There is so much going on in my mind right now. I’m probably unable to comprehend what happened. But that’s about it, I am the national record holder,” Nirbhay said.

DIY approach

Nirbhay trains without a coach and plans his training program by looking at *YouTube* videos. Isolation is nothing new for him.

After his father Rakesh Choudhary — a retired Indian Air Force officer and a former hammer thrower — mentored him in his formative years, Nirbhay has been training on his own at the JLN Stadium with the help of hammer throw



Nirbhay Choudhary erased the previous mark of 70.73m. AFI

literature available online and occasional lessons on Instagram from European coaches.

“Everything is available online now. All the literature, diet plans, and exercises are there. For the past two years, I have been following that and making my plans accordingly,” Nirbhay told *The Indian Express*. “I always wanted to train under a coach who has enormous international experience and that is why I was training myself to produce a result which helps in getting a top-level coach,” he added.

Nirbhay is a big fan of two-time world champion and 1988 Seoul Olympic gold medallist Sergey Litvinov. The late Russian athlete is considered one of the greatest hammer throwers. “I watch all the world-class throwers but the videos of Sergey Litvinov have been my favourites. A lot of my early techniques come from his videos,” said Nirbhay.

He also watched videos of

Litvinov’s son, Sergey Litvinov Junior, who is a coach and a former thrower with efforts over 80m. After watching the videos, Nirbhay reached out to Litvinov Jr and received some valuable tips from him.

“Litvinov Jr runs an academy in Germany. I reached out to him and he replied in Russian. I got it translated. He advised me to work with a light hammer and focus on pelvic muscle exercises. These things really helped me,” said Nirbhay. “I wanted to go to Germany to train with him but couldn’t due to financial constraints.”

Battle with dengue

After winning a junior-level medal, Nirbhay gave two years to himself where he was recovering from dengue and only practising, before playing his first senior national event this year at Indian Athletics Series 14 in Panchkula.

“I was suffering from dengue last year on the same

“I was manifesting for a very long time. Since the time I was in bed battling dengue, I wanted this. I had all the reasons to believe that it would come.”

NIRBHAY CHOUDHARY,
ON BREAKING NATIONAL RECORD.

date. 10th September, 2025. I was in bed and my family asked me to reconsider my future in the game but my mother supported me and Lalit Bhanot sir (South Asian Athletics Federation president) asked me to hold my fort,” said Nirbhay.

On the wall adjoining the bed where Nirbhay recovered from dengue, he wrote “70+ National record on 10 September” before coming for the Indian Athletics Series Final.

Similarly, on September 9 he promised a national record as a birthday gift to her sister.

“I was manifesting for a very long time. Since the time I was in bed battling dengue, I wanted this. I had all the reasons to believe that it would come. I was constantly crossing 65m in training and with a light hammer (5 kg), I was throwing 80m and above,” explained Nirbhay.

While he missed the Asian Games cut, Nirbhay believes he has bigger throws inside him.

“I want to obliterate this national record six or seven more times. I hope after this throw, I get more international exposure and that will bring the best out of me. I don’t regret missing the Asian Games but I am sure that bigger throws and competitions are there for me,” he said.

With just one more national competition left this year, Nirbhay has got a good base to start the 2027 season where World Championships and Olympics qualification will start.

Patri follows up U15 title with Asian U17 crown ahead of Jr Worlds trial

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, September 13

FOUR TOURNAMENTS, including three senior meets on the bounce. Three finals, including an U17 Asian Championship title. Bengaluru whiz Tanvi Patri, is making expected progress and followed up her U15 Asian title with an U17 one, while still only 15. Both came at Chengdu, China.

What made it a double gain for India was her opponent in the 15-10, 11-15, 15-12 win, academy-mate from Bengaluru, Shaina Manimuthu, also aged 15. Both are headed to Guwahati on Monday where they will be at the trials for the Junior World Championships - with one spot out of three up for grabs, if Tanvi Sharma finds automatic qualification for the October 5 starting event at Egypt, chasing the world juniors crown.

For Patri though, the Sunday finish was commendable. “She had played 4 good weeks of badminton, including the title Indonesia International Challenge,” reprised coach Sagar Chopda. Since her U15 Asian title, a couple of realizations had hit her team -- coaches at Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru led by Vimal Kumar and her father, a software engineer employee at the IT city, simultaneously devoted to her career.

Patri had been prone to injuries over the last two years, and had to be pulled back from the grind of the circuit for close to eight weeks. “We realised we can’t keep pushing her,” Chopda says of the prodigy, while adding, “It’s why these 4 weeks were good news, aside from the title.”

While Singapore IC played slow - conditions where stroke-makers with game smarts and variations tend to struggle - Indonesia saw her picking her first senior title at Pontianak, where fast shuttles were to her liking, and she defeated the stronger Rachel Chan. “She’s beating players 2-3 years older than her, and yesterday she



Tanvi Patri (left top) and Shaina Manimuthu (right top) stood on the girls' U17 singles podium, while Aaditya Singh Negi (left) and Tanmay Verma bagged the boys' U15 doubles bronze medal. BAI

showed good skill to come back from 6-10 down against the Chinese (Yu Ying Gui). You can’t discount her, when she’s down,” Chopda explains.

The plan ahead sounds simple, but is terribly important. “Stay injury-free and get stronger,” Chopda says. Her wins, including against the Korean at Indonesia, have broader contours of sharp downward strokes, mixing drops and half-smashes, though the attack is still a work in progress, understandably due to a strength deficit. Ying Gui though, caught Patri on her forehand corner - which was a major learning in just how much work needs doing.

A large part of her early badminton philosophy was shaped by Chinese coaches when the Balasore, Odisha-born shuttler trained at Kunshan, where her father worked for an IT major. The backhands at the net can be traced back to those fundamentals, even as she trained in roller skating to help her with balance. Significantly, Chinese coaches at Kunshan would smash at her body, which greatly sorted out her defense. With Vimal and Sagar, the attack is getting honed, even as

she continues to be a fan of Viktor Axelsen.

Her father Rabinarayan actually trained in badminton so he could coach her. She has also been consciously kept away from electronics (No music on headphones) because it could mess with her equanimity, by the badminton-mad father.

Shaina Manimuthu, on the other hand, impressed coaches with her fitness parameters - strength, power and endurance. The daughter of a CRPF soldier, with a sturdy fitness base, she hits hard smashes and shows immense grit.

“Her smashes are hit hard and she has good strength, maybe the best in her age-group. Her game is looking impressive, and she could spring a surprise in coming years though we haven’t started her out on international events,” Chopda says. The power was visible in her semis against the Japanese, Anon Okimoto.

With two U15s also throwing their hats into the ring, the Guwahati trials could get interesting for the solitary spot, with Tanvi Sr (who’s only 18 later this year), also in contention and Rajasthan’s U19 national champ Parul Choudhary in the

mix as well.

Isharani loses in final

At the Vietnam Open Super 100, Isharani Baruah lost 21-8, 21-15 to Thai breakthrough star, Sarunrak Vitidsarn. “Isha did well to get to the finals. She was very aggressive in her quarters and semis which is an improvement in her game. But we will sit and chat with her on what went wrong in the finals,” Chopda said.

Sarunrak, the Thai sensation, and younger sister of Men’s singles former World champ, Kunlavut, is extremely deceptive - in the Ratchanok realms, and at 20 has begun to make her way up, inflicting defeats this week on both Tanvi Sharma, Mansi Singh and Isharani. Her clears from the back are impressive. However, the incremental improvement for the Assamese crazy-ball jump-smasher has been in nurturing her attack.

“She tended to keep retrieving, waiting for opponent mistakes. When on attack, she used to be impatient. But this week she was good and in that attacking zone. Finals, of course, could’ve done much better, Chopda explained.

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